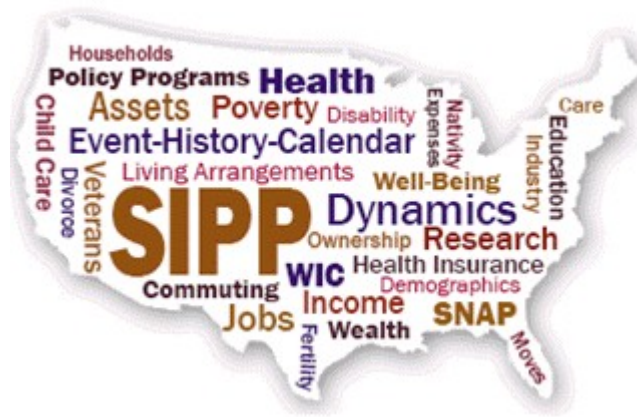


2025 Survey of Income and Program Participation Users' Guide



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Document History

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August 2026	Updated the number of eligible Wave 1 households in Table 1-2, <i>Summary of the 1984 to 2024 SIPP Panels</i> .

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1 Introduction to the Survey of Income and Program Participation

This guide is intended as a comprehensive reference for using 2025 Survey of Income and Program Participation (2025 SIPP¹) microdata. For information on previous years of SIPP data, please see the SIPP Users' Guide webpage at <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/guidance/users-guide.html>.

Additional information about the survey is available on the SIPP website at <www.census.gov/sipp>.

Please contact the SIPP team at census.sipp@census.gov with any questions you have about the survey or its data.

1.1 SIPP's Mission

While SIPP has evolved over the years, its purpose remains the same: SIPP provides high-quality data related to income, labor force participation, social program participation and eligibility, and general demographic characteristics. SIPP data help to assess the effectiveness of existing federal, state, and local programs. SIPP also forecasts future government program costs and coverage and provides improved statistics on income distribution and measures of economic well-being in the United States. The main objective of the SIPP has been, and continues to be, to provide accurate and comprehensive information about the income and program participation of individuals and households in the United States. The survey's mission is to provide a nationally representative sample for evaluating: 1) annual and sub-annual income dynamics; 2) movements into and out of government transfer programs; 3) family and social context of individuals and households; and 4) interactions among these areas.

1.2 A Brief History of SIPP

Until the advent of SIPP, the main source of data on income and program participation was the Current Population Survey's (CPS) March Income Supplement. The CPS, however, had some limitations in measuring income, particularly in capturing changes in household composition throughout the year and in measuring periods of program participation. Additionally, the CPS did not collect data on assets and liabilities, which are crucial to fully assessing a household's economic status and eligibility for program benefits. The CPS was also designed to be a cross-sectional survey, meaning it collects data at a single point in time, rather than over a period.

¹ SIPP data are collected as yearly overlapping panels with new panels beginning each year. 2025 SIPP data include Wave 2 of the 2022 Panel, Wave 3 of the 2023 Panel, and Wave 4 of the 2024 Panel, but is collectively referred to as "2025 SIPP."

By the 1970s, the increasing size of government programs and their interactions with the labor market led to a need for longitudinal data. To address this need, the Department of Health, Education, and Welfare (HEW) initiated the Income Survey Development Program (ISDP) in the late 1970s. In developing ISDP content and procedures, HEW focused on questionnaire length, length of reference period, and linkage of survey data to program records. Much of the work centered around four experimental field tests that were conducted in collaboration with the Census Bureau. These tests examined different concepts, procedures, questionnaires, and recall periods.

Creation of SIPP (1984)

Based on experience obtained in the ISDP, planning began for implementation of the Survey of Income and Program Participation (SIPP). The primary goals in designing SIPP were to improve reporting of income and other program-related data, allowing the analysis of changes over time at a micro-level. The design also needed to allow for flexible data collection, where certain information could be collected more frequently than others. These goals were met principally by using a survey design in which the same people are interviewed more than once. Persons at households selected for a sample panel were interviewed about their income and other topics once every 4 months for approximately 2 1/2 years.

The first SIPP interviews were conducted in October of 1983, with a sample of over 20,000 households. In each interview, survey participants were asked to provide information covering the 4 months since the previous interview. SIPP's design called for a nationally representative sample of individuals 15 years of age and older in civilian, non-institutionalized households. These individuals, along with others who subsequently lived with them, were interviewed once every 4 months over a 32-month period.

The 1996 Redesign

In 1990, the Census Bureau asked the Committee on National Statistics (CNSTAT) at the National Research Council to conduct a comprehensive review of SIPP. The resulting report, *The Future of the Survey of Income and Program Participation* (Citro and Kalton, 1993), summarized the first nine years of the survey and provided recommendations for its future. Some of those recommendations were implemented in what is known as the 1996 redesign.

A primary goal of the 1996 redesign was to improve the quality of longitudinal estimates, improving the ability to provide policymakers with reliable data over time. Specific changes to the survey included:

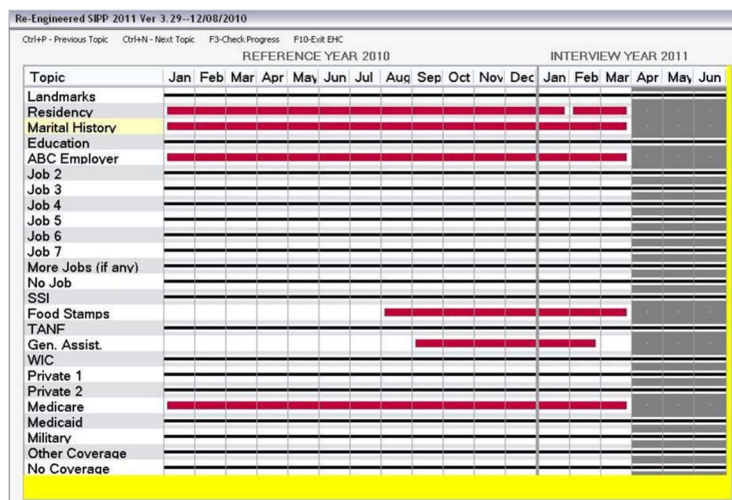
- Expanding the sample size to ensure greater representation.
- Extending the interview period from 32 to 48 months (4 years) to improve the ability to track changes over time.
- Introducing computer-assisted interviewing (CAI), which allows for automatic consistency checks of reported data during the interview, reducing the need for post-collection edits and imputation, and thus maintaining higher longitudinal consistency.
- Oversampling households from areas with high poverty concentrations to improve the accuracy of estimates for vulnerable populations.

Due to delays caused by the 1995 and 1995-1996 federal government shutdowns and related furloughs, the first interviews of the redesigned SIPP began in April 1996, rather than the originally scheduled date of February 1996. Later that year, Congress passed the Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity Reconciliation Act (PRWORA). That law significantly altered the nature of public transfer programs, shifting greater responsibility to state governments, establishing new eligibility rules for a number of programs, and setting limits on who could receive benefits. The existing welfare program, Aid to Families with Dependent Children (AFDC), was replaced by the Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) program. These legislative changes came after interviewing for the 1996 Panel had already begun using a questionnaire designed for the array of transfer programs that existed before PRWORA was enacted. To accommodate program changes brought about by PRWORA, the Census Bureau began adapting transfer-program questions to reflect the current situation.

The 2014 Redesign (Re-engineered SIPP)

In 2006, the U.S. Census Bureau began its second major redesign of the SIPP, known as Re-engineered SIPP (or Re-SIPP). The catalyst for this redesign was SIPP's imminent cancellation. Though SIPP was saved by support from various stakeholders, major changes were deemed necessary. The primary goals of the redesign were to reduce costs, minimize respondent burden, and to improve data quality and timeliness. To achieve these goals, the survey instrument was completely overhauled, and a new instrument, 'SIPP-EHC', was introduced. A key change was the shift in the survey reference period from four month to one year. This change was designed to improve the survey's longitudinal tracking capabilities and provide more accurate data on income and program participation. The redesigned instrument introduced an Event History Calendar (EHC), which is intended to aid respondents in recalling events accurately over the longer reference period. The EHC provides increased data quality and inter-topic consistency for information reported by survey participants. [Figure 1-1](#) shows an early design of this interactive calendar. The first interviews with this new instrument were conducted in February 2014. The 2025 SIPP data, which are the focus of this guide, are based on the 2014 redesign.

FIGURE 1-1. EARLY DESIGN OF THE SIPP EVENT HISTORY CALENDAR (EHC)



1.3 Uses of SIPP

SIPP data are used to address questions such as:

- How have changes in program eligibility rules or benefit levels affected recipients?
- How have changes in eligibility rules affected the program's target population – those eligible to receive benefits?
- How does income from other household members affect labor force participation and reasons for not working?
- How do wealth and income patterns differ across various age, sex, and racial groups?

Because SIPP is a longitudinal survey – capturing changes in household and family composition over a multiyear period – it also helps answer questions like:

- What factors affect change in household and family structure and living arrangements?
- What are the interactions between changes in household and family structures and the distribution of income?
- What effects do changes in household composition have on economic status and program eligibility?
- What are the primary determinants of turnover in programs such as the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP)?

A major use of SIPP data is to evaluate participation in, and eligibility for, government programs, and to analyze the impacts of modifications to those programs. This research helps assess the economic status of the nation, track change over time, and provide policy makers the data needed to make informed economic decisions. SIPP data also support research that focuses on dynamic characteristics of the population, such as changes in income, eligibility for and participation in transfer programs, household and family composition, labor force behavior, and other associated events.

1.4 Survey Content

While the main objective of SIPP is to provide accurate and comprehensive data about the income and program participation of individuals and households in the United States. In addition to these core areas, SIPP collects extensive data on various dimensions of economic well-being, including family dynamics, educational attainment, housing expenditures, asset ownership, health insurance, disability, childcare, and food security. These data put the income and program reciprocity of individuals and households into the family and social context.

The 2021 SIPP introduced new questions in four subject areas: Marital History, Parental Mortality, Retirement and Pensions, and Disability. These additions were designed to producing detailed statistics about: personal retirement plans such as Individual Retirement Accounts (IRAs), Keogh accounts, 401(k), 403(b), and thrift plans; participation in pension and retirement plans provided by an employer or business; current and previous marital status; parental mortality; self-designation of health status; work disability; and adult and child disability. The additional content was developed through a joint statistical

agreement between the Census Bureau and the Social Security Administration (SSA) and is largely a subset of questions that were included in the “2014 SIPP SSA Supplement.”

Table 1-1 provides an overview of topics collected in the 2025 SIPP. Chapter 4 provides detailed information about how these topics appear in the 2025 SIPP public-use data. For more information about the collection of each topic, please visit the SIPP Content page at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/about/sipp-content-information.html.

TABLE 1-1. TOPICS COLLECTED IN THE SURVEY OF INCOME AND PROGRAM PARTICIPATION

<u>Demographic Characteristics</u>	<u>Assets and Liabilities</u>	<u>Program Participation and Income Transfers</u>
Age, sex, race, and Hispanic origin	<i>Assets:</i>	Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC) and tax filing
Educational enrollment	Interest-earning assets	Energy assistance
Educational Attainment and Nondegree Credentials	Other income-generating assets	General Assistance (GA)
Family and household relationships	Other assets	‘Other’ assistance
Fertility	Retirement accounts	School meals
Language	<i>Liabilities:</i>	Social Security – child
Marital status and marital history	Debts secured by assets	Social Security – self
Nativity, citizenship, and parent nativity	Unsecured debt	Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC)
Parent mortality	<i>Additional topics:</i>	Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP)
Residence	Rent and mortgage payments	Supplemental Security Income (SSI)
Veteran status	Utility payments	Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF)
<u>Employment</u>		Unemployment Compensation/Insurance
Commuting and work schedule	<u>Health and Well-Being</u>	Veterans benefits
Earnings	Adult well-being	Workers’ compensation
Hours and pay changes	Food security	<u>Other Income</u>
Job characteristics	Child care	Annuity and life insurance retirement income
Labor force participation	Child well-being	Disability income payments
Parental leave	Disability	Lump sum severance pay and retirement plan income
Reasons for not working	Health care utilization and medical expenditures	Miscellaneous income
Time away without pay	Health insurance	Pension Income
		Retirement account withdrawals
		Support paid
		Support received
		Survivor income benefit

1.5 Survey Organization

This section outlines the organizational structure of SIPP data collection, including the use of *panels*, *waves*, and *reference periods*.

1.5.1 Panels

A SIPP panel consists of a group of households selected to be interviewed periodically over multiple years. A panel may run alone, such as the 2014 Panel, or concurrently with other panels, such as the 1990 through 1993 Panels. Since 1984, there have been a total of 21 SIPP panels. ~~Table 1-2~~ [Table 1-2](#) lists all current and historical SIPP panels along with their respective data collection periods.

Beginning with the 2018 Panel, SIPP adopted a staggered approach in which new panels are introduced annually and overlap with existing ones (e.g., 2019, 2020, and subsequent panels). Figure 1-2 depicts the timeline and structure of these panels. Although multiple panels are now collected during each annual interview cycle, they are referred to by their calendar year of collection (i.e., all panels collected in 2025 are collectively referred to as “2025 SIPP”).

The 2025 SIPP continued to face challenges related to rising data collection costs and lower-than-average national unit response rates. For technical documentation and more information on SIPP data quality, please visit the SIPP website's Technical Documentation page at [<www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation.html>](http://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation.html).

1.5.2 Waves

Within a panel, a full cycle of administering the questionnaire – i.e., conducting a round of interviews with the selected households – is called a *wave*. The first time an interviewer contacts a household is Wave 1; the second time is Wave 2, and so on.

Prior to the 2014 Panel, most SIPP panels included between 8 and 16 waves. Starting with the 2014 Panel, SIPP adopted an annual interview schedule rather than a four-month cycle, reducing the number of waves to four. As a result, 2014 and later panels include only four interviews, compared to the 8 to 16 interviews conducted in earlier panels. Each wave continues to produce a corresponding published public-use data file.

TABLE 1-2. SUMMARY OF THE 1984 TO 2024 SIPP PANELS

Panel	Date of First Interview	Date of Last Interview	Number of Wave 1 Eligible Households	Number of Waves
1984	Oct. 83	Jul. 86	20,897	9
1985	Feb. 85	Aug. 87	14,306	8
1986	Feb. 86	Apr. 88	12,425	7
1987	Feb. 87	May 89	12,527	7

Panel	Date of First Interview	Date of Last Interview	Number of Wave 1 Eligible Households	Number of Waves
1988	Feb. 88	Jan. 90	12,725	6
1989	Feb. 89	Jan. 90	12,867	3
1990	Feb. 90	Sep. 92	19,800	8
1991	Feb. 91	Sep. 93	15,626	8
1992	Feb. 92	May 95	21,577	10
1993	Feb. 93	Jan. 96	21,823	9
1996	April 96	Mar. 00	40,188	12
2001	Feb. 01	Jan. 04	50,500	9
2004	Feb. 04	Jan. 08	51,379	12
2008	Sept. 08	Dec. 13	52,031	16
2014	Feb. 14	Jun. 17	42,348	4
2018	Feb. 18	May. 21	44,870	4
2019	Mar. 19	Jul. 19	24,500	1*
2020	Feb. 20	Jun. 23	22,241	4
2021	Feb. 21	Jun. 24	14,624	4
2022	Feb. 22	Jun. 25	33,302	4
2023	Feb. 23	Ongoing	13,293	Ongoing
2024	Feb. 24	Ongoing	12,266	Ongoing
2025	Feb. 25	Ongoing	11,743	Ongoing

* Due to data collection issues during the 2019 SIPP, the 2019 Panel Wave 1 cases were de-prioritized during collection in favor of retaining the longitudinal capacity of the 2018 SIPP Panel.

1.5.3 Reference Periods

Most questions in the 2025 SIPP referred to the previous calendar year (January through December of 2024). Notable exceptions to this are questions about disability status and parent-child relationships, which are asked based on the respondent's status at the time of the interview.

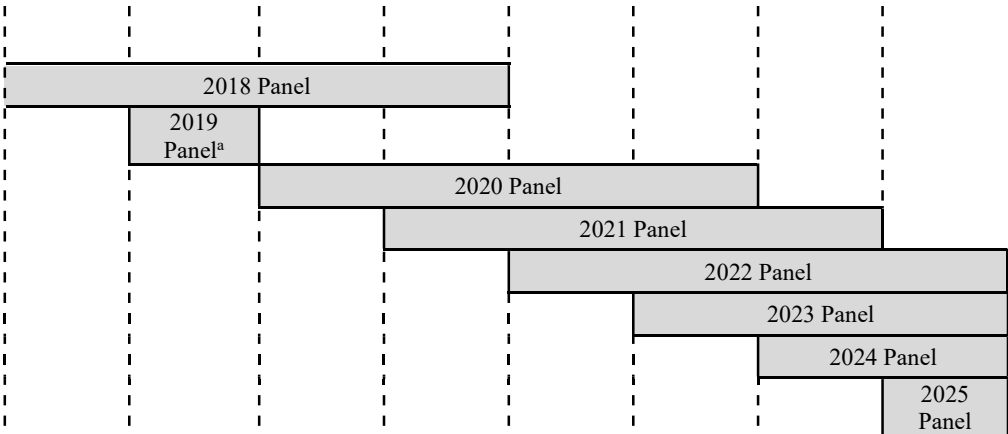
Despite the annual interview schedule, SIPP still captures key month-level data. For example, SIPP asks each respondent if he or she had a health insurance plan at any time between January 1 of the reference year and the time of interview. If the answer is yes, the event history calendar captures spell- and month-

level data on the respondent's coverage for each month in the reference period.² Over the course of 4 waves per panel, SIPP data are collected and published covering 48 consecutive months.

Figure 1-2 provides a summary of the SIPP data collection organizational structure starting with the 2018 panel. In addition to the panel details mentioned in Section 1.5.1, it provides information about the different SIPP samples and their corresponding response rates as well as details about each data file.

² In the SIPP, the term “spell” is used to describe a continuous period of time a respondent received, participated in, was covered by, or was in a state of a given topic.

Figure 1-2. Overview of SIPP Data Beginning With 2018 SIPP Panel

	2018 SIPP	2019 SIPP	2020 SIPP	2021 SIPP	2022 SIPP	2023 SIPP	2024 SIPP	2025 SIPP
Reference Year	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Release Date	20-Aug	21-Sep	21-Oct	22-Aug	23-Jun	24-Jul	24-Jul	15-Jul
Panel Details								
Sample Details								
Wave 1 Eligible Households	44,870	24,500	22,241	14,624	33,302	13,293	12,266	11,743
Weighted Response Rate	58.40%	42.90%	45.00%	48.80%	36.90%	46.50%	46.40%	42.60%
Data File Details								
Persons	63,915	50,212	52,572	56,872	41,070	40,263	36,915	32,052
Wave 1	63,915	14,285 ^a	18,948	14,604	24,131	12,857	11,632	9,490
Wave 2		35,927	0 ^a	11,827	7,976	14,119	7,697	6,389
Wave 3			33,624	0 ^a	8,963	6,310	11,858	5,896
Wave 4				30,441	0 ^a	6,977	5,728	10,277
Person-months	763,186	593,604	622,339	670,678	487,736	476,744	437,168	379,215
Number of Variables ^b	4,942	5,013	5,026	5,214	5,238	5,200	5,203	5,204

^a The 2019 SIPP panel was discontinued after Wave 1.

^b Includes status flags.

2 Sampling Design and Interview Procedures

SIPP uses a complex sample design rather than a simple random sample to determine which households are interviewed. This complex sample design has important implications for the estimation of standard errors. Because the SIPP design is not a simple random sample, the standard errors reported by most off-the-shelf statistical software will underestimate the true standard errors of estimates from SIPP.

The 2025 SIPP sampled about 38,000 designated Housing Units (HUs) total, from 518 sample areas for Wave 1 and 686 sample areas for Waves 2 through 4 designed to represent the civilian, noninstitutionalized population of the U.S.³ This yielded 32,500 eligible HUs.⁴ Of the eligible HUs, approximately 14,000 households were interviewed between February and June 2025, resulting in 32,000 person interviews.

2.1 Sample Design

The Census Bureau employs a two-stage sample design to select the SIPP sample. The two stages are (1) the selection of primary sampling units (PSUs, discussed below), and (2) the selection of address units within sample PSUs. Census Bureau interviewers follow an established procedure to identify sample members within the selected address units.

2.1.1 Sample Universe

The SIPP sample universe is the civilian, noninstitutionalized population of the United States.⁵ The sampling universe is based on addresses from multiple sources – chiefly the 2020 Decennial Census – and contains approximately 331.2 million individuals at the time of sampling for the 2025 SIPP. SIPP samples housing units from the current Master Address File (MAF), which is maintained by the U.S. Census Bureau and is the source of addresses for the American Community Survey, other demographic surveys, and the decennial census. The MAF is updated using the U.S. Postal Service’s Delivery Sequence File and various automated, clerical, and field operations.

³ The SIPP sampling areas are redesigned approximately every 10 years. The 2025 Panel was the first sample of a new redesign.

⁴ A HU may be ineligible for interview for many reasons, the most common being that the HU is vacant or no longer a residential unit.

⁵ Civilian status is determined at time of interview. Those who were non-civilians during the reference year but civilians at time of interview are in the sample universe.

2.1.2 Primary Sampling Units (PSUs)

PSUs comprise one or more contiguous counties. Single counties are used as long as the county has a population of 7,500 or more. When the population threshold is not met, adjacent counties are combined. Larger populated PSUs are identified as self-representing (SR) PSUs, while the remaining PSUs are identified as non-self-representing (NSR). PSUs are redesigned approximately every 10 years, and the SIPP 2025 Panel is the first sample of a new redesign. Generally, PSUs with 171,000 or more housing units are classified as SR. SR PSUs are in the SIPP sample with certainty, while the NSR PSUs are stratified and selected with a probability proportionate to their size. During the stratification process, NSR PSUs are grouped according to their similarity on specified poverty measures. Given that SIPP uses a state-based sample design, all strata are formed within state boundaries. During the PSU selection process, two NSR PSUs are selected from each stratum with their probability proportionate to their size in relation to the entire stratum in which they belong. The SIPP 2025 Panel contains 170 SR PSUs and 348 NSR PSUs in the sample.

2.1.3 Selection of Addresses in Sample PSUs

The universe of addresses within each sample PSU is divided into two strata, one with a higher concentration of low-income households and the other with a lower concentration of low-income households. Addresses are sorted by geographic and demographic variables, and a systematic selection of units is taken from each stratum. A higher sampling rate is used in the stratum with the higher concentration of low-income households, thereby resulting in an oversample of low-income households. For the 2025 SIPP, the sampling rate for the low-income stratum is 1.6 times the overall sampling rate in each PSU. This results in a 30 percent increase in the number of cases in and near poverty than without oversampling.

2.2 Locating Sample Address and Respondents

During Wave 1, the interviewer visits the sampled address, compiles a household roster, and attempts to interview all members of the household who are aged 15 years and older. Information about household members under 15 years of age is collected via a proxy interview. Typically, a household member is someone who sleeps in the household the majority of the time. The SIPP instrument determines whether each person is a household member through a series of questions. [Table 2-1](#) provides additional detail about who is, and is not, considered a household member in SIPP.

TABLE 2-1. SIPP HOUSEHOLD MEMBERSHIP DETERMINATION

Question	YES (Is Member of Household)	NO (Not Member of Household)
Person staying at SIPP address at time of interview		
Members of family, visitors, etc. ordinarily sleeps here	Y	
- here temporarily, no living quarters held elsewhere	Y	

Question	YES (Is Member of Household)	NO (Not Member of Household)
- here temporarily, living quarters held elsewhere		N
In Armed Forces, stationed locally and sleeps here	Y	
In Armed Forces, stationed elsewhere and here on leave		N
Student temporarily attending school here, living quarters held elsewhere		N
- married and accompanied by own family	Y	
- student nurse attending school nearby	Y	
Absent person who usually lives at SIPP address		
Inmate in an institutional special place regardless of whether living quarters are being held here		N
Temporarily on vacation, in hospital, and living quarters held	Y	
Absent for work, living quarters held here	Y	
Absent for work, living quarters held here and elsewhere but comes here infrequently		N
Unmarried college student working away from home during break, living quarters held here	Y	
In Armed Forces, stationed elsewhere	Y	
In school elsewhere, living quarters held-not married or with own family	Y	
- married and accompanied by own family		N
- attending school overseas		N
- student nurse living at school		N
Exceptions and doubtful cases		
Person with two residences, sleeps most often in other location		N
Person with two concurrent residences, sleeps here most often	Y	
Citizen of foreign country temporarily in U.S., living on premises of an embassy, ministry, legation, chancellery, or consulate		N
Citizen of foreign country temporarily in U.S.- studying here and no other usual residence in U.S.	Y	
- living and working here and no other usual residence in U.S.	Y	
- visiting or traveling in U.S.		N

While the Census Bureau prefers that all respondents who are present at the time of the interview answer for themselves, SIPP accepts proxy interviews from another household respondent when necessary. Also, within each household the instrument identifies a “reference person,” typically the first person listed as the owner or renter of the housing unit.

For Waves 2+ cases, SIPP switches from a household survey to a person-based survey. All people who were interviewed in the first wave of the panel and any children subsequently born to or adopted by them are designated as original sample members. When visiting the original household, the interviewer determines whether one or more original sample members are present. If so, the interviewer updates the household roster, listing all people living or staying there, including anyone who may have joined the household, such as a new spouse or baby, and the dates they entered the household.

For those remaining at the same address, the interviewer verifies that certain previously collected information still applies, completes the questionnaire for each person aged 15 years and older, and collects certain information for children under age 15. Information is likewise collected for all new household members. They are interviewed each wave so long as they live with an original sample member. Also noted are people who left the household and their dates of departure, along with their new address (if known).

2.3 Following Movers

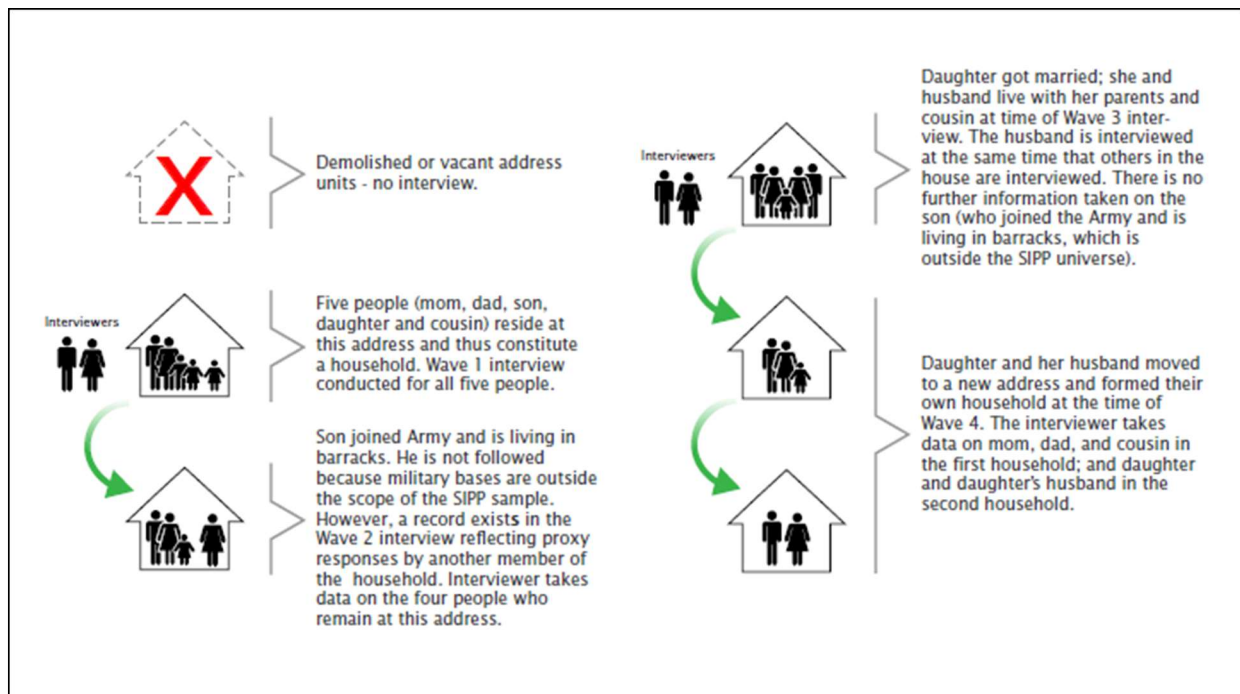
SIPP is a true longitudinal survey that tracks people over time. With few exceptions, original sample members are interviewed annually over the duration of the panel no matter where they reside. When original sample members move to a new address, interviewers attempt to locate and interview them every year. [Figure 2-1](#) illustrates a few examples of SIPP’s following rules.

Movers are interviewed at their new addresses, along with other household members who are living or staying there. When original sample members move into households with other individuals not previously in the survey, the new individuals become part of the SIPP sample for as long as they continue to live with an original sample member. Similarly, when new individuals move in with original sample people after the first interview, they too become part of the SIPP sample for as long as they continue to live with an original sample member. If no original sample members live at an address where a previous interview was conducted, SIPP does not collect information from the new occupants of that address.

If an entire household moves, the interviewer tries to find the original sample people and interview them at their new address(es). Should the entire household move more than 100 miles away from a SIPP PSU, Field Representatives (FRs) attempt to conduct the interview by telephone. If the household cannot be reached, the sample members are dropped from the survey.

SIPP does not interview original sample members if they move outside the United States, become members of the military living in barracks, or become institutionalized (e.g., nursing home residents, prison inmates). The Census Bureau attempts to track such individuals so they can be interviewed should they return to the noninstitutionalized resident U.S. population.

FIGURE 2-1. EXAMPLES OF SIPP FOLLOWING RULES



2.4 Difference Between Movers and Those Who Are Temporarily Away

There is an important difference between a mover and a person who is temporarily away. A mover no longer lives at the sample address. However, a person is temporarily away if the household is that person's usual place of residence, according to the membership rules given in [Table 2-1](#) ~~Table 2-1~~, and specific living quarters are held for the person to which he or she is free to return at any time. The following two examples illustrate the distinction:

- A college student living on campus with a room held at home is still a household member at the sample address. In this case, the interviewer would try to interview that student or obtain a proxy interview with the household reference person. If the hypothetical college student originally lived in New York and, upon graduation, moved to Los Angeles to live on his or her own, the student would be considered to have moved as of the graduation date. The student's new address in Los Angeles would become his or her new household, and, if the student was an original sample member, he or she would be treated in the same way as any other original sample member who moved to the new address.
- If a household member is in the hospital following an operation but is expected to come home, that person is still a household member at the original address. If an individual interview is not feasible, the interviewer might do a proxy interview for that person. If,

however, the person moved into a nursing home, he or she would not be eligible for a SIPP interview, whether individual or proxy. At each interview, the interviewer asks the status of any original sample member who entered an institution between Wave 1 and the current wave. If the interviewer learns that the person has returned to the noninstitutionalized population, an interview is attempted.

2.5 Type-2 Persons

One of the challenges of the SIPP is capturing data on individuals who were part of the household at some point in the reference year but left the household before the interview. Data on these individuals, referred to as “Type-2” people, are important to understand how household composition and income change over the year. The information collected about Type-2 people varies by topic and is discussed more in Section 3.5.7 and within topics in Chapter 4. Note that a Type-2 person can be at any address a respondent lived at during the reference year, not just the interview address.

2.6 Interview Sequence

The SIPP interview sequence is listed in [Figure 2-2](#). A detailed list of questions asked during the interview is available on the *Questionnaires and Instruments* page of the SIPP website at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/questionnaires.html.

At the beginning of the interview the household respondent is asked about the characteristics of the housing unit and the household roster is created. Next, the household respondent provides demographic information for all household members and provides information about household relationships.

Following demographics and relationships, the personal interviews begin. Respondents first provide a list of all Type-2 people and provide basic demographic information about these people. Next, interviewers ask for additional demographic information followed by a series of screener questions to minimize respondent burden. Based on answers to these screener questions, the interviewer may skip over questions for certain topics. Section 2.6.1 provides more detail about income screeners.

The interview then moves into the Event History Calendar (EHC). The EHC was developed to facilitate respondent recall over the longer reference period and allows for integrated reporting across the domains of residency, marital history, educational enrollment, employment/time not working, program participation (SSI, SNAP, TANF, WIC, and GA), and health insurance coverage. Data in the EHC are entered as “spells,” and detailed information about each spell is then collected. Unlike the other sections of the instrument, the sequence within the EHC is not fixed; interviewers may go through EHC topics in any order.

Once the EHC is complete, respondents go on to complete the rest of the interview (i.e., post-EHC content). This includes questions about additional program participation, assets, health, and well-being. The interview concludes with the interviewer getting contact information for each household member. This information can make it easier to find household members for future waves of interviews. Note that

interviewers may pause an interview before it is complete and return to it later. They can switch from one person's interview to another, or they can exit the interview completely.

FIGURE 2-2. THE 2024 SIPP INTERVIEW SEQUENCE

Household roster and demographics - Address verification - Sample address characteristics and coverage (living quarter type and tenure) - Roster creation - Demographics (including date of birth, sex, race and ethnicity, relationships and marital status, educational attainment, veteran status, language spoken, place of birth, and citizenship)
Start of personal interviews - “Type 2” Roster/Info - Additional demographics (including certifications and marital history) - Income and program screeners - Event History Calendar - Residences - Marriage and cohabitation - School enrollment - Labor force (including jobs, businesses, contingent work, unemployment, time not in labor force, commuting, industry, occupation, and work schedule) - Programs (GA, SNAP, SSI, TANF, WIC) - Health insurance (private, Medicare, Medicaid, military, other health insurance coverage) - Health insurance follow-ups - Annual program income - VA benefits - Workers compensation - Unemployment Compensation/Insurance - Energy assistance - Free and reduced-price school meals - Social Security (Self, Child, Medicare deductions) - Other annual programs income - Lump-sum payments from pension and retirement - Disability income - Survivor benefits - Child support received - Child support paid - Other support paid - Tax returns and EITC - Miscellaneous income - Other annual assistance programs - Food assistance - Transportation assistance

- Other Assistance (clothing and housing) - Training Assistance - Retirement income - Life insurance - Assets owned - Vehicles - Primary residence - Utility payments - Debts owed - Health status, health care utilization, and medical expenditures - Disability - Fertility (including multiple partner fertility) - Parental leave - Parent mortality and nativity - Child care arrangements - Child care payment assistance - Child well-being - Time spent with parent(s) - Number of outings - Repeated grade, suspended, expelled, gifted classes - Extra-curricular activities (sports, lessons, religious service) - School performance - Adult well-being - Housing conditions - Neighborhood safety - Ability to meet essential expenses - Food security
Interview wrap-up - Follow-up visit/call info - Interview closeout
Contact History Instrument and Neighborhood Observation Instrument

FRs also complete a Contact History Instrument (CHI) following each household contact attempt. CHI is a standalone instrument and is completed for both personal visits and telephone interviews. Using CHI, FRs record contact attempts, outcomes of contact attempts, judgements of reluctance encountered from households, any strategies used with households, and more. CHI also includes a Neighborhood Observation Instrument (NOI). NOI is a set of observation questions that are completed during the first personal visit attempt only. These questions ask about the condition of the neighborhood and ask for judgements by the FR on things like household members' ages and presence of children.

2.6.1 Income Screener Questions

The SIPP instrument includes functionality to help reduce respondent burden. One example is with the income screener questions. This set of questions, which are asked in the pre-EHC portion of the instrument, limit the universe for some means-tested programs. When certain parameters are met, the instrument skips the SNAP, TANF, GA, and WIC questions in the EHC.

The income screener questions ask about:

- Annual income below a specified amount
- Monthly income below a specified amount
- And a catch-all for specific means-tested programs

The income amounts are based on 200 percent of the poverty threshold for the number of people residing in the sample unit. Annual amounts are rounded to the nearest \$1,000, while monthly amounts are rounded to the nearest \$500. This conservative approach ensures that resource sharing between household members is captured. For example, in an unmarried partner household with one child, the father may earn more than 200 percent of the poverty threshold for an individual but not more than 200 percent of the poverty threshold for three people. In other words, if the household as a whole or one or more members could have been eligible for means-tested programs based on income, the intention is to ask about receipt of means-tested programs.

If respondents report having annual income above the specified threshold, they move on to the monthly question. If they then report having monthly income above the specified threshold, they move on to the catchall program question ensuring they did not receive some type of means-tested assistance. If respondents report having income below a specified threshold or having some type of means-tested assistance, they remain in universe for the SNAP, TANF, GA, and WIC questions. Otherwise, if respondents satisfy all three program screener questions, they are not asked about receipt of these programs.

The income screener questions were designed to reduce respondent burden in the instrument. They are not included on the public use data file.

2.6.2 Grouping Families (Clumps)

In another effort to reduce respondent burden, SIPP groups certain related people into “clumps” whereby the household respondent’s answer applies to all members of the clump. Thus, in the subsequent interviews of fellow “clump” members, certain questions will not be asked.

The clump is an internally derived instrument variable, and not part of SIPP’s public-use data. When certain parameters are met, the SIPP instrument limits the number of people who are in universe for the income screener questions and the family – or household-based EHC screener questions (SNAP, TANF, and GA). The intention is to ask only one respondent the family – or household-based program questions when resources were shared during the entire reference period.

Who is included in the screener clump?

- Household respondent
- Spouse of the household respondent
- Children of the household respondent under age 22 who did not have dependents living with them

The clump always includes the household respondent, who is the first person interviewed. If the household respondent resided with a spouse during the entire reference period, then the spouse is included in the clump. Similarly, if the household respondent resided with their children under age 22 who did not have dependents of their own living with them during the entire reference period, then the children are included in the clump.

Who is not included in the screener clump?

- Non-nuclear families
- Parents of household respondents between the ages of 15 and 21

The clump intentionally excludes multigenerational households, unmarried partner households, and other types of non-nuclear family forms because of their complexity. This conservative approach allows for the income dynamics across different family forms to be captured. For example, in a multigenerational household, a daughter and granddaughter might receive TANF, while a father and mother did not. Additionally, the screener clump intentionally excludes the parents of a household reference person between the ages of 15 and 21. This conservative approach ensures the collection of the most accurate information from all adults in the household.

The clump is derived by the instrument to reduce respondent burden. This information is not included on the public use data file.

2.7 Feedback/Dependent Interviewing

Dependent interviewing is the process in which information from a previous interview carries forward into the current survey instrument to streamline the interviewing process and maximize data quality. To both improve data quality and reduce respondent burden, the SIPP instrument features the use of dependent data for Waves 2+ cases. Nearly 500 items are carried forward from wave to wave, allowing respondents to verify information for these items and reduce interview length.

Dependent data also mitigate the negative effects of seam bias. Seam bias is a common ailment of longitudinal surveys, in which event changes are reported disproportionately at the “seam” between waves. The key to alleviating seam bias is to create overlapping periods in which one wave’s interview period includes a portion of the next year’s reference period. Through dependent interviewing, the instrument already possesses data for the early part of the next wave’s reference period, since each interview covers the previous calendar year plus the months leading up to the interview in the current calendar year. With this data from the previous wave, the instrument can tailor question wording to remind respondents of their situation during the previous wave. Therefore, the recall window shrinks, and respondents are less apt to report changes at the transition between two reference periods. When SIPP

introduced increased use of dependent interviewing in the 2004 Panel, every area of the survey experienced a decrease in seam bias, with many topics cutting its effect in half (Moore, 2008).

Utilizing dependent data in a household survey, particularly one allowing for proxy respondents, creates the possibility of sharing information within a household that a respondent would rather keep private. To protect respondent confidentiality within a household, the Census Bureau instituted the Respondent Identification Policy (RIP) in 1998. RIP mandates that Census demographic surveys gain respondent consent to reference any previously collected data. Therefore, there is a small subsample of respondents for whom dependent data is not used.

2.8 Nonresponse

The Census Bureau distinguishes between household and person nonresponse. Household nonresponse occurs either when the interviewer cannot locate the household or when the interviewer locates the household but is unable to interview any adult household members. Person nonresponse occurs when the FR interviews at least one person in the household but cannot interview at least one other household member. This usually occurs because that person refuses to answer the questions or is unavailable and a proxy cannot provide the responses.

SIPP follows all original sample members from one wave to the next, except for original sample members under the age of 15 who moves out without an accompanying adult original sample member. Those original sample members who leave the original household and form new households are retained, and members of the new household are added to the SIPP sample. This expansion of original households can be estimated within the interviewed sample but is impossible to determine within the non-interviewed sample. Therefore, a growth factor based on the growth in the known sample is used to estimate the unknown expansion of the non-interviewed households. Growth factors account for the additional nonresponse stemming from the expansion of non-interviewed households. They are used to compute a more accurate estimate of the weighted number of non-interviewed household units (HUs) at each wave. The Census Bureau categorizes household nonresponse as Types A, B, C and D, and person-level nonresponse as Type Z. Each type is discussed in more detail below.

2.8.1 Type-A Household Nonresponse

Type-A household nonresponse occurs when the interviewer finds an eligible household address but cannot obtain interviews. Examples of Type-A nonresponse include:

- The interviewer finds no one at home despite repeated visits.
- All eligible household members are away during the entire interview period (e.g., an extended vacation).
- Household members refuse to participate in the survey.
- Interviews cannot be conducted because of language barrier.

When this type of household nonresponse occurs in Wave 1, SIPP does not attempt to interview the household members at subsequent waves. For Type-A nonresponse that occurs in Waves 2+, however, interviewers try to obtain interviews in the following waves.

2.8.2 Type-B Household Nonresponse

Type-B non-interviews occur when a sample unit is currently vacant, unfit for residence, or occupied by people who are ineligible to be interviewed. Examples of Type-B non-interviews include:

- The sample unit is under construction and is not ready to be occupied.
- The sample unit is to be demolished (due to fire, deterioration, etc.).
- All household members age 15+ are on active duty in the Armed Forces.

When this type of non-interview occurs in Wave 1, SIPP does not attempt to interview the household in subsequent waves. For Type-B non-interviews that occur in Waves 2+, SIPP will attempt to interview household members in following waves if the entire household was in the Armed Forces, institutionalized, or designated as a “Type B – Other” household. Type-B non-interviews do not affect the response rate.

2.8.3 Type-C Household Nonresponse

Type-C non-interviews occur when a sample unit does not exist or is permanently unable to be occupied, or when there are no eligible household members remaining in a Wave 2+ interview. Examples of Type-C non-interviews include:

- The sample unit address includes a unit designation that is not in use.
- The sample unit was converted to a permanent business.
- All household members are deceased (Waves 2+).
- All household members moved (Waves 2+).

SIPP does not attempt to interview Type-C non-interviews in subsequent waves. Like Type-B non-interviews, Type-C non-interviews do not affect the response rate.

2.8.4 Type-D Household Nonresponse

Type-D household nonresponse occurs when original sample members move to an unknown address or an address where the respondent is unable to be interviewed. Type-D nonresponse applies only to Wave 2 and beyond.

2.8.5 Type Z Person Nonresponse

Type Z person-level nonresponse occurs when a sample person is part of the household on the date of the interview but refuses to answer or is not available for the interview and a proxy interview is not obtained. While household nonresponse is usually handled by weighting adjustments, Type-Z cases are handled by imputation. (See discussion of imputation and weighting in Chapters 6 and 7, respectively.)

2.8.6 Item Nonresponse

Item nonresponse is an additional source of missing data; it occurs when respondents do not answer one or more survey questions, even though they complete most of the questionnaire. Respondents might refuse to answer a particular question or set of questions, or not have the information requested. Although interviewers are trained to attempt to persuade respondents to answer all applicable questions and will call back if a respondent can provide data later, those efforts are not always successful. In many cases, the Census Bureau handles item nonresponse by imputation, that is, by assigning values for the missing items. Chapter 6 provides more information about how SIPP handles missing data.

3 SIPP Public-Use Microdata Files

This chapter introduces the SIPP public-use microdata files, available on the *Survey of Income and Program Participation Datasets* webpage at <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/data/datasets.html>. Note that variables on the data file do not always correspond directly to the items on the questionnaire. Additionally, for those that do align, the range of possible values may not exactly match the response categories presented on the survey instrument. Also, some variables are derived from combinations of other variables, commonly referred to as “recodes.”

Additionally, raw SIPP data are available to researchers with an approved Federal Statistical Research Data Center (FSRDC) project. Information about accessing SIPP data through an FSRDC is available at <www.census.gov/about/adrm/fsrdc.html>.

3.1 SIPP Data Files

The 2025 SIPP public-use microdata release includes the following datasets.

Primary Data File: This file contains person-month-level data reflecting the survey’s topical content. Each individual may have up to 12 records. Household-level variables are copied across all members of a household; person-level variables are copied across all months for each individual; spell-level variables are copied across all months within a spell; and month-level variables vary month-to-month.

Replicate Weights File: This file provides person-month-level replicate weights for records on the corresponding primary or core data file. The 2025 data include 240 replicate weights.

Longitudinal Weights Files: These files offer weights for cohorts of respondents for who participated every month of a designated longitudinal period (two-year, three-year, or four-year spans) regardless of their originating panel. Included in these cohorts are individuals who exited the target population due to death or relocation to ineligible addresses (institutions, foreign living quarters, military barracks), as well as those for whom data were imputed for missing months. The Census Bureau makes nonresponse adjustments to the longitudinal weights to compensate for attrition and post stratification adjustments to make the weighted sample totals conform to population totals for key variables.

Longitudinal Replicate Weights Files: These files provide replicate weights for individuals in the Longitudinal Weight files.

Detailed information on accessing these files and tools to facilitate the use of SIPP data are provided in Section 5.1. The primary identification (ID) variables essential for navigating SIPP data are discussed beginning in Section 3.4.

Table 3-1 ~~Table 3-1~~ describes the general variable naming conventions for variables within the 2025 SIPP data files.

TABLE 3-1. VARIABLE NAMING CONVENTIONS

Variable Prefix	Description
E	Basic edited variable (i.e., processed version of raw survey data)
R	Recoded variable (combination of other variables)
T	Topcoded, bottomcoded, or otherwise disclosure-protected variable (discussed in section 3.2)
A	Universe and imputation status flag for edited and recoded variables (discussed in section 3.3)
G	Sample or geography identifier
S	Record ID variable
W	Weight variable

3.2 Confidentiality Procedures for the Public-Use Files

Prior to public release, SIPP data undergo additional editing to ensure the confidentiality of respondents. This editing includes topcoding and bottomcoding select variables (e.g., income, assets, and age), perturbing select variables, suppressing geographic information, and suppressing variables with low case counts. Because of these procedures, estimates based on public-use data may differ slightly from estimates published by the Census Bureau.

3.2.1 Topcoding and Bottomcoding

Certain data points, such as exceptionally high income or asset values, may inadvertently reveal a respondent's identity. To mitigate this risk, the Census Bureau uses topcoding and bottomcoding techniques (setting limits the maximum/minimum of published values) on these variables and other continuous variables prior to public release. This is done in different ways for different variables. For incomes and amounts with a skewed distribution, such as annual salary or home values, the amount is replaced by an average of topcoded values.⁶ For other income variables, such as program income for which a threshold is determined by institutional rules, amounts over a certain maximum value are set to

⁶ For hourly wages, the median above the threshold is output on the data file instead of the mean. For most variables using this methodology, the mean output is the within-cell average based on person-characteristics. More information about these characteristics and the distributions above the topcoding threshold, such as mean, median and standard deviation, is available.

that maximum. As in the past, aggregate income variables for persons, families, and households are the sum of their component variables after they have been topcoded.

While income is the primary variable subject to topcoding, other variables that may disclose a respondent's identity, such as age, are also topcoded. Additionally, variables like occupation may be aggregated into broader categories to further protect respondent confidentiality. In some cases, variables such as employment start dates or those with negative values may be bottomcoded if they pose a disclosure risk.⁷

3.2.2 Perturbation

Perturbation is used to obscure atypical characteristics of individuals or households at a specific point in time. For instance, consider a 55-year-old first-time mother or a household with sextuplets. The Census Bureau's editing procedures identify and modify such unusual circumstances to protect the mother's privacy.

Dates associated with events that may be associated with a public record are also perturbed. For example, events such as a birth, death, marriage, or divorce may be recorded in the SIPP while a household is in sample, but this information may be perturbed to protect privacy. Data users should be aware of these disclosure avoidance procedures when using demographic information.

3.2.3 Suppression of Geographic Information

Geographic information that can be used to identify survey respondents, such as household addresses, is excluded from SIPP's public-use files. Additionally, individual metropolitan areas and specific non-metropolitan areas (such as counties outside of metropolitan areas) are not included. SIPP does identify metropolitan and nonmetropolitan status for respondents in states where (1) both the metropolitan and non-metropolitan populations are over 250,000 or (2) the state's population is entirely metropolitan. Respondents living in states that do not fit these criteria are coded as "non-identified" for metropolitan status.

3.2.4 Suppression of Other Variables

Variables that do not have a sufficient number of records with in-universe values have all records set to *missing*. These variables are also labeled as "Suppressed" in their metadata. Note that variables without any in-universe values, such as higher-numbered *RREL_PNUM* array variables, also receive the "Suppressed" designation.

⁷ In the case of bottomcoded earnings and asset variables, the set of outliers is replaced with the threshold value to minimize the difference between the SIPP's internal and public-use poverty rates. The mean and median values below the bottomcode are also provided to users wishing to implement a different procedure.

3.3 Status Flags

Nearly all subject-matter variables in the SIPP data files have a corresponding “status flag” variable prefixed with an “A.” These status flags indicate whether the corresponding variable’s value for a given record was reported, imputed, or assigned.

Possible status flag values are listed in [Table 3-2](#). A value of 0 signifies that the item is “Not in universe” for that record, meaning the item did not meet the criteria to be assigned data. A value of 1 indicates that the item was reported by the respondent. Status flags values between 2 and 6 denote that the item underwent some type of imputation. Values of 7 and 8 are most common among recoded variables and indicate that an item underwent a combination of imputation methods, either with reported data (values of 7) or without (values of 8). Finally, some recoded variables have a status flag value of 9, meaning that data users should refer to the status flags of the individual components for more detailed information.

TABLE 3-2. STATUS FLAG VALUES

Status Flag Value	Meaning	Description
0	Not in universe	The item is not imputed, and no data was reported by the respondents.
1	In universe, as reported	The item is not imputed, and data was reported by the respondents.
2	Statistical imputation (hot-deck)	The item is imputed a value from hot-deck imputation.
3	Logical imputation	The item is imputed logically.
4	Model-based imputation	The item has gone through a model-based imputation procedure.
5	Cold-deck value imputation	The item is imputed to a cold-deck value. This cold-deck value is what each cell in the hot-deck matrix gets initialized to. It is the most common reported value a respondent would be likely to report for that particular cell. So, if an item could not get a hot-deck value, this initialized value is used to set the value for that item.
6	Imputed from a range	The item is imputed based on a range.
7	Combination of 1 and 2/3/5/6	The item is imputed using reported value and any combination of imputation method values 2, 3, 5, and 6 (described above).
8	Combination of 2/3/5/6	The item is imputed using any combination of imputation method value 2, 3, 5, and 6 (described above).
9	Can be determined from the status flags for the components of this recode	The item is a recoded variable created using other variables in the data.

3.4 Understanding the Identification (ID) Variables in SIPP

Because SIPP is a longitudinal survey, it's important to understand how to identify and link individuals, families, and households over time. [Table 3-3](#) describes 2025 SIPP's highest-level identification (ID) variables for navigating and linking data. Sections 3.4.1 through 3.4.5 provide further discussion on these variables. Additional variables are available to identify individuals who are members of related subfamilies, unrelated subfamilies (also known as *secondary families*), and government transfer program units, such as SNAP units. Sections 3.4.5 and 3.6 discuss these other variables in greater detail.

TABLE 3-3. 2024 SIPP IDENTIFICATION (ID) VARIABLES

ID Type	Variable
Sample Unit ID	SSUID
Person Number within Sample Unit ID	PNUM
Month of Record	MONTHCODE
Monthly Residence ID	ERESIDENCEID
Residence ID at Time of Interview	EHRESIDENCID
Interview Address ID	SHHADID

3.4.1 Sample Unit ID (SSUID)

During the initial interview (Wave 1), each sampled dwelling unit is assigned a unique, random sample unit identifier known as SSUID. The same SSUID is then assigned to each person within the Wave 1 household (i.e., original sample person) and remains unchanged throughout the panel. If an original sample person moves to a different address (i.e., a spawned household), they retain the same SSUID. If new people join an original sample person at either the original or a new address, they are assigned the same SSUID as the original person and become secondary sample persons. At the conclusion of the panel, all individuals who have ever resided with an original sample person share the same SSUID. This SSUID serves as their common link to the original sample unit (i.e., a parent household).

In the 2025 SIPP data, the SSUID consists of 14 digits, with the last two digits signifying which panel respondents entered the SIPP sample. For example, respondents who entered the SIPP sample in the 2025 Panel have '25' as the last two digits in their SSUID.

3.4.2 Person Number (PNUM)

Each sample member is assigned a person number when they first enter the SIPP sample called PNUM. This person number differentiates persons within the sample unit and does not change throughout the panel. The first digit indicates the wave in which a person joined the SIPP sample, and the next two digits correspond to the person's place on the household roster. PNUMs are unique within SSUIDs.

3.4.3 Month of Record (MONTHCODE)

Since the 2025 SIPP data file is published in person-month format, each record refers to a specific reference month for a specific person. Given that the 2025 SIPP's reference period spans from January through December of 2024, most individuals have twelve records on the SIPP data file. The variable MONTHCODE identifies the numerical calendar reference month for each record. For example, records with MONTHCODE=1 refer to January, MONTHCODE=2 are records for February, and so on.

3.4.4 Residence IDs (ERESIDENCEID and EHRESIDENCID)

The Monthly Residence ID (ERESIDENCEID) is a six-digit address identifier that is unique within original sample units (SSUIDs) and may vary by month, depending on a record's address during the month specified by MONTHCODE. Sample members who move, either within or across waves, are identified by a change in their ERESIDENCEID field, as discussed more in section 3.5.2.

The first digit of ERESIDENCEID identifies the first wave in which the address appears in the data; addresses entered in Wave 1 start with '1', those entered in Wave 2 start with '2', and so on. The second and third digits, are always '00' for ERESIDENCEID values in the 2025 SIPP data. The last three digits of ERESIDENCEID represent the unique numbering of addresses that are associated with an original sample unit (SSUID). While the Wave 1 interview addresses are usually assigned values of 100001, this does not have to be the case. There are a small number of cases with values other than 100001 for their Wave 1 interview address.

A record's ERESIDENCEID at the time they were interviewed is available as EHRESIDENCID, which does not vary by month.

3.4.5 Interview Address ID (SHHADID)

Each sample unit is assigned an address ID called SHHADID that differentiates parent (or original sample) households from spawned households. SHHADID is 3 digits in 2025 SIPP data; the first digit is always '0', the second digit signifies which wave a household entered the SIPP sample, and the third digit signifies a generic counter of households within a sample unit. All parent households have '11' as the last two digits of their SHHADID. For Waves 2+, spawned households have '21' through '49' as the last two digits of their SHHADID. For example, the second spawned household that entered the SIPP sample in Wave 3 would have '32' as the last two digits of their SHHADID. SHHADID values are unique within SSUIDs. That said, it is important to note that SHHADIDs may change throughout the panel.

3.5 Identifying Persons and Their Relationships

3.5.1 Identifying Unique Persons

Each individual in the SIPP can be uniquely identified by the combination of the SSUID and the PNUM. These ID variables are essential for linking records across multiple SIPP data files, both longitudinally and for weighting. [Table 3-4](#) demonstrates the relationship between SSUID and PNUM.

TABLE 3-4. IDENTIFYING UNIQUE PERSONS EXAMPLE

Sample Unit ID (SSUID)	Person Number (PNUM)	Notes
12345678912322	101	Original sample member in 2022 Panel
12345678912322	401	Entered SIPP sample in Wave 4 of 2022 Panel
12345678912323	301	Entered SIPP sample in Wave 3 of 2023 Panel
12345678912324	101	Original sample member in 2024 Panel
12345678912324	201	Entered SIPP sample in Wave 2 of 2024 Panel
12345678912325	101	Original sample member in 2025 Panel
12345678912325	102	Original sample member in 2025 Panel

3.5.2 Household Reference Person (Householder)

Each interviewed household is designated one individual as the "household reference person" or "householder." This person is typically the individual in whose name the housing unit is owned or rented (maintained). If no such person exists, an adult member of the household is designated. In cases where the residence is jointly owned or rented by a married couple, either spouse may be designated as the householder. The household reference person can be identified by values 1 or 2 for the variable ERELPRPE.

In rare instances, multiple reference persons may be identified within a single EHRESIDENCID. In such cases, the household members within each EHRESIDENCID should be separated into distinct households based on their corresponding SHHADID values.

3.5.3 Determining Monthly Household Composition

A *household*, as the term is used in Census Bureau publications, consists of all people who occupy a housing unit regardless of their relationships to each other. For many purposes, a household can be thought of as people living at a common address. In SIPP, a person's Monthly Residence ID (ERESIDENCID) together with their Sample Unit ID (SSUID) identifies the household in which that person (PNUM) is a member of for that month. In conjunction with interview-month Residence ID (EHRESIDENCID) and mover flag (TMOVER), these variables may be used to identify residence history, identify mover status, and construct households over the twelve-month period.

Table 3-5 provides example residence history data that demonstrates determining household composition and identifying movers. In the example household:

- All four people lived together during the interview month (all four people have the same SSUID and EHRESIDENCID values).
- Person 1 lived at the interview address for all twelve months of the reference period (ERESIDENCEID=EHRESIDENCID for all twelve months of data).
- Person 2 and Person 3 lived at the interview address with Person 1 for months 9 to 12 (September-December). All three people have the same ERESIDENCEID value for months 9 to 12 (September-December), and this value is equal to the interview month Residence ID value, EHRESIDENCID.
- Person 2 and Person 3 moved to the interview address in month 9 (September). The ERESIDENCEID value for both people changed from '100002' in month 8 to '100001' in month 9 (September), indicating that the two respondents changed residences. Alternatively, the mover flag value (TMOVER = 2) for month 9 (September) on both respondents' records also indicates that the respondents moved during month 9 (September), and that this move is to a new residence in the same county and same state as the previous residence.
- Person 2 and Person 3 lived together for months 1 through 8 (January-August) at a different residence than the interview month residence (ERESIDENCEID values for both people are equal for months 1 through 8 (January-August), but this value differs from the EHRESIDENCID value).
- Person 4 did not live with Person 1, Person 2, or Person 3 for any of the twelve months of the reference period (monthly ERESIDENCEID values are never equal to the ERESIDENCEID values for Person 1, Person 2, or Person 3 in the same month during the reference period).
- Person 4 moved to the interview address, with Person 1, Person 2, and Person 3, at some point after the reference period ended and before or during the interview month (Person 4 has the same SSUID and EHRESIDENCID values, despite having a different ERESIDENCEID value than each of the other three people for every month of the reference period).

TABLE 3-5. IDENTIFYING HOUSEHOLDS AND MOVERS

MONTHCODE	SSUID	PNUM	ERESIDENCEID	EHRESIDENCID	TMOVER
(Person 1)					
1	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	<i>missing</i> (Not in universe)
2	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
3	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
4	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
5	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
6	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
7	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
8	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)

MONTHCODE	SSUID	PNUM	ERESIDENCEID	EHRESIDENCID	TMOVER
9	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
10	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
11	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
12	10111110312323	101	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
(Person 2)					
1	10111110312323	102	100002	100001	<i>missing</i> (Not in universe)
2	10111110312323	102	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
3	10111110312323	102	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
4	10111110312323	102	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
5	10111110312323	102	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
6	10111110312323	102	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
7	10111110312323	102	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
8	10111110312323	102	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
9	10111110312323	102	100001	100001	2 (mover)
10	10111110312323	102	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
11	10111110312323	102	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
12	10111110312323	102	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
(Person 3)					
1	10111110312323	103	100002	100001	<i>missing</i> (Not in universe)
2	10111110312323	103	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
3	10111110312323	103	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
4	10111110312323	103	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
5	10111110312323	103	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
6	10111110312323	103	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
7	10111110312323	103	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
8	10111110312323	103	100002	100001	1 (non-mover)
9	10111110312323	103	100001	100001	2 (mover)
10	10111110312323	103	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
11	10111110312323	103	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
12	10111110312323	103	100001	100001	1 (non-mover)
(Person 4)					
1	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	<i>missing</i> (Not in universe)
2	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)
3	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)
4	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)
5	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)
6	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)

MONTHCODE	SSUID	PNUM	ERESIDENCEID	EHRESIDENCID	TMOVER
7	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)
8	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)
9	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)
10	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)
11	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)
12	10111110312323	301	300001	100001	1 (non-mover)

3.5.4 Monthly Household Relationships

SIPP data include several recoded variables that denote the monthly relationship of each household member to each other. Because the survey allows for a possible 30 persons on the roster (up to 20 interviewed household members plus up to 10 Type-2 people), there are 30 RREL variables (RREL1-RREL30) and 30 corresponding PNUM identifiers (RREL_PNUM1-RREL_PNUM30) on each person-month record. The vector of monthly relationships (RREL[x]) must be used in conjunction with the vector of person numbers (RREL_PNUM[x]) in that month to determine monthly household relationships. The possible household relationship values are listed in [Table 3-6](#).

TABLE 3-6. MONTHLY HOUSEHOLD RELATIONSHIP VALUES

99 = self	10 = half siblings
1 = opposite-sex spouse	11 = stepsiblings
2 = opposite-sex unmarried partner	12 = adoptive siblings
3 = same-sex spouse	13 = other siblings
4 = same-sex unmarried partner	14 = parent-/child-in-law
5 = biological parent/child	15 = brother-/sister-in-law
6 = stepparent/stepchild	16 = aunt/uncle/niece/nephew
7 = adoptive parent/child	17 = other relative
8 = grandparent/grandchild	18 = foster parent/ child
9 = biological siblings	19 = other nonrelative

[Table 3-7](#) shows an example of the RREL values as they would appear on the public-use file for a household containing a couple and their child for months 1 and 2. All three individuals live together at month 1, while PNUM=102 moves to a different residence at month 2. This residence change is reflected in the RREL and RREL_PNUM vectors.

TABLE 3-7. MONTHLY HOUSEHOLD RELATIONSHIP MATRIX

SSUID	PNUM	ERESID ENCEID	MONTH CODE	RREL1	RREL2	RREL3	RREL_ PNUM1	RREL_ PNUM2	RREL_ PNUM3
12345...	101 (Husband)	100001	1	99	1	5	101	102	103
12345...	102 (Wife)	100001	1	1	99	5	101	102	103
12345...	103 (Child)	100001	1	5	5	99	101	102	103
12345...	101 (Husband)	100001	2	99	5	<i>missing</i>	101	103	<i>missing</i>
12345...	102 (Wife)	100002	2	99	<i>missing</i>	<i>missing</i>	102	<i>missing</i>	<i>missing</i>
12345...	103 (Child)	100001	2	5	99	<i>missing</i>	101	103	<i>missing</i>

3.5.5 Identifying Parents, Children, Spouses, and Partners at a Monthly Level

RREL and the relationship matrix can be used to identify the various relationships between household members present each month, but a simpler way exists for identifying a person's spouse, partner, parent(s), or child(ren). Four variables (EPNSPOUS_EHC, EPNCOHAB_EHC, RPNPAR1_EHC, and RPNPAR2_EHC) identify the person number of the spouse, person number of the partner, person number of the first parent, and person number of the second parent, respectively. In each case, the person is identified only if she or he is living at the same address as the record holder in that month.

With these variables, users can identify a variety of family configurations. For example, these variables can be used to identify households containing three generations. ~~Table 3-8~~ shows an example household containing a husband, wife, their two adult children, and their grandchild.

TABLE 3-8. IDENTIFYING, PARENTS, CHILDREN, AND SPOUSES

Person	Relationship to John Doe	PNUM	EPNSPOUS_EHC	RPNPAR1_EHC	RPNPAR2_EHC
John Doe	Self	101	102	<i>missing</i>	<i>missing</i>
Jane Doe	Spouse	102	101	<i>missing</i>	<i>missing</i>
John Doe Jr.	Child	103	<i>missing</i>	101	102
Joan Doe	Child	104	<i>missing</i>	101	102
Jimmy Doe	Grandchild	105	<i>missing</i>	104	<i>missing</i>

3.5.6 Determining Monthly Family Composition

The term *family*, as used at the Census Bureau, refers to a group of two or more people related by birth, marriage, or adoption who reside together; all such people are considered members of one family. For example, a grandparent living with a grandchild would be considered a family, as would a pair of cousins, a parent with an adopted child, an aunt with a nephew, or a blended family of married partners with a mix of biological and stepchildren.

SIPP groups related persons into families via the variable RFAMNUM by using the monthly household relationships (RRELS). This variable will have the same numeric value for everyone in the household that month who is related to the family reference person (RFAMREF) by birth, marriage, or adoption. If there is a second group of people in the household who are related to each other, but not to the first family, then they will have a value of '2' on RFAMNUM (and are known as a *subfamily*). People who are unrelated to anyone else in the household will have a unique value of RFAMNUM and will not have a value for type of family (RFAMKIND).

Rules for Assigning RFAMNUM and RFAMKIND

When grouping sample members into RFAMNUM groups and assigning RFAMKIND, SIPP processing edits institute the following process through the household roster:

1. The edit checks the roster for the first married couple and picks one of the spouses as the family reference person (RFAMREF). The edit then looks for all persons related to the selected spouse and assigns them all RFAMNUM=1. The edit then moves through the household roster, looking for a second married couple not yet assigned to a family and initiates the same grouping process, grouping members in RFAMNUM=2. The edit continues through the roster, scanning for married couples who are not part of a previously assigned RFAMNUM group. Each person in the group with a married couple will have the family type variable, RFAMKIND, set to a value of 1 for “married couple.”
2. Once all married couples are in families, the edit looks for the first mother-child pair not yet assigned to a family, selects the mother as the family reference person (RFAMREF), and groups anyone related to the mother (and not already assigned to a family) into a RFAMNUM group. Each person in that group will have the RFAMKIND value of 2, for “female, no spouse present.”
3. Once all mother-child pairs are in families, the edit looks for the first father-child pair not yet assigned to a family, selects the father as the family reference person (RFAMREF), and groups anyone related to the father (and not already assigned to a family) into a RFAMNUM group. Each person in that group will have the RFAMKIND value of 3, for “male, no spouse present.”
4. Once all father-child pairs are in families, the edit looks for remaining household members not yet assigned to a family. If any people have any relatives not already assigned to a family, they are grouped in the same RFAMNUM group. Those with no relatives are grouped in their own RFAMNUM group. Each person in a family of more than one will have RFAMKIND set to a value of 2 for “female, no spouse present” or 3 for “male, no spouse present” according to the sex of the family reference person (RFAMREF).

Table 3-9 provides an example of how household members are assigned to families.

TABLE 3-9. IDENTIFYING A FAMILY

Person	Relationship to John Doe	SSUID	PNUM	ERESID ENCEID	RFAM NUM	RFAM KIND	RFAM REF
John Doe	Self	12345678998725	101	100001	1	1	101
Jane Doe	Spouse	12345678998725	102	100001	1	1	101
Jimmy Doe	Child	12345678998725	103	100001	1	1	101
James Moe	Unrelated friend	12345678998725	104	100001	2	3	104
Joseph Moe	Other nonrelative (James' cousin)	12345678998725	105	100001	2	3	104
Joan Roe	Other nonrelative (James' girlfriend)	12345678998725	106	100001	3	<i>missing</i>	106

3.5.7 Type-2 Persons

As discussed in Section 2.5, a “Type 2” person is someone who lived with a respondent at any address (not just the interview address) during the reference year but not at the time of interview. While Type-2 people are never interviewed, and as such do not have a person-record in the data, SIPP respondents are asked to provide certain information about Type-2 people. The SIPP data files provide the following information for each Type-2 person: sex, age, whether he/she worked for pay during the time lived together, annual income, and relationship to interviewed household members in a given month. This information is available on the records of interviewed respondents. For example, the variables ET2_SEX1, TT2_AGE1, ET2_WORK1, and TT2INC1 show the sex, age, employment status, and income for the first Type-2 person reported for a SIPP respondent. Relationship to Type 2 people is available in the monthly household relationships (RRELs). This information will only be populated for the months in which the SIPP respondent resided with the Type-2 person.

Type-2 people are also eligible to be selected as recipients of respondents’ programs, such as health insurance or TANF. Additionally, a version of monthly household poverty and income estimates include Type-2 people. Each SIPP respondent may report up to 10 Type-2 persons. Though Type-2 people do not have a person-record in the data, they are given PNUM values of 60-69. If you see values of 60-69 in variables that reference PNUMs (e.g., RREL_PNUM), know that Type-2 people are being pointed to.

3.6 Identifying Program Participation in Government Transfer Programs

SIPP collects data on several government transfer programs, including the following:

- Disability benefits
- Energy assistance
- Food assistance
- Foster/child/spousal support
- General Assistance (GA)
- Retirement income
- School breakfast/lunch
- Social Security (adult)
- Social Security (on behalf of a child)
- Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC)
- Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), formerly known as Food Stamps Program
- Supplemental Security Income (SSI)
- Survivor benefits
- Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF)
- Transportation assistance
- Unemployment Compensation/Workers' Compensation
- Veterans benefits

Most of these data are reported at the annual and monthly level for each individual, but some are reported only annually and for the household (e.g., energy assistance). In the next sections, several programs are used to highlight the ways in which benefits can be received across persons in households over time. Each program, regardless of how it is collected, is also discussed in depth in section 4.4 of this document.

3.6.1 Collecting Information for Program Units

Government transfer programs differ in ways that make the collection of benefit data a challenge. Some programs are means-tested, requiring applicants' resources to fall below a defined threshold to qualify for benefits. Non-means-tested programs waive income and asset restrictions but may have other eligibility restrictions such as employment or job loss. Some programs are designed to provide benefits to an individual, while others determine eligibility at the family or household level. Numerous instrument efficiencies allow some information to be collected at a household or family level to reduce respondent burden. In most instances, collected data are edited to assign information to the persons covered by the benefit, although for EHC programs there is also information on the record of the benefit "owner" who may or may not be covered.

3.6.2 Understanding Program Participation Data Collected in the EHC

Key concepts for understanding how program participation data from the EHC are stored include: **coverage** and **ownership**.

There are two indicators of program **coverage** available on the public-use file: annual and monthly coverage. Annual coverage indicates participation in a program in at least one month of the reference period (since the 2018 SIPP, these have been named with a “YRYN” suffix; e.g., RSNAP_YRYN). For each person, these variables have the same value for every month of the reference period. Monthly coverage variables indicate participation in a program in a specific month of the reference period (since the 2018 SIPP, monthly coverage variables have been named with an “MNYN” suffix; e.g., RSNAP_MNYN). For each person, the value of these variables can vary from month to month.

Several additional variables contain information about program receipt spells. Each of these variables have the same value for the duration of a spell except for amount, coverage type, and unit size which may change from month to month while a spell is ongoing. [Table 3-10](#) summarizes these detailed spell-level variables.

TABLE 3-10. DESCRIPTION OF DETAILED VARIABLES AVAILABLE FOR SNAP, WIC, TANF, GA, AND SSI

Concept	Description	Constant within a spell	Variable suffix
Begin month	Month benefit receipt began	Yes	BMONTH
End month	Month benefit receipt ended	Yes	EMONTH
Left censor year	Year benefit receipt began <i>if receiving benefit in January the first time a respondent is interviewed</i>	Yes	LCYR
Continuation flag	Spell status <i>if benefit was received in December</i>	Yes	CFLG
Reason began	Reason receipt began	Yes	BRSN
Reason ended	Reason receipt ended <i>if receipt ended during reference period</i>	Yes	ERSN
Monthly payment	Value of monthly benefit	No	AMT
Coverage type ¹	Benefit covers children, adults, or both	No	COVTYP
Unit size ²	Number of people in the unit	No	CNT
Source ³	Source of payment	Yes	SRC1, SRC2

¹ Coverage type is only available for WIC and TANF.

² Unit size is only available for SNAP.

³ Source is only available for SSI.

This detailed information is stored on records differently depending on the program and **ownership** of the benefit. Benefits from SSI cover an individual, while benefits from SNAP, WIC, TANF, and GA cover a “program unit.” Program units may include just one person, more than one person but not all household members, or all household members. The people who are included in a program unit varies based on program rules and household composition.

For SNAP, WIC, TANF, and GA, detailed information about the spell is located on the record of the benefit **owner** in the months covered by a spell, regardless of whether this person was covered by the

benefit. For these programs, a respondent aged 15 or older in each program unit is identified as the benefit **owner** for each spell (these variables have an “OWN” suffix; e.g., ESNAP_OWN). These ownership variables are held on both the records of the benefit owners in every month of a spell and on the records of those in the program unit each month they had benefit coverage.

For SSI, however, detailed information about program receipt is available on the monthly records of the person covered by the benefit in each month of a spell. If the respondent is under age 18, ESSI_OWN points to the owner of the benefit, but the owner’s record contains no additional information about the benefit.

Table 3-11 summarizes which respondents are in universe for the EHC program coverage and ownership variables as well as detailed spell-level variables. The next section provides detailed examples to illustrate how data are stored on records with and without program receipt.

**TABLE 3-11. UNIVERSE OF VARIABLES BY OWNERSHIP AND COVERAGE
FOR SSI, TANF, WIC, SNAP, AND GA**

Variable Suffix	● in universe for all cases		○ in universe for some cases		— not in universe			
	SSI		TANF or WIC		SNAP ⁵ or GA			
	Covered	Not Covered	Owner	Non-Owner	Owner	Non-Owner	Covered	Not Covered
YRYN	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●
MNYN	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●
OWN	●	—	●	●	●	●	●	—
BMONTH	●	—	●	—	●	—	—	—
EMONTH	●	—	●	—	●	—	—	—
LCYR ¹	○	—	○	—	○	—	—	—
CLFG ²	○	—	○	—	○	—	—	—
BRSN ³	●	—	●	—	●	—	—	—
ERSN ^{3,4}	○	—	○	—	○	—	—	—
AMT	●	—	●	—	●	—	—	—
COVTYP	n/a	n/a	●	—	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a
SRC1	●	—	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a
SRC2	●	—	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a

¹ This variable is only available for spells that include January of the reference period (e.g., ESNAP_BMONTH=1) the first time a respondent is interviewed. Like other detailed spell variables, it is present for each month of the spell.

² This variable is only available for spells that end in the last month of the reference period (e.g., ESNAP_EMONTH=12). Like other detailed spell variables, it is present for each month of the spell.

³ Respondents select reasons from a mark all that apply list. Since most respondents select a single reason, the public-use file only has one variable that corresponds to the first reason reported.

⁴ This variable is only available for spells that ended during the reference period.

⁵ The variable suffix list omits CNT, which is only available for SNAP. This variable is in universe for all cases for owners and not in universe for non-owners.

3.6.3 Means-Tested Program Participation in a Sample Household

Table 3-12 details a sample household consisting of four related household members. A husband (person 101) and wife (person 102) own the house. Additionally, their adult daughter (person 103) and grandson (person 104) lived with them for the duration of the reference period. Three examples are presented to demonstrate:

- SNAP receipt that covers everyone in the household with a change in payment amount (Table 3-13)
- SSI receipt for an individual (Table 3-14)
- Multiple TANF spells across the reference period with a change in program unit (Table 3-15)

TABLE 3-12. SAMPLE HOUSEHOLD

	Husband	Wife	Adult daughter	Grandson
PNUM	101	102	103	104
TAGE	60	53	20	2

SNAP Example

The entire household was covered by SNAP benefits from January through December of the reference period (Table 3-13). From January through June of the reference period (months 1 to 6), the benefit amount was \$340. Due to an increase in household income the benefit amount decreased to \$295 for the rest of the reference period (months 7 to 12). The benefit owner was the wife (person 102). As shown, the begin month of benefit receipt, the end month of benefit receipt, and the benefit amount are only present on the wife's (person 102) monthly records. The other household respondents point to person 102 as the owner (ESNAP_OWN=102), indicating that the full detailed spell information can be found on that person's record. This example includes a subset of SNAP variables (refer to Table 3-10 and Table 3-11 for a full listing). Note that the amount variable is structured similarly to other detailed spell variables in terms of whose records are in universe and have values.

TABLE 3-13. IDENTIFYING MONTHLY PROGRAM PARTICIPATION: SNAP

Month	Variables					
	RSNAP_YRYN*	ESNAP_BMONTH	ESNAP_EMONTH	RSNAP_MNYN	ESNAP_OWN	TSNAP_AMT
Husband (101)						
1	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
2	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
3	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
4	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
5	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
6	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
7	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing

Month	Variables					
	RSNAP_YRYN*	ESNAP_BMONTH	ESNAP_EMONTH	RSNAP_MNYN	ESNAP_OWEN	TSNAP_AMT
8	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
9	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
10	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
11	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
12	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
Wife (102)						
1	1	1	12	1	102	340
2	1	1	12	1	102	340
3	1	1	12	1	102	340
4	1	1	12	1	102	340
5	1	1	12	1	102	340
6	1	1	12	1	102	340
7	1	1	12	1	102	295
8	1	1	12	1	102	295
9	1	1	12	1	102	295
10	1	1	12	1	102	295
11	1	1	12	1	102	295
12	1	1	12	1	102	295
Adult Daughter (103)						
1	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
2	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
3	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
4	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
5	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
6	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
7	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
8	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
9	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
10	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
11	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
12	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
Grandson (104)						
1	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
2	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
3	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
4	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
5	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
6	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
7	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
8	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
9	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing

Month	Variables					
	RSNAP_YRYN*	ESNAP_BMONTH	ESNAP_EMONTH	RSNAP_MNYN	ESNAP_OWN	TSNAP_AMT
10	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
11	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing
12	1	missing	missing	1	102	missing

* RSNAP_YRYN has the same value in each month because it is a reference period indicator.

SSI Example

The wife (person 102) reported receiving \$700 in SSI benefits during each month of the reference period (Table 3-14). Since SSI provides benefits to individuals, the example only includes the records for person 102. This example includes a subset of SSI variables (refer to Table 3-10 and Table 3-11 for a full listing).

TABLE 3-14. IDENTIFYING MONTHLY PROGRAM PARTICIPATION: SSI

Month	Variables					
	RSSI_YRYN*	RSSI_MNYN	ESSI_BMONTH	ESSI_EMONTH	ESSI_OWN†	TSSI_AMT
	Wife (102)					
1	1	1	1	12	missing	700
2	1	1	1	12	missing	700
3	1	1	1	12	missing	700
4	1	1	1	12	missing	700
5	1	1	1	12	missing	700
6	1	1	1	12	missing	700
7	1	1	1	12	missing	700
8	1	1	1	12	missing	700
9	1	1	1	12	missing	700
10	1	1	1	12	missing	700
11	1	1	1	12	missing	700
12	1	1	1	12	missing	700

* RSSI_YRYN has the same value in each month because it is a reference period indicator.

† ESSI_OWN only has values for respondents under age 18.

TANF Example

The adult daughter (person 103) reported receiving TANF benefits in January through April of the reference period (months 1 to 4) that covered her and her son but stopped receiving benefits for a few months (months 5 to 8) (Table 3-15). In September, she reported receiving TANF benefits that only

covered her son (person 104) through the remainder of the reference period (months 9 to 12). Detailed information about each spell, including the benefit amount, is available on the benefit owner's record (person 103). Since the adult daughter (person 103) and grandson (person 104) are the only people covered by the TANF benefit, this example only includes the records for these two household members.

TABLE 3-15. IDENTIFYING MONTHLY PROGRAM PARTICIPATION: TANF

Month	Variables										
	RTANF_YRYN*	RTANF_MNYN	ETANF_BMONTH	ETANF_EMONTH	ETANF_OWN	TTANF_AMT	ETANF_LCYR	RTANF_CFLG	ETANF_COVTYP	TTANF_BRSN	TTANF_ERSN
Adult Daughter (103)											
1	1	1	1	4	103	190	2	missing	3	4	5
2	1	1	1	4	103	190	2	missing	3	4	5
3	1	1	1	4	103	190	2	missing	3	4	5
4	1	1	1	4	103	190	2	missing	3	4	5
5	1	2	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
6	1	2	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
7	1	2	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
8	1	2	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
9	1	2	9	12	103	90	missing	3	1	6	missing
10	1	2	9	12	103	90	missing	3	1	6	missing
11	1	2	9	12	103	90	missing	3	1	6	missing
12	1	2	9	12	103	90	missing	3	1	6	missing
Grandson (104)											
1	1	1	missing	missing	103	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
2	1	1	missing	missing	103	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
3	1	1	missing	missing	103	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
4	1	1	missing	missing	103	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
5	1	2	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
6	1	2	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
7	1	2	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
8	1	2	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
9	1	1	missing	missing	103	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
10	1	1	missing	missing	103	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
11	1	1	missing	missing	103	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing
12	1	1	missing	missing	103	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing	missing

* RTANF_YRYN has the same value in each month because it is a reference period indicator.

3.7 Geography

Geographic data released on SIPP's public-use file include state and metropolitan/nonmetropolitan status variables. The SIPP sample is designed to be representative at the state level; however, the coefficient of variation should be calculated for any state-level estimate to determine if the estimate is reliable.

The SIPP sample is not designed to produce metropolitan-area-level (MSA-level) estimates, but MSA identifiers and additional geographic data are collected and accessible at Census Research Data Centers (RDCs) for researchers with Special Sworn Status and approved research projects.

Identifying States in 2025 SIPP

The variables TEHC_ST and TST_INTV, which are based on the Federal Information Processing Standards (FIPS) State Codes, identify the 50 states and District of Columbia. TST_INTV identifies the state of residence for the interview month, while TEHC_ST identifies the state for each of a respondent's residences during the reference period. TEHC_ST also identifies the world region for respondents who lived outside of the United States at some point during the reference year.

Identifying Metropolitan Areas in 2025 SIPP

The variables TEHC_METRO and TMETRO_INTV identify whether a household is located in a metropolitan or non-metropolitan area. TMETRO_INTV identifies the metropolitan status for the interview month residence, while TEHC_METRO identifies the metropolitan status for each of a respondent's residences during the reference period. TEHC_METRO and TMETRO_INTV have three categories: "metro," "non-metro," and "not identified." To protect respondent confidentiality, metro or non-metro areas with a population below 250,000 are recoded to "not identified." No other reassignment is done for this variable. See Section 3.2.1 for more details on how the topcoding for TEHC_METRO and TMETRO_INTV is implemented.

The Census Bureau's *Metropolitan and Micropolitan* webpage at <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/metro-micro/about.html> provides more detail about metropolitan area delineations over time.

4 Topics in the 2025 SIPP Public-Use Microdata

This chapter details topical content available in the 2025 SIPP public-use data. Much of the 2025 SIPP content and guidance overlaps with 2024 SIPP data. Significant differences, if present, are noted within each topic. For guidance on historical SIPP data, please see the applicable Users' Guide available at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/guidance/users-guide.html.

In addition to comprehensive information about the income and program participation of individuals and households, SIPP collects data on many facets of economic well-being. SIPP also collects extensive information concerning family dynamics, educational attainment, health insurance, disability, childcare, and food security. Altogether, SIPP data can put income, program reciprocity, and program eligibility into the household, family, and social context.

The terms *household-level*, *person-level*, *person-month-level*, and *spell-level* are used throughout this chapter to indicate a variable's record level. Values for **household-level variables** vary only between households; each household member receives the same value on all person-month records. **Person-level variables** vary only between people, and all person-month records for a person-level variable receive the same value. **Person-month-level variables** can vary from month-to-month; all persons can have a different value for each of their person-month records. **Spell-level variables** have values that remain constant within a "spell" of participation, coverage, or receipt of EHC-based topics (e.g., jobs, health insurance, SSI, and TANF).

Definitions for other terms used in this chapter – such as *coverage unit*, *reference person*, and *continuation flag* – are available in the Glossary section of this guide.

4.1 Demographics

4.1.1 Basic Demographics

SIPP collects basic demographic information about the whole household during each interview, including each person's date of birth, sex (ESEX), race, and Hispanic origin. Age variables include each individual's birth year (TDOB_BYEAR) and month (EDOB_BMONTH), as well as their age at the time of the interview (TAGE) and at each of the 12 months of the reference period (TAGE_EHC). Published race variables include a variable with categories for "White alone," "Black alone," "Asian alone," and "Residual" (ERACE), and a more detailed race variable (TRACE). Hispanic origin variables include a variable that indicates if a respondent is of Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin (EORIGIN), as well as a detailed Hispanic origin variable (EHISPAN).

Level of information the Basic Demographics data provide

The Basic Demographics variables are person-level variables, except for TAGE_EHC, which is a person-month variable.

4.1.2 Educational Enrollment

The Educational Enrollment section collects information from respondents aged 3 or older on the months of enrollment, grade, type, full-time or part-time status, credential worked toward, and whether a grade was repeated. This information is important because school enrollment is related to labor force participation for adults and can be an outcome measure for children.

Level of information the Educational Enrollment data provide

Most Educational Enrollment variables provide person-month information. All information should be consistent within the same spell of enrollment, and variables EEDGREP and EEDENROLL do not vary across months.

Other concepts related to the Educational Enrollment data

Educational Enrollment questions refer to school enrollment during the individual months of the reference year. “Enrollment spell” refers to a length of consecutive month(s) during which the respondent is continuously enrolled.

4.1.3 Educational Attainment and Nondegree Credentials

The Educational Attainment content (EEDUC and RGED) collects information for adults aged 15 and older about an individual’s highest level of educational attainment. There is also information on whether high school graduates got their diplomas by graduating from high school or by passing a GED exam.

The Nondegree Credentials content (EPROCERT, EWHOCERT, and ECERT) includes data on nondegree, or “alternative,” credentials for adults aged 18 and older or those who have at least a high school diploma or equivalent. This section includes information on whether respondents have a professional certification, state or industry license, and/or educational certificate. Respondents who report a professional certification or license also report the type of institution that awarded the credential.

This information is important because it provides details on the education, training, qualifications, and skill development of the adult population. Educational attainment and nondegree credentials are important outcomes in general and can also be used to show how education and credentialing affect a variety of socioeconomic outcomes.

Level of information the Educational Attainment and Nondegree Credentials data provide

All Educational Attainment and Nondegree Credentials items are person-level items. The information on educational attainment and nondegree credentials can be used with other SIPP topics such as labor force

involvement to examine how attainment and credentialing are related to a variety of socioeconomic outcomes and differ across subgroups of the population.

Additional guidance for using Educational Attainment data

The educational attainment and GED questions for all household members are asked of the household respondent in the Demographics section. The nondegree credentials questions related to professional certifications, licenses, and educational certificates are part of each person's interview.

Development and definition of Nondegree Credentials

The measures of credentials were developed by the Federal Interagency Working Group on Expanded Measures of Enrollment and Attainment (GEMEnA), a group tasked with improving federal data collection on education, credentials, and job training. After an extensive development process, the GEMEnA group defined the concepts accordingly:

Professional certification: A credential awarded by a certification body based on an individual demonstrating through an examination process that he or she has acquired the designated knowledge, skills, and abilities to perform a specific job. The examination can be written, oral, or performance based. Certification is a time-limited credential that is renewed through a recertification process.

License: A credential awarded by a licensing agency based on pre-determined criteria. The criteria may include some combination of degree attainment, certifications, educational certificates, assessment, apprenticeship programs, or work experience. Licenses are time-limited and must be renewed periodically.

Educational certificate: A credential awarded by an educational institution based on completion of all requirements for a program of study, including coursework and tests or other performance evaluations. Certificates are typically awarded for life (like a degree). Certificates of attendance or participation in short-term training (e.g., one-day) are not counted as educational certificates.

4.1.4 Family and Household Relationships

SIPP provides variables for everyone's relationship to the household reference person (the person who owns or rents the home at interview month), parent identification variables ('parent pointers' that identify the coresident parents of the record holder), and parent type (whether biological, adoptive, or step).

The relationship of everyone in the household to everyone else at each month is not directly collected; however, information collected in other questions is used to create variables that identify household relationships for every month of the reference period, allowing for a more nuanced study of changing household relationships over time. These monthly relationship variables are used as the basis for family and household recodes.

SIPP data also indicate spousal and cohabiting relationships that do not include the interview month household's reference person throughout all months. Family and household information allows for the

exploration of differences in poverty status, program participation, work status, etc., by household composition. Below is detailed information regarding these topics.

Relationship to reference person

Since SIPP's 2014 Panel, the relationship to reference person question has included 18 categories. Relationship to reference person is a person-level variable (ERELRPE) collected in the front of the instrument with other basic demographic information. This question is only asked relative to the reference person, who is someone in whose name the home at interview month is being rented or is owned. Although more than one person may have been reported as homeowner or renter, there is only one reference person⁸. If the first person on the household roster is selected as an owner or renter, they will be assigned as the reference person. If the first person on the household roster is not an owner or renter, the first person listed as an owner or renter is assigned as the reference person.

Parent and child identification variables (pointers)

Respondents are asked if each person in the household has a parent present at the time of interview. If they answer yes, they are asked if this person has a second parent present. If a parent is reported, the type of relationship to that parent (biological, step, or adoptive) is determined. Moving from asking about mothers and fathers to parents allows us to capture two-parent families in same-sex relationships rather than showing these families as single-parent families. This improves our ability to collect information about diverse family types without losing previously collected information. Parent pointers are available for people of all ages. The 'pointer' variable contains the person number of the household member identified as the record holder's parent.

Interview month parent pointers (EPNPAR1, EPNPAR2) and parent type (EPAR1TYP, EPAR2TYP) are person-level variables on the child's record. The sex of adults identified as parents in the parent pointers is provided as a person-level recode on the child's record (RPAR1SEX, RPAR2SEX). Mothers and fathers can be identified by using parent pointers in conjunction with recodes of the sex of parent(s).

In addition, monthly versions of parent pointers (RPNPAR1_EHC, RPNPAR2_EHC), parent type variables (RPAR1TYP_EHC, RPAR2TYP_EHC), and parent sex variables (RPAR1SEX_EHC, RPAR2SEX_EHC) are available as recodes based on monthly relationships (see below), interview month parent pointers, residence information, and spouse pointers.

On the parent's record, users will find child pointers (RPNCHILD1-RPNCHILD19) and child type (RCHTYP1-RCHTYP19), which are recodes of interview month parent pointers and parent type. The

⁸ In rare instances, there are multiple reference persons within a single EHRESIDENCID. In these cases, the household members within each EHRESIDENCID should be split into separate households according to their matching SHHADID values.

vector of child pointers contains a list of the person number(s) of the record holder's children who are present in the household during the interview month.

Monthly relationship of everyone in the household

For every month of the reference period, SIPP includes a monthly (person-month) recode of the relationship of each respondent in the household at that month to every other person in the household at that month (RREL1-RREL30). Each person with a record on the file has a set of variables that show how the other household members are related to the record holder during the months they lived together. A combination of residence ID, relationship to reference person, marital status, spouse pointers, cohabiting partner pointers, parent pointers, parent type (biological, step, or adoptive), relationships to Type-2 people, and biological child lists from the fertility history section are used to code monthly relationships.

A separate vector of variables (RREL_PNUM1-RREL_PNUM30) indicates the person number of the household member to which the value in the RREL variable applies. For example, RREL1 indicates the relationship between the record holder and the household member whose person number appears in RREL_PNUM1. A RREL value of 99 is associated with the record holder's person number indicating that it is the relationship of the record holder to themselves. All other monthly relationships are reciprocal; for example, a grandparent and grandchild will both have an 8 as their relationship to one another (grandparent/grandchild). The 'pointer' variables contain the person number of the record holder's parent, spouse, or cohabiting partner. Parent pointers must be used in conjunction with age variables to determine which person is the grandparent and which is the grandchild. Parent pointers and age are both available at the person-month-level.

For more information about residence ID, see the Residence section (Section 4.1.11). For more information about person-level marital status and spouse pointers, see the Marital Status section (Section 4.1.7). For more information on marital history, monthly marital status, and cohabiting partner pointers, see the Marital History section (Section 4.1.8). See the Fertility content (Section 4.1.5) for further information about the biological child lists.

Household and family recodes

SIPP has a recoded household-level variable for the number of people in the household (RHNUMPER) at a given month. There are additional monthly household recodes, including the number of people in the household who are 65 years and over (RHNUM65OVER) and the number of people in the household who are under 18 years old (RHNUMU18). Each of these variables has two versions: one counting only interviewed household members and one counting interviewed household members and Type-2 people (persons living in the household at that month, but not at the time of interview) which have the suffix "WT2" added at the end of the variable name (e.g., RHNUMPERWT2).

The family recodes are monthly recodes and include an index variable that reflects the number of the family in which a person is included (RFAMNUM), a family type variable (married couple; female householder, no spouse present; or male householder, no spouse present - RFAMKIND), the person number of the family reference person (RFAMREF), and the number of people in a family

(RFPERSONS), and number of related people under 18 years in a family (RFRELU18). Because the SIPP does not collect a ‘reference person’ for each month of the reference period, family recodes do not have a reference person available to define a primary family. Instead, all people in the household at any given month are assigned to a family, and each family is assigned a family reference person. As with the household recodes, there are two sets of family recodes: one that includes only interviewed family members and one that includes interviewed family members and Type-2 people who are related to those family members and are present that month, which have the suffix “WT2” added at the end of the variable name (e.g., RFAMNUMWT2).

Level of information the Family and Household Relationships data provide

Relationship to the household respondent, child pointers, and child type are person-level variables only and are based on interview month information. Parent pointers, parent type variables, and parent sex variables are available at both the person-level and person-month-level. Relationships of everyone in the household as well as household and family recode variables are available at the person-month-level.

4.1.5 Fertility

The SIPP instrument asks for complete fertility histories from all respondents aged 15 years and older, including:

- The total number of children ever born/fathered (TCEB)
- The month and year of birth for each child for up to 20 births (TCBYR_1-TCBYR_20; NOTE: The public-use file only releases year of birth and caps the maximum number of births based on current disclosure protection guidelines. Month of birth is not released on the public-use file)
- A direct question about multiple partner fertility (EMPF), asked of all adults with more than one child
- Whether they are a grandparent (EGRNDPR)

Based on this information, additional recode variables are created for other important concepts related to fertility, including:

- Age at first birth (TAGE_FB)
- Whether their current union (married or cohabiting) is a childbearing one (RCB_UNION)
- Number of childbearing unions (TNUM_CBU)

Level of information the Fertility data provide

Fertility data are available at the person level. For instance, all respondents aged 15 years or older have a TCEB value indicating the number of children they have given birth to/fathered, if any. RCB_UNION indicates whether the respondent’s current union is a childbearing one and is included on both partners’ records with a value of 1 if the couple share at least one child.

Additional guidance for using Fertility data

The public-use file also includes a parent screener variable (EPAR_SCRNR), which is asked in the beginning of the survey and before the Fertility questions. Individuals who are labeled as parents in this variable may be parents of biological, step, or adopted children. The remaining Fertility questions are only asked in reference to biological children. Therefore, a person may have an affirmative value in the parent screener variable but have zero children ever born (TCEB).

The Fertility questions are collected in the back end of the survey, after Assets and Disability, but before any of the Child Care or Child Well-Being questions. Household relationships, demographics, marital history, and child well-being are other topics in the SIPP with direct ties to the fertility content. As fertility and the timing of family formation are key predictors of economic well-being, fertility also has important implications for employment and social program use.

4.1.6 Language

Language content includes information on whether people age 5 and older speak a language other than English at home. For people who speak a language other than English at home, there is additional information on what language they speak and how well they speak English. The data file also contains a recode variable that indicates whether households are limited-English speaking, defined as households in which no one age 14 or older speaks English exclusively at home, or in which no one speaks English “very well.”

The content is important because language use and English ability are indicators of possible membership in a community with certain resources, while lack of English-speaking ability can sometimes be a barrier to accessing public services or educational and job opportunities. Additionally, language data allow researchers and policymakers to examine the association between English language proficiency and important socioeconomic outcomes, as well as to obtain basic statistics on language use and ability of the U.S. population.

Level of information the Language data provide

The Language data are provided as person-level variables.

Additional guidance for using Language data

If the interview is conducted in a language other than English, the household respondent is asked if anyone in the household other than the respondent speaks a language other than English at home. If the interview is conducted in English, the household respondent is asked whether anyone speaks a language other than English at home.

RLNGISOL is a variable indicating whether the respondent lives in a limited-English-speaking household. It is set to 1 for households in which there is no one 14 years or older who either (a) speaks only English at home or (b) speaks a language other than English at home but also speaks English “very well.” Otherwise, it is set to 2, indicating that the household is not a limited-English-speaking household. The language content can be used to describe the languages spoken in the United States and to examine

how language affects various outcomes. It can also be used to explore whether people who speak a language other than English at home differ from English-only speakers across a variety of socioeconomic outcomes.

Other concepts related to the Language data

Limited English-Speaking Households: No one in the household age 14 or older speaks English only or speaks English “very well” (RLNGISOL).

4.1.7 Marital Status

Marital status at time of interview is reported in the variable EMS and is collected for every person aged 15 years and older living in the household during the interview month. Values for this variable include never married; married, spouse present; married, spouse absent; widowed; separated; and divorced. Married, spouse absent includes those who report being married, but whose spouse is not present in the household. This includes a variety of situations, such as a wife whose husband is stationed outside the U.S. on active military duty, or a husband whose wife is living in a long-term care facility. For household members who are or have been married, SIPP also collects the identification of the spouse in the household (EPNSPOUSE).

Level of information the Marital Status data provide

Current marital status and spouse pointer are person-level variables.

Other concepts related to the Marital Status data

For information about marital history, monthly marital status, and cohabitating partner pointers, see the Marital History section, (Section 4.1.8).

4.1.8 Marital History

The marital history information collected in SIPP is more detailed than the information collected in other Census Bureau surveys. It can be used in conjunction with other content in the survey such as employment, education, or poverty, as well as to examine changes in household composition over time.

Marital history is reported in the recoded variable EMARPATH, which indicates the detailed marital events experienced by adults aged 15 years and older who have either been married once and are not currently married, or who have been married two or more times. For example, an EMARPATH of 7 indicates that a person has been married two times, their first marriage ended in divorce, and they are currently divorced. Two groups of adults do not have a value for this variable: those who never married and those married once, who are still married. The SIPP also collects additional information on marital history when applicable:

- Number of times married (EXMAR)
- How the first and second marriage ended (widowhood or divorce – EWIDIV1, EWIDIV2)
- Whether the person has ever been widowed or divorced (EVERWID, EVERDIV)

- The year of the first, second, and third or most recent marriage (TMAR1_YR, TMAR2_YR, TMAR3_YR)
- The year of the first, second, and third or most recent separation (TSEP1_YR, TSEP2_YR, TSEP3_YR)
- The year of the first, second, and third or most recent marriage ended (TEND1_YR, TEND2_YR, TEND3_YR)

If a respondent has been married four times, they are asked about their first, second, and fourth marriages. Information on their third marriage is not collected.

Marital status *changes* during the reference period are collected in the EHC for each respondent. Up to three spells of marital status can be recorded per person. All adults aged 15 years and older have a monthly marital status (EMS_EHC). Additionally, SIPP collects data to identify respondents' coresident spouses and partners, namely:

- Respondents married during any month, and living with their spouse, have a spouse pointer for that month indicating the person number of their spouse (EPNSPOUS_EHC).
- Respondents who do not have a spouse present are asked whether they have a boyfriend, girlfriend, or partner in the household and, if yes, they can identify their cohabiting partner, whose person number is located in the 'pointer' variable (EPNCOHAB_EHC at the monthly level; EPNCOHAB if the boyfriend, girlfriend, or partner was present at interview month). Only one cohabiting partnership can be recorded for each marital history spell.

Level of information the Marital History data provide

Number of times married; how the first two marriages ended; ever widowed; ever divorced; marital history; and year of each marital event for the first, second, and third or most recent marriages are all person-level variables. Monthly marital status and monthly spouse pointer are available at the person-month-level. Cohabiting partner pointers are available at both the person-level and person-month-level.

Other concepts related to the Marital History data

The SIPP data also includes a recoded RSSMC variable which indicates whether adults who are currently married, spouse present are in a same-sex marriage or opposite-sex marriage.

For information about person-level marital status and spouse pointer, see the Marital Status section (Section 4.1.7).

4.1.9 Nativity, Citizenship, and Parent Nativity

The Nativity and Citizenship questions are located in the Demographics section and are asked of the reference person about everyone in the household. The Parent Nativity questions are located in the Parent section of the survey and are asked of all respondents whose biological parent(s) is/are not present in the household. Questions include:

- Whether a respondent was born in the United States

- If so, state of birth
- Nativity status and country of origin for the respondent's biological parents (asked of each respondent)

For foreign-born respondents:

- Country of birth
- Citizenship status
- How the respondent became a citizen
- Immigration status on arrival
- Year of entry

Level of information the Nativity, Citizenship, and Parent Nativity data provide

All nativity and citizenship questions are collected at the person level. Questions on parents' nativity status can be used to calculate generational status of respondents.

Additional guidance for using Nativity, Citizenship, and Parent Nativity data

Nativity and Citizenship are asked of the reference person for every person in the household in the demographics section. Biological mother's and biological father's birth in the U.S. and country of birth are asked during the back of the survey for each respondent whose biological parent(s) are not present in the household.

4.1.10 Parent Mortality

Respondents who do not have their biological mother/father in the household are asked the parent mortality questions, including:

- Whether a respondent's biological mother/father is still alive (EBMOM, EBDAD)
- If a parent is deceased, the respondent's age in single years when that parent died (TBMOMDODRAGE, TBDADDODRAGE)
- If a parent is deceased and if the respondent did not provide an age at the time of that parent's death, they are asked whether they were less than 19 years old (a child) or older (an adult) at the time of death (EBMOMDODLT19, EBDADDODLT19)

Level of information the Parent Mortality data provide

All parent mortality questions reflect status at the time of interview and are person-level variables.

Additional guidance for using Parent Mortality data

These items are asked during the Parent section at the back end of the survey of each respondent whose biological parent(s) is/are not present in the household. For respondents whose biological parent(s) is/are present in the household, the parent(s) is/are marked as still alive. Thus, the parent mortality variables on the released file contain information on the biological parents of all respondents.

Users should be aware that TBMOMDODRAGE and TBDADDODRAGE allow for unknown values (999). These are assigned when there is no available information to assign a respondent's age at the time of parental death. Similarly, EBMOMDODLT19 and EBDADDODLT19 also allow for unknown values (3). These are assigned when there is no available information to assign a respondent's child/adult status at the time of parental death.

4.1.11 Residence

The Residence section collects information about an individual's residence history from the start of the reference year through the interview month, including:

- Where the respondent lived
- How long the respondent lived at the residence
- Whom the respondent lived with
- Why the respondent moved to the residence
- Tenure status
- Type of living quarters
- Receipt of housing assistance

As with other data collected in the EHC, residence information is collected in reverse chronological order. That is, each respondent's residence history is collected beginning with the most current residence and working backward through the reference period. The instrument collects information on up to five residences at which the respondent lived during the reference year.

For the residence spell that includes January of the reference period, information on the year and month the respondent moved to the residence is collected along with the tenure status of the residence the respondent lived in prior to the residence that includes January of the reference period.

The instrument stores address information for each new residence entered within a wave. This information is then available for other respondents to select when reporting residence histories, or for reports of multiple residence spells at the same address. This improves the reliability and consistency of the reported address information. For each residence spell, respondents report whom they lived with. The tenure status, type of living quarters, housing assistance receipt, and reason for move information may vary across spells.

In some instances where respondents in a household report living together for an entire reference period, residence history information for the reference period is copied from the first respondent to subsequent respondents who lived with the first respondent. The exception is when respondents report living together during January of the reference month. In these situations, each respondent is asked the month and year of move and the reason for move to the residence, as these may vary across respondents. When respondents do not report living together for the entire reference period, each respondent's residence history information is reported separately.

The residences where respondents lived are assigned unique residence IDs (ERESIDENCEID, unique within SSUID), which can be used to identify households across the reference year and across panels. Residence IDs are assigned in processing and may not correspond to the chronological ordering of residences for any given respondent. The address information can be fed back in subsequent waves and available for respondents to select.

To help data users, recode variables are constructed, including a monthly mover flag and geographic recodes (such as region of residence and metropolitan status). The monthly mover flag (TMOVER) allows data users to easily identify when a respondent changed residences and the type of move (for example, within the same county, to a new county in the same state, or to a new state).

Level of information the Residence data provide

Residence data are collected at the spell level in the EHC and are provided to data users in person-month format. Characteristics of the interview address (region, state, metropolitan status, tenure, and receipt of housing subsidies) are available as household-level variables. This information is also provided as person-month variables for each residence during the reference year.

Additional guidance for using Residence data

All residence information is available at a monthly level. The ERH_BMONTH and ERH_EMONTH variables indicate the beginning and ending months of the residence spell (months beyond reference period are capped at 12). Geographic information for each residence, including region, state of residence, and metropolitan status, are available at a monthly level. Type of living quarters, tenure, rent subsidy, and housing voucher receipt are available for each residence at a monthly level.

The mover flag (TMOVER) identifies when a respondent changes residences and the type of move, while the reason for move (EEHC_WHY) is collected for each residence during the reference period.

Several variables can be used to identify if the respondent moved during the reference period, the month of the move, and the type of move. These variables include:

- ERESIDENCEID - identifies unique households within an original sample unit. A change in ERESIDENCEID from one month to the next indicates a change in residences.
- ERH_BMONTH - the beginning month of the residence spell.
- ERH_EMONTH - the end month of the residence spell.
- TMOVER – a mover flag that indicates if the respondent moved during a given month and the type of move. The categories of TMOVER are:
 1. Same house in the U.S., non-mover
 2. Different house in the U.S., same state and county
 3. Different house in the U.S., same state, different county
 4. Different house in the U.S., different state in the Northeast
 5. Different house in the U.S., different state in the Midwest
 6. Different house in the U.S., different state in the South
 7. Different house in the U.S., different state in the West

For moves that occurred during January of the reference year of the first wave the respondent was interviewed, or moves that are not captured in the survey reference period, the year (TEHC_MVYR) and month (EEHC_MVMO) of move are collected, but not the type of move. In waves 2+, returning sample members will have valid data on TMOVER for January of the reference year, as the edited December data from the previous wave are used to create the TMOVER variable. New respondents in wave 2+ (and all respondents in wave 1) will be blank on TMOVER for January of the reference year.

The variables TEHC_MVYR, EEHC_MVMO, ERH_BMONTH, and ERH_EMONTH are used to create a monthly duration of residence variable (TRES DUR).

The residence data are edited for consistency so that ERESIDENCEID is used in the creation of TRES DUR and TMOVER, and TRES DUR is used in the creation of TMOVER. In most instances, these variables will provide consistent information when identifying a move. However, in a small number of cases a change in ERESIDENCEID from one month to another may not be reflected on TMOVER and TRES DUR. In these instances, a respondent has changed residences from one month to another but reports always living at the residence he or she has moved to on the reason for move variable (EEHC_WHY). Because respondents' own definitions of what constitutes a move may differ from how the SIPP survey identifies a move, the Census Bureau has chosen to leave these apparent inconsistencies in the data.

Other concepts related to the Residence data

Residence ID: Identifies unique households within a given original sample unit (ERESIDENCEID).

Mover flag: Identifies when a respondent changed residences and whether the move was within the same county, to a new county in the same state, or to a new state (TMOVER). In other words, the variable flags the first month in a new residence.

4.1.12 Veteran Status

The Veteran Status content collects information on respondents aged 17 or older about whether they have ever served in the United States Armed Forces and their periods of service.

Respondents are asked whether they have ever served on active duty in the United States Armed Forces. Veterans are men and women who have served (even for a short time), but are not currently serving, on active duty in the U.S. Army, Navy, Air Force, Marine Corps, or Coast Guard, or who served in the U.S. Merchant Marine during World War II.

Respondents who indicated that they ever served on active duty in the past or were currently on active duty are asked to indicate the period or periods in which they served, even if just for part of the period. The periods were determined by the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) and generally distinguish veterans who served during wartime periods from those whose only service was during peacetime. These service periods include:

- September 2001 to present
- August 1990 to August 2001 (including Persian Gulf War)

- May 1975 to July 1990
- Vietnam Era (August 1964 to April 1975)
- February 1955 to July 1964
- Korean War (July 1950 to January 1955)
- January 1947 to June 1950
- World War II (December 1941 to December 1946) or earlier (November 1941 or earlier)

Level of information the Veterans data provide

The Veterans data are available at the person level, except for EAF_HHLD, which is a household-level variable.

4.2 Assets, Employment, and Earnings

4.2.1 Assets

The Assets content provides detailed information on assets and liabilities for individuals and households. Three types of data are collected:

1. Asset ownership during the reference period, including type of ownership (joint ownership and/or individual ownership).
2. Value of assets and any debts held against these assets as of the last day of the reference period.
3. Income received from each asset during the reference period.

Most questions are asked of all household members who were aged 15 years and older as of December of the reference year (referred to as person-level variables), while a few questions are asked only of the household reference person (referred to as household-level variables).

The Assets content produces a wide range of national estimates for wealth and debt, including the distribution of net worth. Additionally, person-level and household-level wealth and income can be used to model eligibility for various government programs. The level of detail within SIPP also provides data users the flexibility to construct their own units of analysis (individuals, families, households, etc.) and study how changes in household structure and other conditions affect wealth over time.

Table 4-1 ~~Table 4-1~~ lists topics covered within the Assets content, as well as the microdata abbreviation used for naming the associated variables. Indicators for income questions and type of ownership questions (where applicable) are included as well. Additionally, starting with the 2018 SIPP, many asset variables are imputed with statistical model-based imputation, as described in Section 6.2.1 of this Users' Guide. The table also lists which variables were imputed using model-based-imputation.

TABLE 4-1. TOPICS COVERED IN THE 2025 SIPP ASSETS CONTENT

Topic	Microdata abbreviation	Level of data	Income questions	Type of ownership questions	Model-based imputation of ownership	Model-based imputation of value
<u>ASSETS*</u>						
<i>Retirement Accounts</i>						
IRA and Keogh accounts	IRAKEO	Person	§		✓	✓
401(k), 403(b), and Thrift Savings Plan accounts	THR401	Person	§		✓	✓
Defined benefit or cash balance plan	PENSION	Person	§		✓	
<i>Interest-Earning Assets</i>						
Government securities	GOVS	Person	✓	✓	✓	
Checking accounts	CHK	Person	✓	✓	✓	
Savings accounts	SAV	Person	✓	✓	✓	
Money market accounts or funds	MM	Person	✓	✓	✓	
Certificates of deposit	CD	Person	✓	✓	✓	
Municipal and corporate bonds	MCBD	Person	✓	✓	✓	
Educational savings accounts	ESAV	Household				
<i>Other Income-Generating Assets</i>						
Stocks	ST	Person	✓	✓	✓	
Mutual funds	MF	Person	✓	✓	✓	
Rental property	RP	Person	✓	✓	✓	
Annuities	ANN	Person	✓		‡	
Trusts	TR	Person	✓		‡	
<i>Other Assets</i>						
Other real estate	RE	Person		✓	✓	
Businesses owned as a job	BSJ(1-7)	Person		†	✓	
Businesses owned as an investment only	BSI(1-3)	Person			✓	
Life insurance policies	LIFE	Person			✓	
Primary residence (for non-mobile homes)	PR	Household		†		
Primary residence (for mobile homes)	MH	Household		†		
Cars, trucks, and vans	VEH	Household		†		
Recreational vehicles	RECV	Household		†		
Other financial investments (such as coins, collectibles, jewelry, artwork, mortgages paid to	OINV	Person	✓		✓	

Topic	Microdata abbreviation	Level of data	Income questions	Type of ownership questions	Model-based imputation of ownership	Model-based imputation of value
him/her, other loans owed to him/her, and royalties)						
<u>LIABILITIES</u>						
<i>Debts Secured by Assets</i>						
Primary residence debt (for non-mobile homes)	PR	Household		†		
Primary residence debt (for mobile homes)	MH	Household		†		
Rental property debt	RP	Person		✓		
Other real estate debt	RE	Person		✓		
Vehicle debt	VEH	Household		†		
Recreational vehicle debt	RECV	Household		†		
Debt on businesses owned as a job	BSJ(1-7)	Person		†		
Debt on businesses owned as an investment only	BSI(1-3)	Person				
<i>Debts Not Secured by an Asset (Unsecured Debt)</i>						
Credit card debt and store bills	CC	Person		✓	✓	
Student loans and educational-related expenses	ED	Person		✓	✓	
Medical Debt	MED/MD	Person		✓	✓	
Other debt (includes loans obtained through a bank or credit union, money owed to private individuals, debt held against mutual funds or stocks)	OT	Person		✓	✓	
<u>ADDITIONAL TOPICS</u>						
Rent and mortgage payments	RENTMORT	Household				
Utility payments	UTILS	Household				

* All reported assets are those held outside of other pooled assets. For example, reported mutual funds are those held outside of retirement accounts.

§ SIPP asks respondents who owned either a (1) 401(k), 403(b), or Thrift Savings plan, (2) Individual Retirement Account (IRA) or Keogh account, or (3) defined benefit or cash balance plan to report any income received from their account during the reference year. Section 4.5.3 provides additional detail on income received from 401(k)-style accounts or IRA/Keogh plans. Section 4.5.2 provides additional detail on pension income.

† Joint ownership can be inferred from the reported list of owners.

‡ SIPP uses model-based imputation to impute whether respondents owned any annuities, trusts, or both (ANNTR).

Asset variable names are designed to make it easier to identify related variables using consistent stems for topics and characteristics. For example, EOWN_CHK and TJSCHKVAL both refer to checking accounts. TJSCHKVAL and TJSSAVVAL both refer to the value of an account held jointly with a spouse as of the last day of the reference period (for a checking account and a savings account, respectively). [Figure 4-1](#) details the convention used to name variables within the section.

FIGURE 4-1. NAMING CONVENTIONS FOR ASSETS AND LIABILITIES VARIABLES

<u>Person-level assets and liabilities:</u>							
Ownership of asset or liability:	E	+	OWN_ (for assets) or DEBT_ (for liabilities)	+	Variable Abbreviation		
	E or T	+	Joint/Own Prefix	+	Variable Abbreviation	+	Characteristic
Details for asset or liability:	(T when variable is topcoded)		(JS, JO, or O , where applicable)		(such as THR401, SAV, CHK)		(INC for income, VAL for value, DEBTVAL for debt value, etc.)
<u>Household-level assets and liabilities:</u>							
Ownership of asset:	EOWN_	+	Variable Abbreviation				
	E or T	+	Variable Abbreviation	+	Asset Number	+	Characteristic
Details for asset: (includes details for liabilities)	(T when variable is topcoded)		(such as VEH, PR, ESAV)		(when multiple assets of one type are reported)		(VAL for value, DEBTVAL for debt value, etc.)

Vehicle Value and Status Flag Assignment

In SIPP, respondents are asked to report the year, make, and model of their vehicles. Using this information, values are assigned from a dataset created by J.D. Power, which is one of the major providers of vehicle trade-in value data. For respondents who report a year, make, and model, the vehicle values are usually assigned a status flag value of 1. For respondents who provide slightly less usable vehicle information, such as reporting a year and make but not a model, or reporting a very new vehicle that doesn't have sufficient resale history, these car values are usually assigned a status flag of 5. This

indicates that their vehicle values involved more complex calculations, which may result in less accurate data than vehicles with a status flag of 1. For respondents who provided so little vehicle information that their values had to be imputed via hot-deck, their status flag is assigned a value of 2.

Respondent Burden Reduction

For person-level assets that can be owned jointly, the survey is designed to refrain from asking identical questions to spouses. This is to reduce respondent burden. The survey tailors question text to ensure that proper values are collected. For example, if a married couple owns an asset jointly with a non-household member, the first spouse is asked to report only “your and your spouse’s share” of an asset’s value, debt, and income. Then, the second spouse skips these questions. In editing, reported values are divided by two and copied to both spouses’ records. In all cases, both spouses are asked about individual ownership (ownership in own name).

Level of information the Assets data provide

Most asset questions are asked of all household members who were aged 15 years and older as of December of the reference year and are available as person-level variables. A few topics are collected at the household level, including educational savings accounts; primary residence (both mobile and non-mobile homes); cars, trucks, and vans; recreational vehicles; and rent, mortgage, and utilities payments.

Additional guidance for using Assets data

Asset Value, Debt, and Income

All asset and debt values are as of the last day of the reference period (December 31st of the preceding year). An asset value of zero means that either the value was zero or the asset was no longer owned as of the last day of the reference period. A debt value of zero means that the respondent did not hold the debt as of the last day of the reference period. Reported income is the total amount of income received between the first and last days of the reference period.

Educational Savings Accounts

The household reference person is asked whether anyone in the household was the owner or a beneficiary of an educational savings account. If so, the survey then collects detailed information on up to three accounts with the largest balances, including the owner and the beneficiary of each account and the value of each account as of the last day of the reference period. Only those educational savings accounts whose owner resides in the household are included in the calculations of net worth.

Recreational Vehicles

SIPP asks the household reference person whether anyone in the household owned recreational vehicles and, if so, the type. It then collects information on the owners of each vehicle, vehicle value, and vehicle debt as of the last day of the reference period. If two of the same type of recreational vehicle are owned (such as owning two motorcycles), characteristics for the second recreational vehicle of that type are put into the ‘other recreational vehicle’ variables.

Other concepts related to the Assets data

Net Worth and Wealth: Net worth, otherwise known as wealth, is the sum of asset values minus the sum of liabilities for a person or household.

Primary Residence: Primary residence is the residence at which household members live most of the time. In the SIPP Assets content, primary residence variables are split into *primary residence that is not a mobile home* and *primary residence that is a mobile home*. This is to capture differences between the two home types. In general, the SIPP collects information on the value of the home or mobile home, the number of mortgages or loans (if any) on the property, and additional details pertaining to each mortgage or loan (such as the interest rate, whether it is fixed or variable, and if the debt is for the site if it is a mobile home).

4.2.2 Commuting and Work Schedule

Commuting content covers the means of transportation to work, distance to work, travel time to work, mileage reimbursement, parking and toll expenses, additional commuting expenses, and other job-related expenses. Work Schedule content consists of days of the week worked, days of the week worked entirely at home, the start and end times of work, the type of schedule worked, and the reason for working a given schedule.

Commuting and Work Schedule data are collected at the spell level for each job the respondent reports in the EHC, for up to seven jobs for the entire calendar year. The data associated with a given job are copied to every monthly record for the specific job spell. As with other data in the EHC, Commuting and Work Schedule information is collected in reverse chronological order. That is, each respondent's information is collected and recorded beginning with the most current job.

The Commuting section begins by asking about the mode of transportation used to get to work (such as “drove own vehicle,” “bus,” “worked at home,” etc.). Subsequent Commuting questions are based on the specific mode(s) of transportation selected. If the respondent selects more than one mode of transportation (or more than two, if “worked at home” is also selected), then the respondent is asked to select their primary mode of transportation. If the respondent drove his or her own vehicle or a company car, the respondent is asked about one-way miles driven to work, miles reimbursed, and any daily expenses incurred for parking and tolls. If the respondent commuted using another mode (excluding “drove own vehicle,” “drove company vehicle,” and “worked at home”), he or she is asked about other daily commuting expenses. With the exception of those who only select “worked at home,” workers are asked the one-way travel time to work in minutes. Finally, workers who worked for an employer or had another work arrangement, excluding self-employment, are asked about any annual job-related expenses that are not already reported.

The Work Schedule section immediately follows the Commuting questions and begins by asking which days of the week the respondent worked for a given job, the start and end time of most workdays, and whether any days were worked entirely at home. If the respondent did work at home, he or she is asked to report the specific days worked at home. The section then asks all respondents who report a job about their type of work schedule and the reason for that work schedule.

Prior to the 2014 SIPP Panel, Commuting and Work Schedule data were collected in separate topical modules that were not asked during the same wave. Commuting data were collected for up to three jobs held during the reference month, while Work Schedule data were collected for up to two jobs held during the reference month.

Level of information the Commuting and Work Schedule data provide

Commuting and Work Schedule data are collected at the spell level in the EHC and are provided to data users in person-month format.

Additional guidance for using Commuting and Work Schedule data

Commuting and Work Schedule variables are available for each job spell held by a respondent and are edited in person-month format.

Place of work geography is collected as an address for each job spell but is not released to the public. Instead, place of work is recoded to characterize the geographic relationship between work and home.

Respondents can mark multiple modes of transportation. Among respondents who indicate multiple modes, a follow-up question identifies the primary mode of transportation. Respondents have the option of selecting “worked at home” as a mode of transportation.

Questions about commuting distance and time both refer to the daily one-way trip. Commuting distance is collected in miles, and commuting time is collected in minutes.

Multiple questions measure expenses. Commuters who drove are asked how many of the daily one-way miles driven to work were reimbursed by their employer and about parking or toll expenses incurred. Commuters who used other transportation modes are asked about the daily amount of other commuting expenses incurred. Workers who worked for an employer or had another work arrangement are asked about annual job-related expenses incurred.

4.2.3 Employment and Earnings

Changes in labor force status, earnings, or usual hours of employment can all impact eligibility for and receipt of benefits. The longitudinal nature of SIPP allows it to measure movements in and out of the labor force, movement between jobs, and changes in earnings, making the labor force data critical. The detailed weekly nature of the employment data also allows for observation of short duration spells of employment and non-employment.

SIPP collects information about an individual’s work history from the beginning of the reference year through the interview month, including:

- When a job was held
- Different types of employment earnings
- Employment and business characteristics
- Reasons the respondent did not hold a job

- Whether the respondent looked for work

The data are collected at a spell level, instead of the person-month format in which they ultimately appear. Most of the information about an employment or non-employment spell does not vary over the time it was held. This means that much of the information about a job spell will be copied to every monthly record in which the job was held. The exceptions are earnings sources that vary by month—bonuses, commissions, overtime, and tips—and recoded variables created in processing. In the 1990 to 2008 Panels, data were also collected at a spell level, but much of the information about a job spell was copied to every monthly record in the reference period, regardless of when that job was held.

For all of the variables regarding timing of an event about a job, the dates are collected in reverse chronological order to improve recall. However, on the output file the variables are available chronologically. Each respondent's jobs are collected beginning with the most current job, but on the data file they start with the first job held in the reference year and end with the current job. The respondent may hold multiple jobs concurrently.

The Employment section begins by asking whether the respondent currently works for pay. If not, it asks whether the respondent worked at all since January of the reference year. Basic information about the job, such as beginning and ending dates, the type of arrangement (job for employer, self-employed business, or other), and the reason for the job ending (when applicable) are collected first. The next questions are characteristics of the job/business such as industry, occupation, union status, the number of employees, and incorporation status.

For industry and occupation, respondents are asked to provide kind of business or industry, kind of work, and usual activities at work. Industry describes the kind of business conducted by a person's employing organization, or own business if self-employed. Occupation describes the kind of work the person does on the job. Questions administered by Census personnel are open-ended, and respondents' answers about industry and occupation are recorded verbatim. These responses are converted to standard codes by Census Bureau coding staff during processing.⁹

To account for changes in the labor force, the Census Bureau periodically revises the code lists used to classify industry and occupation in the SIPP and other surveys. As a result, data users interested in comparing industry and occupation over time in the SIPP should be aware that different code lists are used depending on the SIPP panel. For instance, the 2014 Panel uses the 2012 Census Industry Code List and the 2010 Census Occupation Code List, the 2023 SIPP uses the 2017 Census Industry Code List and the 2018 Census Occupation Code List, and the 2025 SIPP uses the 2022 Census Industry Code List and

⁹ For more information on how responses to the industry and occupation questions are coded, see the "General Overview of the Alphabetical Indexes of Industries and Occupations" page at <<https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/demo/guidance/industry-occupation/IOindexesoverview2024.pdf>>

the 2018 Census Occupation Code List.¹⁰ Because different code lists are used between SIPP panels, the data are not directly comparable unless conversion rates for industry and occupation are first applied.¹¹

Next, the survey asks about the types of earnings the respondent received (wages, salaries, commissions, tips, overtime, or bonuses) and the amounts earned. For wage or salary earnings, SIPP asks about current or most recent pay rate. Respondents can report up to two changes in pay rate over the job spell. For example, respondents may report changes in pay rate due to an annual raise or due to a movement in and out of part-time status. SIPP also ask for the number of hours worked per week, and similarly allow the respondent to report up to two changes in the number of hours worked. If earnings from commissions, tips, overtime, and bonuses are received every month, then SIPP collects the data at the spell level. For example, a waiter who received tips in every month of his job would report how much he usually earned in tips. If earnings from commissions, tips, overtime, and bonuses are *not* received every month, then SIPP collects the monthly amounts. For example, a real-estate agent who received commissions in only some months on the job would report the commissions she earned in each month. Finally, SIPP asks respondents to report any time they were away from the job without pay within the reported job spell.

The same questions are asked for each job, for up to seven jobs. This practice is consistent with SIPP's data collection practice from the 2014 Panel but differs from the 1984 to 2008 Panels. In the 1984 to 2008 Panels, SIPP only collected data for the first two jobs and sorted them by which one was held for more weeks or hours. Beginning with the 2014 Panel, a respondent that has reported multiple jobs, no "main" job is determined, and jobs are sorted on the public-use file by the earliest month they were held within the reference period.¹² Ties are broken by which job was reported first by the respondent. Similarly, moonlighting is no longer distinguished separately from any other job. Respondents with a main job and an additional part-time job will simply have two jobs listed concurrently. In addition, the classification of "contingent workers" is no longer used. The questions about whether a job has an "other" work arrangement and whether that arrangement was definite are still present, but they are applied to a particular job and not to an individual. In this way, SIPP can identify occasional or indefinite work that happens in addition to any main job held.

¹⁰ Additional information concerning the Census industry and occupation code lists, including documentation, crosswalks, and PUMS code lists are available online at <www.census.gov/topics/employment/industry-occupation/guidance/code-lists.html>.

¹¹ For additional information about the Code Lists, conversion rates, and comparability between panels, see <www.census.gov/topics/employment/industry-occupation/guidance/code-lists.html>.

¹² Starting with 2021 SIPP data, respondents are asked which employer is their primary employer. This question does not impact question path for respondents, rather the question was requested by the Social Security Administration for their Modeling Income in the Near-Term model.

If an individual held more than seven jobs during the reference period, some summary information is collected about the additional jobs. That information is included with the employment status recode and the earnings recodes (e.g., RMESR, TPEARN) but is not included on the edited file directly.

Jobs may be linked across waves using EJB(n)_JOBID. If a job was held at the time of the interview, then during the subsequent interview the respondent will answer questions about the job and earnings during the next wave. Some responses are carried forward (such as industry and work arrangement), while others are asked again (such as occupation and earnings).

Finally, during periods when respondents are not employed, SIPP collects information about their labor force status. This includes information about why they were not working: unpaid work in a related household member's family business or farm for 15 hours or more per week,¹³ time spent on layoff, and time spent looking for work. To facilitate consistency in reporting, if the respondent held a job during part of the year, the survey instrument will calculate gaps in employment automatically and collect information about each spell of non-work separately. Note that it is possible for separate spells of non-employment to be present in a single month if there is a short job spell within the month. Because the data are mapped to a person-month format, this can lead to multiple spells of non-employment being mapped to the same month. In these rare cases, identified by the variable ROVERLAPMN, the output file will have some characteristics from both spells of non-employment, and the timing variables will relate to the earlier spell.

For data users' convenience, the public-use data file provides both recoded variables and the components used to create those recodes. Examples of recoded variables include weekly (RWKESR1-5) and monthly employment status (RMESR), weekly wage and salary earnings (TJB(n)_WKSUM1-5), monthly total earnings from each job (TJB(n)_MSUM and TJB(n)_MSUMALT), monthly total earnings from all jobs (TPEARN and TPEARN_ALT), hours worked per week across all jobs (TWKHRS1-5), and monthly average hours worked per week across all jobs (TMWKHRS).

Level of information the Employment and Earnings data provide

All data related to employment status are available at the weekly level. All information about spells of employment and non-employment are included on the monthly records, and so monthly statistics can be calculated for all items.

Most Employment and Earnings data is provided at the person-month level. However, the job screener flags indicating the presence of job (n) during the reference year (EJB(n)_SCRNR) are person-level variables.

¹³ Questions about industry and occupation also are administered to unpaid family workers.

Additional guidance for using Employment and Earnings data

All of the labor force data are collected in the EHC. Each job gets its own line in the calendar, and periods of time not working are recorded on a separate line.

The Away Without Pay question specifies that the time away should be two weeks or more. However, if respondent reports only a single week away without pay, this information remains in the data.

Other concepts related to the Employment and Earnings data

Class of Worker: The ownership type of a respondent's employer, or the respondent's own business if self-employed. This variable identifies whether the respondent is self-employed, works in the private sector, or in government. The class of worker category is, in most cases, independent of industry and occupation.

Commission: A form of payment based on the amount of services the employee performed. For example, in sales positions, employees are often paid a percentage of the amount the customer paid or a percentage of the profit received by the firm. SIPP also asks respondents to include broader pay for unit of service when reporting commission amounts, which could include payments more commonly known as piece-rates. It could also include other types of pay schemes, such as painters who are paid by the room or truck drivers who are paid by the mile. Commission can be in lieu of wage and salary payments ("straight commission") or in addition to these payments.

Earnings: Remuneration (pay, wages) of a worker for services performed during a specific period of time. SIPP focuses on reporting monthly earnings, but for wage and salary earnings, data are available at the weekly level.

Employed Persons: Persons who report holding a job, business, or doing any other work for pay during the time period specified. This includes those who are temporarily absent from a job, whether the absence was paid or unpaid. Also included as employed are those who worked 15 hours or more unpaid in a related household member's family business or farm.

Full-Time Workers: Those who usually work 35 hours or more per week.

Industry: Describes the kind of business conducted by a person's employing organization, or own organization, if self-employed. Industry data are derived from questions about employer/business name, kind of industry.

Labor Force: The sum of those classified as either unemployed or employed.

Occupation: Describes the kind of work that the individual does on the job. Occupation data are derived from questions about kind of work and usual activities at work.

On Layoff: Persons are considered to be "on layoff" if they are currently unemployed due to slack work, shortages, or other business-related concerns (rather than personal misconduct). Persons on layoff who

are expecting to be recalled to their positions are considered unemployed whether they looked for work or not during the layoff.

Part-Time Workers: Those who usually work fewer than 35 hours per week.

Unemployed Persons: Persons who had no employment during the week and were either on layoff awaiting recall or looking for work.

Wages and Salaries: Payments per unit of time, generally not tied to performance. Wages are payment per hour of work; salaries are usually given as an annual amount. Both wages and salaries can be paid in several ways; SIPP allows them to be reported as weekly, biweekly, monthly, or twice per month, as well as reporting the hourly wage, annual salary, or gross annual amount. Any other pay schedules are asked to report monthly averages.

Weekly Hours: The number of hours the respondent usually (more than half the time) worked per week at their job during the period specified. Respondents whose hours vary are instructed to attempt to give an average amount.

4.2.4 Employer-Sponsored Retirement Accounts

SIPP has historically asked individuals to report whether they own any retirement accounts, which are categorized into (1) 401(k), 403(b), and Thrift Savings plans, (2) Individual Retirement Account (IRA) and Keogh accounts, and (3) defined benefit and cash balance plans.

Beginning with the 2021 interview, the SIPP asked a series of questions sponsored by the Social Security Administration (SSA) about employer-sponsored retirement and pension plan coverage. These questions are a revised subset of the questions included in the 2014 SSA Supplement and the Retirement and Pension Plan Coverage Topical Module that was administered as far back as the 1984 SIPP panel. These new questions offer insight into employer-sponsored retirement plan offers by current and prior employers or businesses (if self-employed), and amounts contributed to retirement accounts by the employer and the employee.

The SSA uses these data in their model-based simulations program Modeling Income in the Near Term (MINT) to make informed decisions about policies and benefits that affect people in or approaching retirement. MINT projects the economic and demographic condition of older Americans based on data collected in SIPP. Of specific importance to the SSA is the impact of legislative changes on the economic well-being of future beneficiaries, the ability of people to save for retirement, and eligibility for Old Age Survivors and Disability Insurance (OASDI) survivor and retirement benefits.

To collect data on employer-sponsored retirement accounts, the SIPP identifies respondents that had at least one job in December of the reference year. If the respondent had multiple jobs in December, they were asked to specify which job they considered to be their main employer or business.

If the respondent reported having at least one of the three types of retirement accounts, they were then asked whether each account was provided through their main employer. Through EMAIN_JOB, data

users can now use EJB(n)_JOBID (the longitudinally consistent job identifiers) to link employers and retirement benefits.

Next, respondents were asked whether they made contributions to their employer-sponsored retirement accounts, and if so, how much they contributed to the account during the reference year. Owners of employer-sponsored 401(k)-style accounts and IRA/Keogh plans were asked whether their employer made contributions, and if so, the amount contributed during the reference year. Respondents who held multiple accounts through their main employer were also asked to identify which of those accounts they considered to be their most important plan.

If the respondent was employed in December of the reference year but reported having no retirement accounts or none through their main employer, they were asked whether their employer or business offered any retirement plans to its employees. If the employer offered retirement plans, the SIPP then asked respondents whether they were included in such a plan.

The SIPP also identifies participation in pension and retirement plans received through previous employment, regardless of whether a retirement account was owned during the reference year.

Level of information the Employer-Sponsored Retirement Accounts data provide

Most questions are asked of all household members who were employed in at least one job or business as of December of the reference year and owned at least one retirement account. Some questions do not require the ownership of retirement accounts or that respondents were employed in December of the reference year. All variables are at the person level.

Some of the employer-sponsored retirement account variables are imputed with statistical model-based imputation. For a list of SRMI-imputed variables, refer to [Table 6-1](#) ~~Table 6-1~~ in Section 6.2.1.

Other concepts related to the employer-sponsored retirement accounts data

401(k), 403(b), and Thrift Savings plans: A 401(k) is a defined-contribution retirement plan that allows employees or self-employed individuals to set aside an amount of money each year for retirement. These plans are established through employers, and employers may offer matching contributions according to predetermined formulas. A 403(b) plan is a retirement plan for certain employees of public schools, employees of certain tax-exempt organizations, and certain ministries.

Cash Balance Plan: A cash balance plan, sometimes called a hybrid plan, is a defined benefit plan that specifies the promised benefit in terms of a stated account balance. The employer maintains this plan for the employee and chooses how to invest the funds that are in the account. Each year the employer deposits some money into the employee's account, along with an "interest portion" based on the amount of money currently in the account.

Defined Benefit Plans: In defined benefit plans, benefits are set at some level determined by a formula that often depends on an employee's salary history and length of service; and it is the company's responsibility to ensure that these benefits can be paid by contributing enough money to an account and managing investments. Sometimes the employee may make tax-deferred contributions to the plan.

Individual Retirement Accounts (IRAs): An IRA is a personal retirement plan which allows individuals to set aside an amount of money each year for retirement. Earnings on all amounts contributed to any IRA accumulate on a tax-deferred, and potentially tax-free, basis. These plans are often established by individuals but may also be established by employers and can include traditional IRAs, IRA annuities, SEP-IRA (Simplified Employee Pension Plan IRA), Roth IRA, Education IRA, SIMPLE IRA (Savings Incentive Match Plans for Employees), or self-directed retirement accounts (IRAs held by brokerages).

Keogh Plans: A Keogh (or H.R. 10 plan) refers to a qualified retirement plan maintained by a self-employed individual, either a sole proprietor or a partner. The self-employed individual may take a tax deduction for annual contributions to the plan made on behalf of the individual and on behalf of any eligible employees.

4.2.5 Parental Leave

The SIPP instrument collects parental leave information for all respondents aged 15-64 who have given birth to or fathered at least one child. All data are collected in reference to the birth of the respondent's first child. Available data for these respondents include:

- Whether they worked for pay at any time during the pregnancy (EPREGWORK)
- What type(s) of leave (if any) they used after the child was born and up to the time the baby was 12 weeks old (EBIRTHRSN1-10)
- How long (in weeks) prior to the birth they stopped working (TPREBIRTHINT)
- What type(s) of leave (if any) they used prior to the birth (EPREGRSN1-10)
- Whether they worked at any time after the birth (EBIRTHWORK)
- Age of the first child when the parent started working (TPSTBRTHINT)
- Unit of time used in reporting the age of the first child when the parent started working (EPSTBRTH_TP)

Universes for individual variables vary based on responses to prior items in the question sequence – for example, EBIRTHRSN1-10 are only in universe for those that worked for pay at any time during the pregnancy.

Level of information the Parental Leave data provide

Parental leave data are available at the person level for all respondents aged 15-64 who have given birth to or fathered at least one child (TCEB > 0).

Additional guidance for using Parental Leave data

The 2008 SIPP panel and other prior SIPP panels included questions regarding maternity leave. Parental leave questions were not included in the 2014 SIPP panel or in the 2018 SIPP. A revised question sequence was added to the survey beginning in the 2019 SIPP and was asked of both men and women. Starting in the 2020 SIPP, the age condition of 15-64 was added to the universe for respondents to receive parental leave questions to avoid recall bias. Additional changes were made to the question sequence in

2022. For more specific information on these changes, see the 2022 Users Guide at https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/methodology/2022_SIPP_Users_Guide_SEP23.pdf. There are few nationally representative sources that track use of parental leave in the United States, which does not have a federally guaranteed parental leave policy.

Parental Leave questions are only asked in reference to biological children. Parental Leave information is collected in the back end of the survey, after Assets, Disability, and Fertility, but before any of the Child Care or Child Well-Being questions.

4.3 Health and Well-Being

4.3.1 Adult Well-Being

SIPP collects information on certain characteristics of the household (e.g., are there cracks in the ceiling or walls or holes in the floor), surrounding neighborhood (e.g., is the neighborhood safe from crime), and food security (e.g., did the household ever not have enough food). These questions are intended to be answered by the household reference person; however, any household member aged 15 years and older may act as a proxy. These measures offer additional insight into living conditions that more common measures (such as income or wealth) are unable to provide.

Level of information the Adult Well-Being data provide

All Adult Well-Being questions are asked of the reference person and are available at the household level, meaning the answers provided by the household respondent apply to the entire household. These questions refer to conditions experienced during the reference year. For respondents who lived in multiple locations during this period, the questions refer to the residence in which the reference person lived for most of the year.

Additional guidance for using Adult Well-Being data

The information on adult well-being and food security can be used to examine differences in living conditions, financial hardships, and food security among the population. The food security component of these data includes six yes or no questions about the household's access to food, which are used to produce two recode variables. The recode variable RFOODR counts the number of these questions to which the reference person responded 'yes,' indicating a challenge to food security. The recode variable RFOODS categorizes these counts into three categories: low (0-1 yes responses), medium (2-4 yes responses), or high (5-6 yes responses) food insecurity.

4.3.2 Child Care

SIPP collects information on child care arrangements for children under the age of 15. The 2014 SIPP redesign minimizes respondent burden by streamlining the question format. Instead of running through a series of questions for each child, the questionnaire is organized by arrangement type. For example, respondents are asked whether they used grandparent care for any child; if so, they are then asked which

child used grandparent care. Data are edited to store child care data on the parent and the child's record. Additionally, information on the cost of child care, help to make child care payments and amount of work time lost due to child care problems is collected.

The Child Care and Child Well-Being sections of the survey utilize a concept labeled 'reference parent.' This is the person who will answer the questions about the children. In households in which both parents are present, the mother is the reference parent. If the mother is not available for an interview, the father of the child can give proxy responses for her. Priority is given to biological mothers, then other mothers, then biological fathers, and then other fathers. In single-parent families, the resident parent is the reference parent. If neither parent is in the household, the householder is the reference parent. The child care questions ask the respondent to identify the child care arrangements used while the reference parent was working, in school or training. If the reference parent was not working, in training or enrolled in school in the fall (September-December) of the reference year, then the respondent is asked to identify the child care arrangements used while the reference parent was otherwise busy.

Note that Child Care data from the 2014 Panel through 2025 SIPP are not comparable to data from the 2008 and prior SIPP panels due to changes in data collection and data processing. In 2008 and prior SIPP panels, the parent was asked about each form of child care used for each individual child in the household with the reference period being a typical week in the previous month. In addition, the parent was asked about the number of hours the child spent in each arrangement. Beginning with the 2014 SIPP Panel, for each type of child care arrangement, the reference parent was asked whether any child living in the household regularly used the reported type of care in a typical week in December of the reference year, which could be up to 6 months before the interview. If a parent had more than one child in universe for the reported type of child care, a follow up question asked them to identify all children using that arrangement. Beginning with the 2019 SIPP, the reference parent was asked about child care during the fall of the reference year, which could be up to 11 months before the interview.

Level of information the Child Care data provide

The data are edited so that data are available on the reference parent's record as well as the child's record. They are available at the person level. From the reference parent's record, measures can be extrapolated to the couple level, family level, household level, and national level. The child care questions are asked about care arrangements used in the Fall (September-December) of the reference year.

Additional guidance for using Child Care data

The child care variables prefixed with an "E" are the edited versions stored on the parent's record. Variables prefixed with an "R" are recoded versions that are stored on the child's record and are based on the original variable stored on the parent's record. The variable ERP identifies an adult as a reference parent (1=yes, 2=no), and EREFPAR is the child-level variable that identifies the PNUM of the reference parent.

Most child care questions correspond to children 0-14 years old, but there are some exceptions. For example, all HeadStart care arrangements and nursery or preschool correspond to children aged 2-7 and before/after school care program corresponds to children aged 3-14.

Related to child-care assistance only, beginning with 2018 SIPP data, respondents who were not asked the child-care assistance question, because they did not fulfill the income requirement, are given a value of “2” for ECHLD_ANY and “3” (logical imputation) for ACHLD_ANY. This change affected the size of the child-care assistance universe. An internal income screener variable that is used to set the universe for child-care assistance is not available to the public, therefore, data users are unable to recreate the universe for this program and should be aware of this change when analyzing child-care assistance data.

Other concepts related to the Child Care data

Child Care: Child can be in parental, relative, and nonrelative child care arrangements.

Child care assistance: Either federal or employer assistance.

Head Start: A federally subsidized child care program.

4.3.3 Child Well-Being

The Child Well-Being section covers a variety of topics such as parental involvement with children, children’s participation in extracurricular activities and children’s school engagement. Questions about parental involvement include the number of times in a typical week coresident and non-coresident parents shared dinners with their children, took them on outings or read to their children. Children’s extracurricular activities include playing on a sports team, participating in club activities, taking lessons or attending religious activities. School engagement includes questions about whether a child has ever repeated a grade, has ever been suspended or expelled, attends gifted classes and level of engagement with school. Like the Child Care section, the Child Well-Being section utilizes the ‘reference parent’ concept for data collection. If the mother is not available for an interview, the father of the child can give proxy responses for her. Priority is given to biological mothers, then other mothers, then biological fathers, and then other fathers. In single-parent families, the resident parent is the reference parent. If neither parent is in the household, the householder is the reference parent.

Level of information the Child Well-Being data provide

Child well-being data is stored on the reference parent’s record and then a recode is created and placed on the child’s record. Variables regarding meals, outings, reading, and religious service attendance are global questions and cover parental engagement with all children, not engagement child by child. Therefore, whatever value is on the parent’s record is carried directly over to the child’s record. For example, for the variable EDINRPAR, the reference parent with two children ages 5 and 10 tells us that she eats dinner with her children 5 nights a week. The value on EDINRPAR is then copied on to each child’s record as a recoded variable (RDINRPAR).

The child well-being variables are available at the person level, and they can be used at a child level or reference parent level (household level).

Additional guidance for using Child Well-Being data

The Child Well-Being questions are asked after the Event History Calendar, following the Child Care section. The universe of respondents consists of adults who are parents of children under 18 years old (ERP). In households in which both parents are present, the mother is the reference parent.

Specific child wellbeing items correspond to children of specific ages. For example, school engagement and extracurricular activities are asked of reference parents with school-aged children (6 to 17 years old). In contrast, among the parental involvement measures, only shared dinners applies to all children 0 to 17 years old, while reading and outings applies to children 0 to 5 years old.

Variables prefixed with an “E” are the edited versions stored on the reference parent's record. Variables prefixed with an “R” are recoded versions that are stored on the child's record and are based on the original variable stored on the parent's record. The variable ERP identifies an adult as a reference parent (1=yes, 2=no), and EREFPAR is a child-level variable that identifies the PNUM of the reference parent.

4.3.4 Disability

The Disability content covers whether the respondent has difficulty performing certain activities due to a physical, mental, or emotional condition. The main Disability section contains six core questions about difficulty with daily tasks, along with six additional questions specific to children or the working-age population. The six core questions ask about hearing difficulty (EHEARING), seeing difficulty (ESEEING), cognitive difficulty (ECOGNIT), ambulatory difficulty (EAMBULAT), self-care difficulty (ESELF CARE), and independent living difficulty (EERRANDS). This set of six questions is consistent with the standard disability question set implemented across multiple government surveys, including the American Community Survey (ACS) and the Current Population Survey (CPS). Consistent with other surveys, the age universes for the core disability items differ. While EHEARING and ESEEING apply to all individuals eligible for an interview, ECOGNIT, EAMBULAT, and ESELF CARE only apply to individuals aged 5 and older and EERRANDS is only asked of individuals aged 15 and older.

The additional child disability questions ask about developmental delays (EDDELAY) for children 1 to 4 years old, difficulty playing with other children (EPLAYDIF) for children 5 to 14 years old, and difficulty with schoolwork (ESCHOOLWK) for children 5 to 14 years old.

The work-limiting disability questions ask about difficulty finding or keeping a job (EFINDJOB) for individuals 15 to 70 years old, limitations in the kind or amount of work possible (EDISABL) for individuals ages 15 and older, and being prevented from working at all (EJOBCANT) for individuals 15 to 70 years old.

To help data users, two disability recode variables are constructed as summary measures of disability:

- RDIS is a standard summary measure of disability that has been used across government surveys since 2008, including the ACS and the CPS. The measure is based on responses to the six core questions about difficulty with daily tasks: ESEEING, EHEARING, ECOGNIT, EAMBULAT, ESELF CARE, and EERRANDS. RDIS=1 indicates that the respondent has difficulty with at least one of the six tasks.
- RDIS_ALT is an alternative summary measure of disability that incorporates the child disability questions, EDDELAY, EPLAYDIF, and ESCHOOLWK, and the work-limiting disability questions, EFINDJOB, EDISABL, and EJOBCANT. RDIS_ALT=1 indicates that the respondent has difficulty with one of the six daily tasks used for the standard summary measure of disability AND/OR has a value of 1 (“yes”) for one of the three child disability variables or for one of the three work-limiting disability variables.

In partnership with the Social Security Administration (SSA), seven additional disability questions were added to the SIPP beginning in 2021. This content includes three questions about functional limitations, including difficulty sitting (ESITD), difficulty lifting (EDIF10), and difficulty grasping (EGRASPD). Additionally, the content includes one question about learning or developmental disability (ELEARNDIS), one question about mental or emotional conditions (EMENTDIS), and one question about health conditions lasting 12 months or longer that limit activities (EHLTHCOND). All respondents aged 5 and over who had a value of 1 (“yes”) for any disability question were asked to report the condition(s) that cause(s) difficulty with those activities. Respondents could report up to 3 conditions and answers were used to construct 3 sets of condition recode variables: RCONDBRIDGE(1-3), RCONDTYP(1-3), RCONDSUBTYP(1-3).

The age universes differ for these additional disability items. ELEARNDIS, EMENTDIS, and EHLTHCOND are asked of individuals ages 5 and older, whereas ESITD, EDIF10, and EGRASPD only apply to individuals ages 15 and older. The universes for the condition recode variables are more complex. All individuals ages 5 and older who had a value of 1 (“yes”) for any disability question are in universe for RCONDBRIDGE1, RCONDTYP1, and RCONDSUBTYP1 (i.e., the first condition question). Individuals who report a condition other than “None” for the first condition question are then in universe for RCONDBRIDGE2, RCONDTYP2, and RCONDSUBTYP2. Finally, individuals who report two conditions are in universe for RCONDBRIDGE3, RCONDTYP3, and RCONDSUBTYP3. For more information on the condition recode variables, please refer to the sub-section below entitled “Additional information on condition recode variables.”

Many of these seven additional disability questions are similar to questions that appeared in previous SIPP panels. [Table 4-2](#) details which of these variables are also available in prior SIPP panels and includes notes on the comparability of variables across panels.

TABLE 4-2. SELECT DISABILITY VARIABLES IN PRIOR SIPP PANELS

2025 ¹ SIPP Disability Variable	Available in 2014 SIPP SSA Supplement?	Available in 2008 SIPP Wave 6 Topical Module?
ESITD	Available	Available

	<i>(Note: Age universe differs – ages 18+, compared to ages 15+ in 2025 SIPP)</i>	
EDIF10	Available <i>(Note: Age universe differs – ages 18+, compared to ages 15+ in 2025 SIPP)</i>	Available
EGRASPD	Available <i>(Note: Age universe differs – ages 18+, compared to ages 15+ in 2025 SIPP)</i>	Available
ELEARNDIS	Similar variable: ELEARNDIS, ECHLEARN_DIS <i>(Question text differs – variables not directly comparable)</i> <i>(Note: Age universe differs – ages 18+ for ELEARNDIS and ages 5-17 for ECHLEARN_DIS, compared to ages 5+ in 2025 SIPP)</i>	Similar variable: ELDIS, ELERNDIS <i>(Question text differs – variables not directly comparable)</i> <i>(Note: Age universe differs – ages 15+ for ELDIS and ages 6-14 for ELERNDIS, compared to ages 5+ in 2025 SIPP)</i>
EMENTDIS	Similar variable: EOTHERM <i>(Question text substantively differs – variables not comparable)</i> <i>(Note: Age universe differs – ages 18+, compared to ages 5+ in 2025 SIPP)</i>	Similar variable: EOTHERM <i>(Question text substantively differs – variables not comparable)</i> <i>(Note: Age universe differs – ages 15+, compared to ages 5+ in 2025 SIPP)</i>
EHLTHCOND	Not available	Not available
RCONDBRIDGE(1-3)	Similar recode variables: TCONDW(1-3), TCONDP(1-3) <i>(Question text differs – variables are not directly comparable, though condition categories are the same)</i> <i>(Note: Age universe differs – refer to 2014 SIPP SSA Supplement Metadata²)</i>	Similar recode variables: ECONDW(1-3), ECOND(1-3), ECONDPH(1-3) <i>(Question text differs – variables are not directly comparable, though many of the condition categories are the same)</i> <i>(Note: Age universe differs – refer to SIPP 2008 Panel Wave 6 Topical Module File Data Dictionary³)</i>
RCONDTYPE(1-3)	Not available	Not available
RCONDSUBTYPE(1-3)	Not available	Not available

¹ Note that the listed 2025 disability variables also appear in 2021-2024 SIPP data.

² For the 2014 SSA Supplement Metadata, refer to <https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/data/datasets/2014/ssa/2014SSA_Metadata_AllSections.pdf>.

³ For the 2008 SIPP Panel Wave 6 Topical Module File Data Dictionary, refer to <<https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/data-dictionaries/2008/sipp-2008-panel-wave-06-topical-module-data-dictionary.pdf>>.

Additional information on condition recode variables

Beginning in 2021 SIPP, respondents ages 5 and over who had a value of 1 (“yes”) for any disability question were asked to report the condition(s) that cause(s) difficulty with activities. Like in the 2014 SIPP SSA Supplement, respondents could choose from a trigram answer list of over 400 conditions when reporting the condition(s) that cause(s) difficulty with activities. The trigram format allowed the interviewer to type the first 3 letters of the word and all conditions beginning with those 3 letters appeared for selection. Respondents could report up to 3 conditions. For the public-use answer list, the detailed condition answers were recoded into broader condition categories. Three sets of condition recode variables are available in the 2025 SIPP data file:

- **RCONDBRIDGE(1-3):** A condition recode variable that is based on the same 41 condition categories employed in the 2014 SIPP SSA Supplement. Note that 30 of these condition categories were also used for the condition recodes in the 2008 SIPP panel. As such, this recode variable provides some measure of comparability to prior SIPP panels.
- **RCONDTYP(1-3) & RCONDSUBTYP(1-3):** A pair of recode variables that are based on a new set of condition categories. Conditions are sorted into both a broad condition “type” (e.g., “Musculoskeletal issues”; “Respiratory disorders”) and a more specific condition “subtype” (e.g., “Musculoskeletal issues: Back or spine problems”; “Musculoskeletal issues: Rheumatoid arthritis”). The RCONDTYP(1-3) variable indicates the individual’s value on the broad condition type, while the RCONDSUBTYP(1-3) variable indicates the individual’s value on both the broad condition type and the more specific condition subtype. For example, a person who reported their first condition as “post-traumatic stress disorder” would be assigned a value of “9” on RCONDTYP1 (for “Mental or emotional disorder”) and a value of “9C” on RCONDSUBTYP1 (for “Mental or emotional disorder: Trauma or stressor-related disorders”). This pair of recode variables is considered an improvement over the 2014 SIPP SSA Supplement condition recode variable.
- Beginning in 2023 SIPP, a change in question text for the first condition question (which constructs variables RCONDBRIDGE1, RCONDTYP1, and RCONDSUBTYP1) reduced respondent confusion and measurement error to better capture the conditions data as intended. For more information on the change in question text, refer to <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2023-usernotes/2023-change-disability-condition-question.html>.

Level of information the Disability data provide

All data related to disability content and status are available at the person level and represent status at the time of the interview.

Additional guidance for using Disability data

Most of the disability questions are located within the same section of the interview. However, one work-limiting disability question, limitations in the “kind or amount of work” a person can do (EDISABL), is asked prior to the main Disability section as a lead-in to questions about disability income receipt.

The format of the Disability section is as follows: first, respondents are asked if they have any difficulty seeing or hearing. All other questions are then presented in a series based on the age universe. While disability data are collected for both children and adults, disability data are not collected for individuals within the household under age 1.

Additionally, the concept of work-limiting disability may be captured through the variables EFINDJOB, EJOBCANT, and EDISABL.

As mentioned earlier, recode variables were also constructed using the disability data collected during the SIPP interview. This includes two summary measures of disability (RDIS and RDIS_ALT). RDIS and RDIS_ALT in 2025 SIPP are comparable to RDIS and RDIS_ALT in 2018-2024 SIPP.

4.3.5 Health Care Utilization and Medical Expenditures

The *Health Care Utilization* content collects information about:

- Respondent’s health status (excellent, very good, good, fair, or poor)
- Number of days sick in bed
- Number of nights spent in hospital and reason(s) for hospitalization
 - Beginning with 2021 SIPP, “To be treated for Covid-19 (suspected or diagnosed), or complications from Covid-19” was added as a response option.
- Prescription medication use
- Number of visits to dentists and dental health
- Number of visits to medical providers
 - Uninsured respondents are asked additional questions regarding the source of their care (e.g., emergency room).

The *Medical Expenditures* content collects information about respondents’ medical expenses, including:

- Health insurance premiums
- Cost of out-of-pocket medical expenditures
- Cost of over-the-counter (OTC) health-related products
- Whether the respondent had a Flexible Spending Account

Level of information the Health Care Utilization and Medical Expenditures data provide

All data related to health care utilization and medical expenditures are available annually at the person level. Utilization and expenditures questions refer to the reference period.

Additional guidance for using Health Care Utilization and Medical Expenditures data

- There are two items in the 2018+ SIPP that ask respondents about amounts paid for health insurance premiums:
 - THIPAYC: Comprehensive insurance premiums*
 - * Note that THIPAYC instructs respondents to exclude premium expenditures for Medicare parts B, C, or D deducted from Social Security Income that were already reported elsewhere in the survey.
 - THIPAYS: Supplemental health insurance premiums
- Items asking about expenditures related to health insurance premiums, health care, and OTC medication ask for amounts paid by the respondent for themselves or anyone in the household.
- Four items capture who expenditures were for:
 - EWHIPAYC: Who comprehensive insurance premiums were for
 - EWHIPAYS: Who supplemental insurance premiums were for
 - EWMDPAY: Who medical out-of-pocket expenditures were for
 - EWOTCMDPAY: Who medical over-the-counter expenditures were for
- The question text for TMDPAY and TOTCMDPAY providing examples of relevant medical costs is optional for interviewers to read if clarification is needed.
- The universe for all amounts questions includes all persons regardless of age (see the SIPP Codebook at <www.census.gov/data-tools/demo/uccb/sippdict> for exceptions). This universe is intended to align with other surveys such as the Current Population Survey - Annual Social and Economic Supplement (CPS ASEC). Persons who would not be expected to have paid expenses, either because of age (under age 15) or because the family was uninsured all year (in the case of premium questions only), have values set to \$0 and allocation flags set to '3: Logical assumption.' As a result of this universe, the total imputation rate will appear higher.



Note on Infants

In the 2025 SIPP, infants (defined as household members less than one year of age at time of interview) do not receive proxy interviews. As a general strategy, infants without data are imputed. However, for the Health Care Utilization and Medical Expenditures section, infants are expected to have unique health care needs, since they have unusually high medical utilization and expenditures compared to other groups. Due to these differences between infants and the rest of the population, SIPP does not impute health care utilization and medical expenditure information for those who are less than one year old. Values for these variables will be set to missing, and status flag variables will be set to '0: Not in universe', except for the two exceptions described below.

1. The questions for the amount paid out-of-pocket for medical expenses indirectly collect information on infants, by asking for amounts paid *for others in the household* for health insurance premiums, health care expenditures, or over-the-counter products. These amounts paid will only be present on the respondent's record, not the infant's record. Respondents are not explicitly instructed to think about and report on expenses related to infants, therefore the measure of medical expenses may not truly capture amounts paid for infants.

2. For the variable EHLTSTAT, SIPP imputes values for infants. This variable collects self-reported (or proxy-reported) health status. SIPP imputes values for this variable under the assumption that reported health status of infants is not fundamentally different from that of other young children.

4.3.6 Health Insurance

The 2025 SIPP data provide information on annual and monthly health insurance coverage. These data can be used to measure the percentage of the population with private health coverage, medical assistance (Medicaid), Medicare, military coverage, and other types of health insurance. In addition to providing health insurance coverage type for each household member, these data provide information on who the policyholder is, whether the employer pays for premiums (and how much), and whether the plan was purchased in a marketplace/exchange. It also allows users to look at how health insurance coverage changes over time, either on its own or in conjunction with other subject-matter content.

For each type of coverage, SIPP asks whether a respondent is currently covered by health insurance or was covered at any point during the reference year. If so, the person is asked to provide a beginning and ending month for that period (or spell) of coverage. No health insurance spell precedes the first month of the reference period nor exceeds the last month of the reference period. To determine whether a health insurance spell exceeds the reference period, data users should use the respective health insurance continuation flag variable (i.e., _CFLG). To determine whether a health insurance spell precedes the reference period, data users must append multiple SIPP data files to determine health insurance coverage duration for respondents of a respective panel. SIPP captures different spells of coverage within the year, each with complete plan details. For example, private insurance questions ask about up to two simultaneous sources of coverage in any given month, with follow-up questions about the type and source. Respondents who had direct-purchase insurance, Medicaid, or other coverage insurance are asked whether their coverage was obtained through <www.Healthcare.gov> or a state-based exchange, whether that coverage had a premium, and if so, whether there was a subsidy. Please note that SIPP classifies marketplace coverage as private direct-purchase coverage. SIPP does not restrict public coverage by income eligibility thresholds nor constrain respondents' perception of a health insurance marketplace. Data users may use their own judgement in how to interpret these data.

Level of information the Health Insurance data provide

For private health coverage, medical assistance (Medicaid), and military health insurance coverage, information is asked of the policyholder or the person in whose name the benefits are received. All people who share the same coverage plan are assigned the same values for all variables applicable to the spell.

Health insurance data are available at the person and person-month levels, and they can be used to calculate annual or monthly health insurance estimates. Definition of annual health insurance coverage: A respondent reported health insurance coverage at least one month within the reference period. Definition

of monthly health insurance coverage: A respondent reported health insurance coverage at least one day within the month.

Additional guidance for using Health Insurance data

For data user convenience, edited variables have been recoded at the monthly and annual levels for each type of health insurance coverage. Edited variables provide information about specific health insurance coverage types, whereas recode variables provide broader health insurance coverage information that consider multiple edited variables. Please see a list of the available edited and recode variables at the person/annual and person-month/monthly levels below.

Person-month level/Monthly Health Insurance Coverage Edited Variables

- Monthly health insurance coverage variables:
 - EPR1MTH – Any type of private (Line 1) health insurance coverage
 - EPR2MTH – Any type of private (Line 2) health insurance coverage
 - ECRMTH – Any type of Medicare health insurance coverage
 - EMDMTH – Any type of Medicaid health insurance coverage
 - EMLMTH – Any type of military health insurance coverage
 - EOTMTH – Any type of other health insurance coverage
- Monthly health insurance coverage *type* variables:
 - EHEMPY1 – Private (Line 1) health insurance coverage
 - EHEMPY2 – Private (Line 2) health insurance coverage
 - EMCPART1 – Part A Medicare coverage
 - EMCPART2 – Part B Medicare coverage
 - EMCPART3 – Medigap coverage
 - EMCPART4 – Part C Medicare coverage
 - EMCPART5 – Part D Medicare coverage
 - EMILITYPE – Military coverage
 - EOTHCOVTYPE – Other type of insurance coverage

Person level/Annual Health Insurance Coverage Recode Variables

- Annual health insurance coverage variables:
 - RHICOVANN – Any type of health insurance coverage
 - RPRIVANN – Any private type of health insurance coverage
 - RPUBANN – Any public type of health insurance coverage
- Annual health insurance coverage *type* variables:
 - REMPLOYANN – Any employment-sponsored related coverage
 - RDIRECTANN – Any direct-purchase related coverage
 - RMEDCAREANN – Any Medicare related coverage
 - RMCAIDANN – Any Medicaid coverage

- RTRICAREANN – Any TRICARE coverage
- RVACAREANN – Any VA Care or CHAMPVA coverage

Person-month level/Monthly Health Insurance Coverage Recode Variables

- Monthly health insurance coverage variables:
 - RHLTHMTH – Any type of health insurance coverage
 - RPRIMTH – Any private type of health insurance coverage
 - RPUBMTH – Any public type of health insurance coverage
- Monthly health insurance coverage *type* variables:
 - RPRITYPE1 – Employer-sponsored related coverage (including TRICARE)
 - RPRITYPE2 – Direct-purchase related coverage
 - RPRITYPE3 – Medigap coverage
 - RPUBTYPE1 – Medicare coverage
 - RPUBTYPE2 – Medicaid coverage or other government/public assistance coverage
 - RPUBTYPE3 – VA Care or CHAMPVA coverage
 - ROTHCOVMTH – Other health insurance coverage through a parent/relative
 - RIHSMTH – Indian Health Service coverage

Table 4-3 shows the recode variables (and the components) for each type of health insurance coverage at the monthly (person-month) and annual (person) level.

TABLE 4-3. HEALTH INSURANCE EDITED AND RECODE VARIABLES BY TOPIC AREA IN 2025 SIPP

Health Insurance Coverage Categories			Timeframe of Measurement							
			Monthly					Annual		
Topic	Response Code		Edited Variables		Recoded Variables					
			Any	Type	Health Insurance Coverage Any	Private/ Public Any	Private/ Public Type	Health Insurance Coverage Any	Private/ Public Any	Private/ Public Type
Private	1	(Current) Employer	EPR {1,2}MTH	EHEMPLY {1,2}	RHLTHMTH	RPRIMTH	RPRITYPE1	RHICOVANN	RPRIVANN	REMPLOYANN
	2	Former Employer								

	3	Union/Association									
	4	Bought it directly								RPRITYPE2	RDIRECTANN
	5	School									
Medicare	1	Part A (Hospital)	ECRMTH	EMCPART1	RHLTHMTH	RPUBMTH	RPUBTYPE1	RHICOVANN	RPUBANN	RMEDCAREANN	
	2	Part B (Medical)		EMCPART2							RPRIMTH
	3	Medigap (Supplement)		EMCPART3		RPUBMTH	RPUBTYPE1				
	4	Part C (Advantage Plan)		EMCPART4							
	5	Part D (Rx Coverage)		EMCPART5	N/A	N/A	N/A				
Medicaid	N/A		EMDMTH	N/A	RHLTHMTH	RPUBMTH	RPUBTYPE2	RHICOVANN	RPUBANN	RMCAIDANN	
Military	1	TRICARE or CHAMPUS	EMLMTH	EMILITYPE	RHLTHMTH	RPRIMTH	RPRITYPE1	RHICOVANN	RPRIVANN	RTRICAREANN	
	2	CHAMPVA				RPUBMTH	RPUBTYPE3		RPUBANN	RVACAREANN	
	3	VA									
	4	Other			N/A	N/A	N/A		N/A	N/A	
Other	1	Gov't/public assistance	EOTMTH	EOTHCOVTYPE	RHLTHMTH	RPUBMTH	RPUBTYPE2	RHICOVANN	RPUBANN	RMCAIDANN	
	2	Through someone else (parent/relative)			N/A	N/A	ROTHCOVMTH	N/A	N/A	N/A	
	3	Indian Health Services			N/A	N/A	RIHSMTH	N/A	N/A	N/A	



Note on Infants

Previously, infant coverage was only captured if they were reported under another household member's plan. Beginning in 2018 SIPP, questions were added to capture health insurance information about infants (defined as household members less than one year of age at time of interview) via a proxy adult. The infant questions ask whether each infant is currently covered by any health insurance, and if so, what type(s). As a result of asking about infant coverage directly, the imputation rates have improved due to more reported data available.

4.4 Program Participation and Income Transfers

The SIPP collects information regarding participation in a wide array of social programs. Information for some of these programs (GA, SNAP, SSI, TANF, and WIC) is collected in the EHC, while information on the remaining programs (i.e., non-EHC programs) is collected later in the survey.

For EHC programs, information is collected in reverse chronological order. That is, respondents are first asked if they or someone in their family are currently receiving the program. If a respondent reports current receipt, the month of the reference period or interview year receipt began is collected. If no one in the respondent's family is currently receiving the program, respondents are then asked if they received it at any time since the first month of the reference period. If receipt is reported during that time, the months that receipt began and ended are collected. If a program spell includes January of the reference period the first time a respondent is interviewed, information on the year the respondent first began receiving benefits is collected.

A continuation flag for respondents who reported receiving the program in the last month of the reference period provides information on whether the spell: (1) ended in the last month of the reference period; (2) ended after the last month of the reference period but before the interview month; or (3) was ongoing as of the interview month.

For each spell, respondents are asked to report the person in whose name the benefit is received (benefit owner), who was covered by the benefit, why receipt began, why receipt ended (if applicable), and payment amount, as this information may vary across spells.

Respondents may report up to four different payment amounts in a spell to allow for changes in payments resulting from factors such as cost of living adjustments and earnings variation.

Information on how non-EHC programs are collected is detailed in the sections below.

4.4.1 Energy Assistance

The Energy Assistance section collects information from the household respondent about the payment of utilities and receipt of energy assistance at any time during the reference period, including:

- Whether the household paid separately for utilities (for households receiving a rental subsidy or housing voucher; EUTILITIES)
- Whether the household received energy assistance (EENERGY_ASST)
- Whether assistance was in the form of checks sent to the household (EENERGY_PMT1); coupons or vouchers sent to the household (EENERGY_PMT2); and/or payments sent directly to the utility company, fuel dealer, or landlord (EENERGY_PMT3) (for households that reported receipt of energy assistance)

Level of information the Energy Assistance data provide

Energy assistance data are available at the household level. The reporting period is the entire reference period.

Other concepts related to the Energy Assistance data

Energy Assistance: Government energy assistance programs help pay heating and cooling costs. This assistance is often paid directly to the utility company, fuel dealer, or landlord. Eligibility varies by state. The SIPP asks whether energy assistance was received in the form of checks sent to the household, coupons or vouchers sent to the household, and/or payments sent directly to the utility company, fuel dealer, or landlord. However, energy assistance programs may also help with energy crisis, weatherization, and energy-related home repairs. Since some types of assistance are not collected in the SIPP, some records have a valid response of a “no” for all three of the payment type variables associated with energy bills.

4.4.2 General Assistance

The General Assistance (GA) section collects information about benefit receipt from the start of the reference period through the interview month (see programmatic details under *Other concepts related to the General Assistance data*). For each GA benefit unit, one adult in the household is considered the owner of the GA benefits (the person in whose name the benefits are received). The GA owner may or may not be covered by the GA benefit.

As shown below, all people are assigned values for the reference period and monthly coverage indicators. People who are covered but are not the owner are assigned a value for an additional variable that points to the benefit owner and provides a link to details about the spell. The benefit owner has values assigned for all the variables applicable to the spell.

Variables on the public-use file provide the following information for the reference period:

Universe: All people

- Reference period indicator (RGA_YRYN)
- Monthly coverage indicator (RGA_MNRYN)

Universe: Benefit owner and people who are covered by the benefit

- Benefit owner (EGA_OWN)

Universe: Benefit owner

- Begin and end month of spell (EGA_BMONTH and EGA_EMONTH)
- Year receipt began if receiving in January of the reference period the first time a respondent is interviewed (RGA_LCYR)
- Continuation flag for spells that include the last month of the reference period (TGA_CFLG)
- Reason receipt began (TGA_BRSN)
- Reason receipt ended (TGA_ERSN)
- Payment amount (TGA_AMT)

Data users should be aware that variable names were standardized across the EHC programs (SNAP, WIC, SSI, TANF, and GA) starting in the 2018 SIPP. To see a side-by-side comparison of GA variable names in the 2014 SIPP Panel and the 2018 SIPP, please see Section 4.4.4 in the 2018 Survey of Income and Program Participation Users' Guide.

Level of information the General Assistance data provide

GA data are collected at the spell level in the EHC and are provided to users in a person-month format. While all data are in a monthly format, the value of the variables may stay the same or vary over time.

Same value for the reference period:

RGA_YRYN

Same value throughout the spell:

RGA_MNYN, EGA_BMONTH, EGA_EMONTH, EGA_OWN, RGA_LCYR, TGA_CFLG, TGA_BRSN, TGA_ERSN

Value may vary within a spell:

TGA_AMT

Other concepts related to the General Assistance data

General Assistance and General Relief programs description: General Assistance programs are funded and administered by state and local governments. Some states do not have General Assistance programs, and some states allow localities to choose whether to implement General Assistance programs. States might also have different names for their programs. The programs primarily serve people who do not qualify for federal assistance. The populations these programs serve vary by locality. Examples include the disabled, the elderly, the unemployed, children, families with children, and employable

individuals without children. The needs of each recipient may also vary. Assistance may be a one-time emergency payment or a regular monthly benefit and/or payment. Payments received may be in cash or in the form of a voucher. Also, the benefit and payment received may be intended for a specific need, such as medical expenses, burial expenses, or to meet general needs.

4.4.3 Other Assistance

The Other Assistance questions focus on informal types of assistance (food, transportation, other (clothing and housing), and training) that fall outside the government's main social welfare programs. Although the programs in this section are not necessarily means-tested, SIPP only collects these data from respondents aged 15 years and older who answered yes to at least one of the income screener questions. For each kind of assistance or topic, variables identify the type of assistance received during the reference period, the source(s) of assistance received during the reference period, and the months in which assistance was received during the reference period.

Food Assistance

SIPP asks respondents whether they received various types of food assistance (excluding SNAP, WIC, and school meals, if collected previously) during the reference period:

- Money, vouchers, or certificates to buy groceries
- Bags of groceries or packaged foods
- Meals from a shelter, soup kitchen, Meals-on-Wheels, or other charity
- Something else

Respondents who report receiving food assistance in the form of money, vouchers, or certificates to buy groceries are asked about the source(s) of assistance during the reference period:

- Government social service agency
- Community or religious charitable organization
- Family or friends
- Someplace else

Respondents are then asked to identify the months they received food assistance during the reference period.

Transportation Assistance

SIPP asks respondents aged 15 and older who indicated potential eligibility for means-tested assistance whether they received various types of transportation assistance during the reference period:

- Gas vouchers
- Bus or subway tokens or passes
- Help repairing, registering, or insuring a car
- Rides to a doctor's office or medical appointment

- Some other kind

Respondents who report receiving gas vouchers or bus or subway tokens or passes are asked about the source(s) of assistance during the reference period:

- Government social service agency
- Someplace else

Respondents are then asked to identify the months they received transportation assistance during the reference period.

Clothing and Housing Assistance

SIPP asks respondents whether they received various types of clothing assistance during the reference period:

- Free or reduced-price clothes
- Money or vouchers
- Both free or reduced-price clothes and money or vouchers

Respondents who report receiving clothing assistance are asked about the source(s) of this assistance during the reference period:

- Government social service agency
- Community or religious charitable organization
- Family or friends
- Employer
- Someplace else

SIPP asks respondents whether they received housing assistance to help pay for housing during the reference year (not including energy assistance, if collected previously).

Respondents who report clothing and/or housing assistance are then asked to identify the months they received clothing and/or housing assistance during the reference period.

Training Assistance

This section asks respondents aged 18-64 who have less than a bachelor's degree and indicated potential eligibility for means-tested assistance whether they participated in any of the following types of training programs to improve or enhance their job readiness skills during the reference period:

- Classes or training to improve basic reading or math skills
- Job readiness training to learn about resume writing, job interviewing, or building self-esteem
- Job search programs or job clubs, or job resource centers to find out about jobs, to schedule interviews, or to fill out applications

- Training to learn a specific job skill, such as computers, car repair, nursing, day care work, or some other job skill

Respondents are then asked to identify the months they participated in training assistance programs during the reference period.

Level of information the Other Assistance data provide

The Other Assistance data are provided to users in the form of person-level and person-month-level variables.

Additional guidance for using Other Assistance data

For each topic, SIPP has an initial question that asks whether the respondent received different types of assistance during the reference period. Each type is edited as a separate yes/no variable. To identify whether a respondent received assistance in at least one month of the reference period, each yes/no variable for that topic must be checked.

To determine the months of receipt during the reference period, monthly yes/no variables are available for each topic. If respondents report more than one type or source of assistance for a single assistance program (e.g., reporting transportation assistance for repairing a car and rides to medical appointments), users are not able to identify which months of receipt were associated with each specific type or source of assistance.

While all data are in a person-month format, the value of some variables is the same for entire reference period (i.e., person-level variables). The value of other variables may vary from month-to-month (i.e., person-month-level variables).

Person-level variables

- Type(s) of assistance
 - Food Assistance:
 - EFOOD_TYPE1 – Money, vouchers, or certificates to buy groceries
 - EFOOD_TYPE2 – Bags of groceries or packaged food
 - EFOOD_TYPE3 – Meals from a shelter, soup kitchen, Meals-on-Wheels, or other charity
 - EFOOD_OTH – Some other kind of food assistance
 - Transportation Assistance:
 - ETRANS_TYPE1 – Gas vouchers
 - ETRANS_TYPE2 – Bus or subway tokens or passes
 - ETRANS_TYPE3 – Help repairing, registering, or insuring a car
 - ETRANS_TYPE4 – Rides to a doctor's office or medical appointment
 - ETRANS_OTH – Some other kind of transportation assistance
 - Other Assistance:

- ECLTH_TYPE – Clothes, money or vouchers, or both clothes and money or vouchers
 - EHOUSE_ANY – Assistance to help pay for housing
- Training Assistance:
 - EWELACTV1 – Classes or training to improve basic reading or math skills
 - EWELACTV2_1 – Job readiness training to learn about resume writing, job interviewing, or building self-esteem
 - EWELACTV2_2 – Job search programs or job clubs, or job resource centers to find out about jobs, to schedule interviews, or to fill out applications
 - EWELACTV2-3 – Training to learn a specific job skill, such as computers, car repair, nursing, day care work, or some other job skill
 - EWELACTV4 – Participated in any work experience program, such as community service job, in exchange for TANF
- Source(s) of assistance
 - Food Assistance:
 - EFOOD_SR1YN – Food source was through a government social service agency
 - EFOOD_SR2YN – Food source was through community or religious charitable organization
 - EFOOD_SR3YN – Food source was through family or friends
 - EFOOD_SR4YN – Food source was through someplace else
 - Transportation Assistance:
 - EGAS_SOURCE – Source of gas vouchers was a government social service agency
 - ETOKEN_SRC – Source of bus or subway tokens or passes was a government social service agency
 - Other Assistance:
 - ECLTH_SR1YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through a government social service agency
 - ECLTH_SR2YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through a community or religious charitable organization
 - ECLTH_SR3YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through family or friends
 - ECLTH_SR4YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through an employer
 - ECLTH_SR5YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through someplace else

Monthly-level variables

- Month(s) of assistance
 - Food Assistance:

- EFOOD_MNYN – Received any food assistance during months of reference period
- Transportation Assistance:
 - ETRANS_MNYN – Received transportation assistance during months of reference period
- Other Assistance:
 - EOTHAS_MNYN – Received any other type of assistance during months of reference period
- Training Assistance:
 - EWELAC_MNYN – Attended training during months of reference period

Respondents who do not indicate eligibility for means-tested programs through a series of income and program screener questions are not asked questions about a series of small, means-tested annual programs, including food assistance (such as receiving food from food banks), transportation assistance (such as receiving free ride programs), job training (such as attending job readiness courses), or clothing or housing assistance. These respondents are assigned a value of "2" (no, did not receive assistance) and a status flag value of "3" (logical imputation) in this series. This change increases the size of the universe for these items and the logical-imputation rate for status flags associated with the variables.

Internal income and program screener variables used to set the universe for this content are not available on the public-use file. Data users cannot recreate the universe and should be aware of this when analyzing Other Assistance data. Users can approximate the instrument universe by excluding observations with a "3" (logical imputation) status flag value.

The below variables are affected by this change.

Food Assistance:

- EFOOD_TYPE1 – Money, vouchers, or certificates to buy groceries
- EFOOD_TYPE2 – Bags of groceries or packaged food
- EFOOD_TYPE3 – Meals from a shelter, soup kitchen, Meals-on-Wheels, or other charity
- EFOOD_OTH – Some other kind of food assistance
- EFOOD_MNYN – Received any food assistance during months of reference period

Transportation Assistance:

- ETRANS_TYPE1 – Gas vouchers
- ETRANS_TYPE2 – Bus or subway tokens or passes
- ETRANS_TYPE3 – Help repairing, registering, or insuring a car
- ETRANS_TYPE4 – Rides to a doctor's office or medical appointment
- ETRANS_OTH – Some other kind of transportation assistance
- ETRANS_MNYN – Received transportation assistance during months of reference period

Training Assistance:

- EWELACTV1 – Classes or training to improve basic reading or math skills

- EWELACTV2_1 – Job readiness training to learn about resume writing, job interviewing, or building self-esteem
- EWELACTV2_2 – Job search programs or job clubs, or job resource centers to find out about jobs, to schedule interviews, or to fill out applications
- EWELACTV2-3 – Training to learn a specific job skill, such as computers, car repair, nursing, day care work, or some other job skill
- EWELAC_MNYN – Attended training during months of reference period

Other Assistance:

- ECLTH_TYPE – Clothes, money or vouchers, or both clothes and money or vouchers
- ECLTH_SR1YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through a government social service agency
- ECLTH_SR2YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through a community or religious charitable organization
- ECLTH_SR3YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through family or friends
- ECLTH_SR4YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through an employer
- ECLTH_SR5YN – Source of clothes or money or vouchers for clothes through someplace else
- EHOUSE_ANY – Assistance to help pay for housing
- EOTHAS_MNYN – Received any other type of assistance during months of reference period

4.4.4 School Meals

The School Meals section collects information about the receipt of school lunches and breakfasts at any point during the academic year, including:

- Whether any children in the family usually got the school lunch/breakfast that their school provided
- Whether the lunches/breakfasts received were free or reduced-price
- Indicator of receipt of school lunches/breakfasts is available on the record of eligible children

Level of information the School Meals data provide

Information about the receipt of school meals is asked of designated parents of children between the ages of 5 and 18 who have not yet graduated from high school. Information about receipt of school meals is stored on the parent's record. Additionally, all children between the ages of 5 and 18 who have not yet graduated from high school have indicators of receipt of school breakfasts and lunches on their records. The reporting period is the current academic school year. The School Meals data are available as person-level variables.

Additional guidance for using School Meals data

While all data are available in a monthly format, these variables hold the same value over the entire reference period. The following variables are available on the record of designated parents of eligible children:

- Indicator that one or more children in the family usually got the lunch their school provided (ESCHOOOLLUNCH)
- Indicator that one or more children in the family usually got the breakfast their school provided (ESCHOOOLBREAK)
- Whether the lunches received were free or reduced-price because the family qualified for the School Lunch Program, or full price because the family did not qualify for the School Lunch Program (EFREE_LUNCH)
- Whether the breakfasts received were free or reduced-price because the family qualified for the School Breakfast Program, or full price because the family did not qualify for the School Breakfast Program (EFREE_BREAK)

The following variables are available on the record of children between the ages of 5 and 18 who have not yet graduated from high school:

- Whether respondent got free lunches, reduced-price lunches, full-price lunches, or did not receive school lunches (RLUNCH_CHLD)
- Whether respondent got free breakfasts, reduced-price breakfasts, full-price breakfasts, or did not receive school breakfasts (RBREAK_CHLD)

Other concepts related to the School Meals data

Federal School Breakfast/Lunch Program: The federal school breakfast and lunch program is a program sponsored by the Food and Nutrition Service of the U.S. Department of Agriculture. This program subsidizes the cost of all school meals for all children in many school districts across the country through the National School Lunch Program. Recipients of free or reduced-price meals are children in school who live in households with limited incomes or who live in districts in low-income areas participating in the Community Eligibility Provision. The benefit generally comes in the form of a discounted or free lunch and/or breakfast every school day during the school year, but in some localities the program is extended through the summer months.

4.4.5 Social Security Benefits for Oneself

The Social Security Benefits for Oneself section collects person- and person-month-level data for each household member aged 18 or older who received Social Security benefits at any time during the reference year.

The section begins by asking about any Social Security benefit receipt for oneself during the reference year. If the respondent reports any Social Security benefit receipt, SIPP then asks why the respondent received Social Security benefits. Social Security benefits for oneself can be received for five reasons:

1. Retirement – the respondent has stopped working due to age or length of job tenure and receives Social Security benefits based on the respondent’s own earnings record. Some respondents may continue working while receiving Social Security ‘because they are retired’ if they are of an age that makes them eligible to begin receiving benefits.

2. Disability – the respondent has an impairment that limits their ability to work.
3. Widowed – a surviving spouse receives the Social Security income of their deceased spouse.
4. Spouse – a beneficiary receives Social Security income based on the record of a living spouse, whether the beneficiary and spouse are currently married or divorced.
5. Other – any reason that the respondent receives Social Security income for themselves, exclusive of reasons 1-4.

SIPP also asks at what age the respondent began receiving Social Security.

Amounts are collected by asking about the amount received in the most recent month of receipt, which can be the interview month. Previous amounts are collected by moving backwards chronologically from the interview month to the start of the reference period. If the start month for the amount reported is after the month in which benefit receipt started, the instrument then asks how much was received prior to the most current amount and when that amount was received.

Spells and amounts are output with two types of variables. First, person-month-level indicator variables show whether the respondent received Social Security benefits for oneself during the month. Second, where respondents report receipt for that month, person-month-level amount variables show the amount. If the respondent received Social Security benefits for oneself at some point during the reference period but not at a given month, the amount is listed as zero. The amount variable reflects the gross monthly payment, that is, the amount prior to any Medicare deductions.

Level of information the Social Security Benefits for Oneself data provide

Monthly Social Security benefit amounts are collected for all household members aged 18 or older during the reference year. Respondents under the age of 18 at the end of the reference year are not in universe for the Social Security Self Benefits for Oneself section. The Social Security Benefits for Oneself data are available in the form of person-month-level variables on months of receipt (ESSSMNYN) and amount received (TSSSAMT). Additionally, these data include person-level reference period indicators of receipt (ESSSANY), the reason(s) for receipt (ESSRSN[1-5]YN), the age at which respondents receiving Social Security began receiving benefits (TSSAGESS), and a continuation flag indicating whether receipt continued through the interview month (RSSS_CFLG).

Additional guidance for using Social Security Benefits for Oneself data

The Social Security Benefits for Oneself section collects amount(s) received and when the amount was received. It collects up to four amount changes during the reference year.

Other concepts related to the Social Security Benefits for Oneself data

Disability: An impairment that may be physical, cognitive, mental, hearing, vision, sensory, emotional, developmental, chronic disease, or some combination thereof.

Retired: Employment status or point in time when employees terminate their employment or reduce their employment hours due to their age or tenure. Retirement is usually between the ages of 50 and 70. However, the Social Security Administration specifies that a cohort-based retirement can be at any age,

including before the age or tenure needed for eligibility for support. Benefits may be claimed early (no earlier than 62) for a lower benefit level, or they may begin being claimed after the full retirement age for a potentially higher benefit level.

Social Security on behalf of oneself: Social Security is managed by the Social Security Administration and is designed to provide retirement, healthcare, disability, and survivors' insurance for U.S. workers. As insured employees work, they pay Social Security taxes and earn credits that count toward eligibility for Social Security benefits. Most workers need 10 years of work to qualify for benefits. Social Security benefits may include monthly income benefits, health insurance (Medicare, Medicaid, or both), lump sum payments, and cost of living adjustments. Workers at least age 62 can retire with reduced benefits and can receive higher benefits beginning at age 65, 66, or 67, depending on their birthdate. Current, former, and surviving spouses can receive Social Security benefits for themselves based on their spouse's earnings record.

4.4.6 Social Security Benefits on Behalf of a Child

The Social Security Benefits on Behalf of a Child section collects person- and person-month-level data from respondents who received Social Security benefits on behalf of a child at any time during the reference year. Monthly Social Security child benefit amounts are collected for all household members aged 18 or older with a child who resided in the house at any time during the reference year. Respondents under the age of 18 at the end of the reference year are not in universe for items asking whether the respondent received Social Security income on behalf of a child. Persons receiving Social Security income on behalf of a child must be 18 or older. Parents under 18 years old are not asked these questions.

The section begins by asking about any Social Security benefit receipt on behalf of a child during the reference year. If the respondent reports any receipt and there is more than one child in the household, SIPP asks the respondent to identify the child(ren) in whose name(s) benefits were received. SIPP next asks why the respondent began receiving Social Security benefits (i.e., whether the child is a surviving child or a dependent child).

Monthly amounts are collected by asking about the amount received in the most recent month of receipt, which can be the interview month. Previous amounts are collected by moving backwards chronologically from the interview month to the start of the reference period. If the start month for the amount reported is after the month in which benefit receipt started, the instrument then asks how much was received prior to the most current amount.

Spells and amounts are output with two types of variables. First, a person-month-level indicator variable shows whether the respondent received Social Security benefits on behalf of a child during the month. Second, where respondents report receipt for that month, a person-month-level amount variable shows the amount. If the respondent received Social Security benefits on behalf of a child at some point during the reference period but not at a given month, the amount is listed as zero.

Level of information the Social Security Benefits on Behalf of a Child data provide

Monthly Social Security child benefit amounts are collected at the person level for all household members aged 18 or older with a child who resided in the house at any time during the reference year. Respondents under the age of 18 at the end of the reference year are not in universe for items asking whether the respondent received Social Security income on behalf of a child. Persons receiving Social Security income on behalf of a child must be 18 or older. Parents under 18 years old are not asked these questions.

The Social Security Benefits on Behalf of a Child data provide person-month level information on months of receipt (ESSCMNYN), amount received (TSSCAMT), and coverage (see the variables referenced below). Additionally, these data include person-level reference period indicators of receipt (ESSCANY), the reason(s) for receipt (ESSKID[1-2]YN), and continuation flags (TSSC_CFLG).

Three variables can be used to link adults receiving Social Security income on behalf of a child with the child beneficiary. First, ESSKIDCOVFLG is a yes/no indicator for coverage on the child's record. Second, ESSCADLTPTR is a variable on the child's record that contains the PNUM of the adult who receives Social Security income on the child's behalf. Third, ESSKIDCTR is a variable on adults' records that shows the number of children on whose behalf the adult receives Social Security income at a given month.

Additional guidance for using Social Security Benefits on Behalf of a Child data

The Social Security Benefits on Behalf of a Child section collects amount(s) received and when the amount was received. It collects up to four amount changes during the reference year.

Other concepts related to the Social Security Benefits on Behalf of a Child data

Child: Refers to family relationship and/or the age of the person. In family relationships, a child references a parent's biological, step, adopted, or guardianship daughter or son. Child also references anyone under age 18.

Disability: An impairment that may be physical, cognitive, mental, hearing, vision, sensory, emotional, developmental, chronic disease, or some combination thereof.

4.4.7 Medicare Deductions

The Medicare deductions section collects person-level data for each household member aged 18 or older who received a given type of Medicare during the reference year.

As applicable, respondents who reported receiving a given part of Medicare (B, C, and/or D) during the reference year are first asked whether they have that premium taken out of their Social Security benefit before it reaches them. Those that do have their premium deducted from their Social Security benefit are asked the monthly amount of their deduction for that Part. Those Part C and D recipients that do not have their premium deducted from their Social Security benefit are asked how much they paid per month for that Part. Since Part B is rarely paid for out of pocket, recipients that do not report having the premium

deducted from their Social Security benefit are not asked a follow-up question about the amount spent on the premium.

Level of information the Medicare deductions data provide

Medicare deduction information is collected at the person-level for all household members that report receiving that type of Medicare (B, C, and/or D). Respondents who do not receive a given Part of Medicare are out of universe for the questions about that Part, and respondents who do not receive Social Security for themselves are out of universe for this content in the edited data. The Medicare deduction data are available in the form of variables about whether the premium was deducted from the respondent's Social Security check (ESSPARTBYN, ESSPARTCYN, ESSPARTDYN), the size of the monthly deduction if the premium was deducted (ESSPARTBKNOW, TSSPARTCAMT, TSSPARTDAMT), and the amount spent if the monthly premium was not deducted (TSSPARTCPD, TSSPARTDPD).

Additional guidance for using Medicare deduction data

The Medicare deductions section collects the size of monthly deductions or premium expenditures, but these values are collected at the person level; that is, they do not vary across months.

Other concepts related to the Social Security Benefits for Oneself data

Medicare: Medicare is the federal health insurance program for people who are 65 or older, certain younger people with disabilities, and people with End-Stage Renal Disease.

Medicare Deductions: Social Security beneficiaries can have their Medicare Part B, C, and D premiums deducted from their monthly benefit. Most people do not pay a Premium for Part A.

Medicare Part A: Medicare Part A helps cover inpatient care in hospitals, critical access hospitals, and skilled nursing facilities. It also helps cover hospice care and some home health care. Most people do not have to pay a premium for Part A.

Medicare Part B: Medicare Part B helps cover medical services like doctors' services, outpatient care, and other medical services that Part A doesn't cover. Part B is optional. Part B helps pay for covered medical services and items when they are medically necessary. Part B also covers some preventive services like exams, lab tests, and screening shots to help prevent, find, or manage a medical problem. If you have Part B, you pay a Part B premium each month.

Medicare Part C: Medicare Advantage Plans, sometimes called "Part C" or "MA Plans," are offered by private companies approved by Medicare. The plan provides all Part A (Hospital Insurance) and Part B (Medical Insurance) coverage. Medicare Advantage Plans may offer extra coverage, such as vision, hearing, dental, and/or health and wellness programs. Most include Medicare prescription drug coverage (Part D). Each Medicare Advantage Plan can charge different out-of-pocket costs and has different rules for how beneficiaries get services.

Medicare Part D: “Part D” refers to Medicare prescription drug coverage. This coverage is optional and offered to everyone with Medicare. Each plan varies in cost and specific drugs covered.

4.4.8 Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC)

The Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC) section collects information about benefit receipt from the start of the reference period through the interview month (see programmatic details under *Other concepts related to the WIC data*). The WIC section does not ask who the owner of the WIC benefit is, so the WIC owner variable, EWIC_OWN, is fully imputed using edited information about the family relationships in the household. For each WIC benefit unit, one adult in the household is considered the owner of the WIC benefits (the person in whose name the benefits are received). The WIC owner may or may not be covered by the WIC benefit.

As shown below, all people are assigned values for the reference period and monthly coverage variables. People who are covered but are not the owner are assigned a value for an additional variable that points to the benefit owner and provides a link to details about the spell. The benefit owner has values assigned for all variables applicable to the spell.

Variables on the public-use file provide the following information for the reference period:

Universe: All people

- Reference period indicator (RWIC_YRYN)
- Monthly coverage indicator (RWIC_MNYN)

Universe: Benefit owner and people who are covered by the benefit

- Benefit owner (EWIC_OWN)

Universe: Benefit owner

- Begin and end month of spell (EWIC_BMONTH and EWIC_EMONTH)
- Year receipt began if receiving in January of the reference period the first time a respondent is interviewed (TWIC_LCYR)
- Continuation flag for spells that include the last month of the reference period (RWIC_CFLG)
- Reason receipt began (TWIC_BRSN)
- Reason receipt ended if receipt ended during the reference period (TWIC_ERSN)
- Payment amount (TWIC_AMT)
- Type of WIC coverage (EWIC_COVTYP)

WIC benefits may be provided to pregnant and postpartum women, infants, and children up to the age of five who are low-income and are at nutritional risk.

The WIC section does not ask about the amount of money received because it is not a cash transfer program. Rather, recipients receive monthly benefits that cover the cost of formula and specified foods. For this reason, all amounts are fully imputed using edited information about the number of recipients in the benefit unit together with information from the USDA on the average expenditure per person.

Level of information the WIC data provide

WIC data are collected at the spell level in the EHC and are provided to users in a person-month format. While all data are in a monthly format, the value of the variables may stay the same or vary over time.

Same value for the reference period:

RWIC_YRYN

Same value for the spell:

RWIC_MNYN, EWIC_BMONTH, EWIC_EMONTH, EWIC_OWN, TWIC_LCYR,
RWIC_CFLG, TWIC_BRSN, TWIC_ERSN

Value may vary within a spell:

TWIC_AMT, EWIC_COVTYP

Other concepts related to the WIC data

Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC) program

description: This federal grant program has been administered by the state and at the federal level by the U.S. Department of Agriculture Food and Nutrition Service since 1974. The WIC program provides supplemental foods, nutrition education, nutrition counseling, and screening and referrals for health, welfare, and social services for low-income women, infants, and children up to age 5 who are at nutritional risk. Women are eligible for WIC if they are at nutritional risk and are pregnant, breast-feeding, or postpartum. Recipients of WIC receive monthly benefits that may include checks, vouchers, or electronic cards to purchase food.

4.4.9 Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP)

The Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) section collects information about benefit receipt from the start of the reference period through the interview month (see programmatic details under *Other concepts related to the SNAP data*). For each SNAP benefit unit, one adult in the household is considered the owner of the SNAP benefits (the person in whose name the benefits are received). The SNAP owner may or may not be covered by the SNAP benefit.

As shown below, all people are assigned values for the reference period and monthly coverage indicators. People who are covered but are not the owner are assigned a value for an additional variable that points to the benefit owner and provides a link to details about the spell. The benefit owner has values assigned for all variables applicable to the spell.

Variables on the public-use file provide the following information for the reference period:

Universe: All people

- Reference period indicator (RSNAP_YRYN)
- Monthly coverage indicator (RSNAP_MNYN)

Universe: Benefit owner and people who are covered by the benefit

- Benefit owner (ESNAP_OWN)

Universe: Benefit owner

- Begin and end month of spell (ESNAP_BMONTH and ESNAP_EMONTH)
- Year receipt began if receiving in January of the reference period the first time a respondent is interviewed (RSNAP_LCYR)
- Continuation flag for spells that include the last month of the reference period (RSNAP_CFLG)
- Reason receipt began (ESNAP_BRSN)
- Reason receipt ended if receipt ended during the reference period (ESNAP_ERSN)
- Payment amount (TSNAP_AMT)
- Number of people in the SNAP unit (ESNAP_CNT)

Data users should be aware that variable names were standardized across the EHC programs (SNAP, WIC, SSI, TANF, and GA) starting in the 2018 SIPP. To see a side-by-side comparison of SNAP variable names in the 2014 SIPP Panel and the 2018 SIPP, please see Section 4.4.13 of the 2018 Survey of Income and Program Participation Users' Guide.

Level of information the SNAP data provide

SNAP data are collected at the spell level in the EHC and are provided to users in a person-month format. While all data are in a monthly format, the value of the variables may stay the same or vary over time.

Same value for the reference period:

RSNAP_YRYN

Same value throughout the spell:

RSNAP_MNYN, ESNAP_BMONTH, ESNAP_EMONTH, ESNAP_OWN, RSNAP_LCYR,
RSNAP_CFLG, ESNAP_BRSN, ESNAP_ERSN

Value may vary within a spell:

TSNAP_AMT, ESNAP_CNT

Additional guidance for using SNAP data

Benefit Owner: A monthly variable that identifies the person number of the individual in whose name the benefit is received.

Continuation Flag: A person-level variable that indicates whether the year-end spell (1) ended in the last month of the reference year, (2) ended after the last month of the reference year but before the interview month, or (3) was ongoing as of the interview month.

Spell: The duration of a benefit or event reported by a respondent in the Event History Calendar section of the survey that is defined by a start month, end month, and a continuous span between the start and end month.

Other concepts related to the SNAP data

Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) description: This federal aid program, administered by each state and funded by the U.S. Department of Agriculture, provides food purchasing assistance for low-income residents. SNAP is commonly known by its former name, the Food Stamp Program. This program was enacted by Congress in the Food Stamp Act of 1964 and later renamed to SNAP (Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program) by the Farm Bill of 2008, when the distribution system of coupon and stamp was replaced and updated with the Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) System. The amount of benefit received depends on the size, income, and expenses of the recipient's household. The benefits are distributed monthly via direct deposit to the EBT. Recipients may use the EBT to pay for food at participating food retail markets, which may include supermarkets, grocery stores, farmers' markets, and farmers' market roadside stands.

4.4.10 Supplemental Security Income (SSI)

The Supplemental Security Income (SSI) section collects information about benefit receipt from the start of the reference period through the interview month (see programmatic details under *Other concepts related to the SSI data*). If a child under age 18 receives SSI, a person aged 18 or older is designated as the owner of the SSI benefits (the person in whose name the benefits are received).

As shown below, all people are assigned values for the reference period and monthly coverage indicators. People who are covered by SSI have values assigned for all variables applicable to the spell.

Variables on the public-use file provide the following information for the reference period:

Universe: All people

- Reference period indicator (RSSI_YRYN)
- Monthly coverage indicator (RSSI_MNRYN)

Universe: People who receive SSI

- Begin and end month of spell (ESSI_BMONTH and ESSI_EMONTH)

- Benefit owner if the person receiving benefits is under age 18 (ESSI_OWN)
- Year receipt began if receiving in January of the reference period the first time a respondent is interviewed (TSSI_LCYR)
- Continuation flag for spells that include the last month of the reference period (TSSI_CFLG)
- Reason receipt began (ESSI_BRSN)
- Reason receipt ended (TSSI_ERSN)
- Payment amount (TSSI_AMT)
- Payment source (ESSI_SRC1 and TSSI_SRC2)

Respondents may report whether they receive their monthly SSI benefit in one or two payments. For each payment, the monthly payment amounts are collected first followed by the payment source. Respondents may report up to five different payment amounts for each source they report in a spell to allow for changes in payments resulting from factors such as cost of living adjustments and earnings variation. The source of each payment is available for analysis, but the amounts are recoded into a single monthly variable. The primary reason for this is respondents who received a combined federal and state payment are not asked to report which portion of the benefit was a federal payment and which portion of the benefit was a supplemental state payment.

Data users should be aware that variable names were standardized across the EHC programs (SNAP, WIC, SSI, TANF, and GA) starting in the 2018 SIPP. To see a side-by-side comparison of SSI variable names in the 2014 SIPP Panel and the 2018 SIPP, please see Section 4.4.14 of the 2018 Survey of Income and Program Participation Users' Guide.

Level of information the SSI data provide

SSI data are collected at the spell level in the EHC and are provided to users in a person-month format. While all data are in a monthly format, the value of the variables may stay the same or vary over time.

Same value for the reference period:

RSSI_YRYN

Same value throughout the spell:

RSSI_MNYN, ESSI_BMONTH, ESSI_EMONTH, ESSI_OWN, TSSI_LCYR, TSSI_CFLG, ESSI_BRSN, TSSI_ERSN

Value may vary within a spell:

TSSI_AMT, ESSI_SRC1, TSSI_SRC2

Other concepts related to the SSI data

Supplemental Security Income (SSI) program description: Supplemental Security Income (SSI) is a means-tested cash assistance program administered by the Social Security Administration with states

having the option to provide supplemental payments. To qualify, a person must meet at least one categorical eligibility requirement for being blind, disabled, or aged 65 or older, as well as have limited income and assets.

4.4.11 Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF)

The Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) section collects information about benefit receipt from the start of the reference period through the interview month (see programmatic details under *Other concepts related to the TANF data*). For each TANF benefit unit, one adult in the household is considered the owner of the TANF benefits (the person in whose name the benefits are received). The TANF owner may or may not be covered by the TANF benefit.

As shown below, all people are assigned values for the reference period and monthly coverage indicators. People who are covered but are not the owner are assigned a value for an additional variable that points to the benefit owner and provides a link to details about the spell. The benefit owner has values assigned for all variables applicable to the spell.

Variables on the public-use file provide the following information for the reference period:

Universe: All people

- Reference period indicator (RTANF_YRYN)
- Monthly coverage indicator (RTANF_MNYN)

Universe: Benefit owner and people who are covered by the benefit

- Benefit owner (ETANF_OWN)

Universe: Benefit owner

- Begin and end month of spell (ETANF_BMONTH and ETANF_EMONTH)
- Year receipt began if receiving in January of the reference period the first time a respondent is interviewed (RTANF_LCYR)
- Continuation flag for spells that include the last month of the reference period (RTANF_CFLG)
- Reason receipt began (TTANF_BRSN)
- Reason receipt ended (TTANF_ERSN)
- Payment amount (TTANF_AMT)
- Coverage type (ETANF_COVTYP)
- Receipt of pass-through child support (ETANF_PTCS)

For each TANF spell, respondents are asked to report the person in whose name the benefit is received (benefit owner), who was covered by the benefit, why receipt began, why receipt ended (if applicable), and payment amount as this information may vary across spells. They are also asked about whether the benefit covered only children, only a pregnant woman, or both children and adults.

If the TANF benefit covered children, then receipt of pass-through child support is asked about.

Data users should be aware that variable names were standardized across the EHC programs (SNAP, WIC, SSI, TANF, and GA) starting in the 2018 SIPP. To see a side-by-side comparison of TANF variable names in the 2014 SIPP Panel and the 2018 SIPP, please see Section 4.4.18 of the 2018 Survey of Income and Program Participation Users' Guide.

Level of information the TANF data provide

TANF data are collected at the spell level in the EHC and are provided to users in a person-month format. While all data are in a monthly format, the value of the variables may stay the same or vary over time.

Same value for the reference period:

RTANF_YRYN

Same value throughout the spell:

RTANF_MNYN, ETANF_BMONTH, ETANF_EMONTH, ETANF_OWN, RTANF_LCYR,
RTANF_CFLG, TTANF_BRSN, TTANF_ERSN

Value may vary within a spell:

TTANF_AMT, ETANF_COVTYP, ETANF_PTCS

Other concepts related to the TANF data

Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) program description: TANF – which depending on where someone lives may have a different state or local name – is an income supplement program serving low-income families with dependent children. Depending on state rules, benefits may cover pregnant women, single parent families, married-couple families, and only children (child-only cases occur when a child's guardian does not qualify for benefits). TANF is funded at the federal level through block grants but administered at the state level.

While parents receive TANF, any court-ordered child support goes directly to the state, which in turn decides whether and how much of the child support payment goes through to the parent and child.¹⁴ This is called pass-through child support, bonus child support, or disregard payments. Some states do not pass any along, some states pass along a portion of the payment, and some states pass the full payment.

¹⁴ For state level information regarding pass through policy see: <<https://www.ncsl.org/human-services/child-support-pass-through-and-disregard-policies-for-public-assistance-recipients>>.

4.4.12 Tax Returns

The Tax Returns sections ask about taxes filed during the reference year, meaning that these questions reference taxes paid on income in the calendar year prior to the reference year.¹⁵ SIPP collects person-level data from respondents aged 15 or older regarding federal tax returns filed during the reference year, specifically:

- Whether the individual filed a tax return during the reference year (for the tax year of the reference year minus one)
- Whether the individual plans to file a return (if no return was filed) for the tax year of the reference year minus one
- Filing status for the tax year of the reference year minus one
 - Single
 - Married filing jointly
 - Married filing separately
 - Head of household
- Whether anyone claimed the respondent as a dependent (respondents between age 15 and 25) for tax year of the reference year minus one
- Whether the individual received an Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC) during the reference year as a result of a filing during the reference year reflecting their income in the tax year of the reference year minus one

Level of information the Tax Returns data provide

Tax Return information is collected at the person level for all household members age 15 or older during the reference year. Children under the age of 15 are not in universe. The Tax Return data are available as person-level variables.

Other concepts related to the Tax Returns data

Earned Income Tax Credit: A tax credit earned by an individual with a tax return filing status of single, head of household, or married filing jointly who has earned income and adjusted gross income within certain limits.

Head of Household: An individual who is unmarried or considered unmarried (unmarried as of the last day of the tax year) who lived with one or more family members and who has paid more than half the cost of keeping the home for the tax year.

¹⁵ For 2025 SIPP respondents, the reference year is calendar year 2024, and tax data were collected regarding their filing for tax year 2023.

Married Filing Jointly: An individual who is married or considered married (married as of the last day of the tax year). To file jointly both the individual and their spouse must agree to file a joint return. On a joint return, you combine income and deduct your combined allowable expenses. A couple can file a joint return even if one had no income or deductions. A joint return tax may be lower than your combined tax for other filing statuses.

Married Filing Separately: A married individual who is responsible only for his or her own taxes or because it results in less tax than filing a joint return.

Single: An individual who is unmarried, considered unmarried (unmarried as of the last day of the tax year), or a widow/widower who does not qualify as head of household, married filing separately, or married filing jointly.

4.4.13 Unemployment Compensation

SIPP collects person-level data from respondents aged 15 or older regarding Unemployment Compensation (UC) receipt, also known as unemployment insurance (UI), at any time during the reference year. Additional questions categorize UC receipt into three different types: regular, supplemental, and other.

The UC section begins by asking whether the respondent received any income from unemployment compensation during the reference year. If so, then the instrument asks about which types of UC were received. The instrument collects data for three types of compensation. The first type is regular, which is the most common type, received from state unemployment agencies and the federal government. The second is supplemental, which includes unemployment insurance paid for privately. The third type is denoted as other in the questionnaire and corresponds to union benefits for which respondents may be eligible if they are members of a union.

For each benefit type reported, the instrument asks for the months of receipt and amounts received. For respondents who received multiple types of UC, once the data about the first type are collected, the instrument moves on to ask about the next type.

Level of information the Unemployment Compensation data provide

Unemployment Compensation data are collected at the person level for all household members who were 15 and older during the reference year. Teenagers who were aged 15 and older during the reference year are in universe for the Unemployment Compensation section. UC amounts are available at the person-month level.

Other concepts related to the Unemployment Compensation data

Covered Employment: “Covered” here refers to being covered by state unemployment insurance programs. Most work for wages falls under the category of covered employment. Exceptions vary by state, but can include independent contractors, sole proprietors or members of a partnership, railroad workers subject to the Federal Railroad Unemployment Insurance Act, some real estate brokers, some

insurance brokers, some agricultural workers, elected officeholders, some church employees, and other exceptions on a state-by-state basis.

Other Unemployment Insurance: This category of unemployment insurance is a catch-all for unemployment compensation not from regular or supplemental unemployment insurance programs. The most common “other” programs correspond to union benefits for which respondents may be eligible if they are members of a union.

Supplemental Unemployment Insurance: This refers to all unemployment insurance plans paid for privately. Some of these are paid for by employees themselves, or by the self-employed. They can be used as an additional wage replacement to regular unemployment compensation, because state UI payments are generally capped at a weekly or monthly amount that may be lower than workers’ full wage rate. These programs are also provided by employers in sectors in which employment is not covered by regular UI plans. Employer-sponsored plans in non-covered employment make up the bulk of supplemental unemployment insurance plans.

Unemployment Insurance (UI)/Unemployment Compensation (UC): This is the name of the programs administered by every state and the District of Columbia that provide assistance to jobless people who are looking for work. In these programs, employers are required to pay a certain amount to the state unemployment agency monthly. The amount paid is tied to each worker’s wage rate and hours worked. These payments fund the unemployment insurance agency. Not all types of employment are covered by UI.

For workers who lose their job, file for UI, and are determined to be eligible for it, these programs provide a payment equal to a percentage of previous earnings. The amount of the payment varies by state. The number of weeks that a worker can receive the benefit also varies by state. During recessions, the federal government often temporarily expands and/or extends UC payments.

4.4.14 Veterans Benefits

The Veterans Benefits section collects person-level data from household members aged 17 or older during the reference year who reported previously serving in the U.S. Armed Forces but are not enlisted at the time of the interview.

SIPP collects the type of veterans benefits and amount received during each month in the reference year. The section begins by asking whether the respondent received veterans benefits at any point during the reference year.

For respondents who report receiving veterans benefits, SIPP asks what type of benefits were received during the reference year. Respondents may report receipt of five separate benefit types:

1. Service-connected disability compensation plan
2. Veterans pension
3. Other VA payments
4. G.I. Bill benefits

5. Insurance proceeds

SIPP asks each VA benefit recipient if he or she was required to complete an Eligibility Verification Report, or EVR, during the reference year in order to receive VA benefits.

For respondents receiving service-connected disability compensation benefits, SIPP collects their disability rating:

1. 0 percent
2. 10-20 percent
3. 30-40 percent
4. 50-60 percent
5. 70+ percent

The instrument collects monthly receipt amounts separately for each benefit type.

Level of information the Veterans Benefits data provide

Receipt of any Veterans Benefits during the reference period, receipt of each specific type of Veterans benefits, EVR requirements, and disability ratings are provided at the person level. Monthly receipt and monthly amounts of each specific type of Veterans benefits are provided at the person-month level.

Additional guidance for using Veterans Benefits data

The Veterans Benefits section collects the type of benefit(s), amount(s) received, and when the amount was received for up to four amount changes during the reference year.

Other concepts related to the Veterans Benefits data

Military Retirement Pay: A retirement pension plan provided for active-duty military personnel with benefits that start when the employee retires.

National Guard Retirement: An Army National Guard employee retirement plan provided for employees who have 20 years of service in the National Guard. By age 60, this retirement plan may be combined with additional income or pensions.

Pension: A benefit plan in which employees and employers pay into a group trust fund. The pension benefits are based on the employee's final pay and the employment tenure with the employer.

Veterans Benefits: A monthly pension administered by the United States Department of Veteran Affairs to active-duty military branch members, their dependents, and their survivors.

Veterans Compensation: A monthly payment administered by the United States Department of Veteran Affairs to veterans, their dependents, and their survivors.

Veterans Pension: A monthly pension administered by the United States Department of Veteran Affairs for veterans who served in the military but did not qualify for military retirement pay.

Reserve Forces Retirement: A retirement pension plan for service members who complete 20 years of service and/or who become eligible for retirement from the Reserve Forces at age 60 or in some cases before age 60 depending on active service.

Service-Connected Disabilities: A disability benefit paid to veterans disabled by injury or illness during active duty. Monthly benefits vary with the type of disability and the number of eligible dependents.

4.4.15 Workers' Compensation

The Workers' Compensation section collects data for household members aged 15 or older regarding Workers' Compensation benefits received during the reference period.

The section begins by asking if the respondent received any Workers' Compensation benefits since the beginning of the reference period. If respondents replied that they have received benefits, the instrument then asks if they receive benefits now. If not, they are asked the month in which they last received benefits. Benefit amounts are collected by moving backwards chronologically, either from the interview month if they currently receive benefits or the last month they received benefits, to the start of when receipt began. Respondents can report up to four amounts received and start months. If the respondent received more than four different monthly amounts throughout the reference period, the instrument asks the amount of benefit received during the first start month of the reference period.

Level of information the Workers' Compensation data provide

Receipt of any Workers' Compensation during the reference period is provided at the person level. Monthly receipt and monthly amounts of Workers' Compensation are provided at the person-month level.

Other concepts related to the Workers' Compensation data

Workers' Compensation: Employer's insurance providing wage and medical benefits to an employee who is injured during the course of employment. Workers' Compensation insurance is required by almost every state. Rules and requirements may vary by state. An employer pays for Workers' Compensation and the employer is covered for work-related accidents. Workers' Compensation benefits can help pay for medical and hospital bills. They also can be provided if the employee cannot return to work. If an employee dies due to a work-related accident, Workers' Compensation insurance can also pay an insurance benefit to the family.

Workers' Compensation Payments: Plans and coverage may vary. Plans can make weekly payments in place of wages (similar to disability insurance), compensation for loss in wages, and reimbursement or payment of medical and health care expenses (similar to health insurance). Workers' Compensation benefits can be payable to families of workers killed during employment (similar to life insurance). Most states have Workers' Compensation coverage requirements; however, some states do not require Workers' Compensation coverage for specific industries such as agriculture and some small private-sector employers.

Job-Related Injury: An injury that occurred while working or because of a work-related role.

Job-Related Illness: An occupational-related disease or disability that occurred as a result of a work-related role or during employment.

4.5 Retirement Income

4.5.1 Life Insurance Retirement Income

SIPP collects person- and person-month-level data on retirement income from a paid-up life insurance policy during the reference year for respondents aged 30 or older who report ever being retired.

Specifically, life insurance retirement income content collects:

- Whether the payment was received as a lump-sum
- Each month of receipt
- The total amount received during the reference year

Level of information the Life Insurance Retirement Income data provide

Life insurance retirement income is collected at the person level for all household members ages 30 or older who report ever being retired. Individuals under age 30 or who report not ever being retired are not in universe for the annuity/life insurance retirement income section. The life insurance retirement income data are person-level variables, but there is a person-month-level receipt indicator.

Additional guidance for using the Life Insurance Retirement Income data

The life insurance retirement income section collects whether income was received (ELIFEYN), whether that income was received as a lump sum (ELIFEREG), the total amount received across the reference period (TLIFEAMT), and the month(s) when the payments were received (ELIFEMNYN).

Other concepts related to the Life Insurance Retirement Income data

Paid-up Life Insurance Policy: A whole life insurance policy, universal life insurance policy, or permanent policy that provides a benefit upon death of the policyholder and accumulates cash value over time, enabling benefits to be paid in the event that the policyholder voluntarily terminates the insurance policy before death or the insured event occurred. The paid-up value is the sum of money that the insurance company will pay to the policyholder in the event that the policyholder voluntarily terminates the life insurance policy.

Retirement Income: Payments received based on length of service at retirement, age of retirement, and other employer retirement requirements. Examples of retirement income include U.S. Government Railroad Retirement; pension from a company, union, federal civilian employee pension; U.S. military retirement pay; retainer pay; National Guard retirement, Reserve Forces retirement; state government pension; local government pension; and any pension type other than Social Security.

Retirement Income from Life Insurance: Individuals with a sufficient number of years of service or who have a disability may retire before reaching age 65 with a pension plan that includes life insurance.

Individuals employed in hazardous occupations such as law enforcement may be eligible to retire with a pension that includes a paid-up life insurance policy or annuity as early as age 40 if they have completed 20 or more years of service.

4.5.2 Pension Income

SIPP collects person-level data regarding whether an individual aged 30 or older received pension income during the reference year, including the type of income and amount received during each month of the reference year.

For respondents who report receiving pension income, SIPP collects which type(s), specifically:

- Federal Civil Service or other Federal Civilian employee pension
- Local government pension
- Military retirement pay
- National Guard or Reserve Forces retirement
- Pension from a company or union including income from a profit-sharing plan
- State government pension
- U.S. Government Railroad Retirement
- Other pension income

SIPP then collects separate monthly amounts for each type of pension income, as well as any lump sum pension income received. Respondents can report up to four amounts received and start months for each of the pension benefits. If the respondent received more than four different monthly amounts throughout the reference year for any one pension income benefit type, the instrument asks the amount of money that the respondent received during the first start month.

Level of information the Pension Income data provide

Retirement income information is collected at the person-month level for all respondents who report every being retired. The Retirement income data are available in the form of person-month-level variables on months of receipt (ERET[1-8]MNYN) and amount received (TRET[1-8]AMT), as well as a person-level variable for receipt of lump sum pension income (TPENLUMPAMT). Additionally, these data include person-level reference period indicators for receipt of any pension (EPENANY) or other retirement (ERETANY) income, receipt of a specific type of pension or retirement income (ERETTyp[1-8]YN), and continuation flags indicating whether receipt continued after the reference period (TRET[1-8]_CFLG).

Other concepts related to the Pension Income data

Federal Civilian Employee Pension or Federal Employees Retirement System (FERS): A civilian retirement pension for civilian federal employees who began their employment after 1987.

Federal Civil Service Pension: A retirement pension for civilian federal employees who began their civilian federal employment between 1920 and 1987.

Local Government Pension: A pension plan for vested local government employees.

Military Retirement Pay: Retirement pension plan provided for active-duty military personnel with benefits that start when the employee retires.

National Guard Retirement: Army National Guard employee retirement plan provided for employees who have 20 years of service in the Guard by age 60 and may be combined with any additional income or retirement pension plan.

Other Retirement Income: Income provided for employee retirement, such as an Individual Retirement Account (IRA).

Pension: An employee benefits plan in which employees and employers pay into a group trust fund. The payment benefits are based on a formula factoring an employee's final pay and employment tenure with an employer.

Reserve Forces Retirement: A retirement pension plan for service members who complete 20 years of service and who become eligible for retirement from the Reserve Forces at age 60. Reserve service members may begin retirement benefits before age 60 if they deploy for war or national emergency. Effective January 2008, for every consecutive 90 days that service members are mobilized, their annuity start date is reduced three by months.

State Government Pension: A pension plan for vested state government employees.

U.S. Government Railroad Retirement: A federally administered retirement program established for railroad employees and employers. The program provides retirement, unemployment, sickness, disability, spousal, and survivor benefits. Tier 1 benefits take the place of Social Security and are first payable at age 62 or after 30 years of service for early retirement. The first full retirement benefits are payable for retired employees between the ages of 65 and 67. The Tier 2 benefits are similar to a private pension retirement plan.

4.5.3 Retirement Account Withdrawals

SIPP collects person-level data from respondents aged 15 years and older as of December of the reference year about their ownership of retirement accounts. SIPP asks about three types of accounts, described in further detail in Section 4.2.1: (1) 401(k), 403(b), and Thrift Savings plans, (2) Individual Retirement Account (IRA) and Keogh accounts, and (3) defined benefit and cash balance plans.

SIPP asks all respondents who owned either a (1) 401(k), 403(b), and Thrift Savings plan or (2) Individual Retirement Account (IRA) and Keogh account whether they received any income or made withdrawals from their account at any point during the reference year (ETHR_INC_YN and EIRA_INC_YN). If respondents reported receiving income from their retirement account(s), they were then asked to report the total amount received during the reference year (TTHR_INC_AMT and TIRA_INC_AMT).

Level of information on the Retirement Account Withdrawals data provide

Data on retirement account withdrawals are collected at the person level for all household members who owned at least one of the following account types: (1) 401(k), 403(b), and Thrift Savings plan or (2) Individual Retirement Account (IRA) and Keogh account.

Other concepts related to the Retirement Account Withdrawals data

401(k), 403(b), and Thrift Savings plans: A 401(k) is a personal retirement plan which allows employees or self-employed individuals to set aside an amount of money each year for retirement. These plans are established through employers, and employers may offer matching contributions up to a specific limit. A 403(b) plan is a retirement plan for certain employees of public schools, employees of certain tax-exempt organizations, and certain ministries.

Individual Retirement Accounts (IRAs): An IRA is a personal retirement plan which allows individuals to set aside an amount of money each year for retirement. Earnings on all amounts contributed to any IRA accumulate on a tax-deferred, and potentially tax-free, basis. These plans are often established by individuals, but may also be established by employers and can include traditional IRAs, IRA annuities, SEP-IRA (Simplified Employee Pension Plan IRA), Roth IRA, Education IRA, SIMPLE IRA (Savings Incentive Match Plans for Employees), or self-directed retirement accounts (IRAs held by brokerages).

Keogh Plans: A Keogh (or H.R. 10 plan) refers to a qualified retirement plan maintained by a self-employed individual, either a sole proprietor or a partner. The self-employed individual may take a tax deduction for annual contributions to the plan made on behalf of the individual and on behalf of any eligible employees.

4.5.4 Retirement Income Recode

The SIPP includes a retirement income recode, TRETINCAMT, which sums income from pensions, retirement accounts, and retirement income from life insurance. TRETINCAMT is a person-month level variable. Income from paid-up life insurance policies and lump sum withdrawals from pensions and retirement accounts are reported at the annual level in SIPP. To construct TRETINCAMT, these annual level variables are divided by 12 and added to the monthly pension income variables.

Respondents may also report income received from disability or survivor provisions of a pension or other retirement plan. This income is captured by TDIS1AMT–TDIS10AMT and TSUR1AMT–TSUR13AMT and is not included in TRETINCAMT. Because TRETINCAMT aggregates income that is already captured in other income recodes, it does not flow directly into the total personal income recode (refer to section 4.7 for more information on the variables that do flow into the total personal income recode).

4.6 Other Income

4.6.1 Disability Income

SIPP collects person-level data about whether an individual between the ages of 15 and 69 who reported a work-limiting health condition received disability income at any time during the reference year. The data

collected in the SIPP include the type of disability payment and the amount received during each month of the reference year. The disability income content includes the monthly amount received by benefit type.

The Disability income section begins by asking if the respondent received any income due to a health condition during the reference year. If so, respondents are then asked which type(s) of disability benefit was/were received:

1. Payments from a sickness, accident, or disability insurance policy
2. Employer disability payments
3. Pension from a company or union including income from a profit-sharing plan
4. Federal Civil Service or other Federal civilian employee pension
5. State government pension
6. Local government pension
7. U.S. Military retirement pay
8. U.S. Government Railroad Retirement
9. Black Lung benefits
10. Other disability income

Note that Social Security Disability Insurance (SSDI) payments are collected in the Social Security on Behalf of Oneself section rather than in the disability income section. Supplemental Security Income (SSI) payments are also captured in separate variables.

Level of information the Disability Income data provide

Disability income data are collected at the person-month level for all household members who were between the ages of 15 and 69 during the reference year who had a work-limiting health condition (EDISABL). Household members under the age of 15 at the end of the reference year and those over the age of 69 at the end of the reference year are not in universe for the disability income section, nor are those without a work-limiting health condition. The Disability income data include a person-level variable indicating receipt of any disability income (EDISANY), person-level indicators of receipt of each type of disability income (EDISTYP[1-10]YN), and person-month level indicators of receipt of a given type of income (EDIS[1-10]MNYN) and the amount received (TDIS[1-10]AMT). An additional variable captures whether respondents who received income from a sickness, accident, or disability insurance policy purchased that policy on his/her own (EDISTYPTWO).

Other concepts related to the Disability Income data

Black Lung Benefits: United States Government program enacted in 1973 to provide monthly payments and medical benefits to coal miners who have disability from pneumoconiosis as a result of employment in and around the United States' coal mines. The act also provides monthly benefits to a miner's dependent survivors if black lung disease caused the miner's death.

Disability: An impairment that may be physical, cognitive, mental, hearing, vision, sensory, emotional, developmental, chronic disease, or some combination thereof.

Disability Insurance: An insurance policy that provides the policyholder benefits in the event that he or she becomes sick or injured.

Federal Civilian Employee Pension, or Federal Employees Retirement System (FERS): A civilian retirement pension for civilian federal employees who began their employment after 1987. It may also provide disability benefits.

Federal Civil Service Pension: A retirement pension for civilian federal employees who began their civilian federal employment between 1920 and 1987. It may also provide disability benefits.

Local Government Pension: An employee retirement plan for vested local government employees. Such plans often provide disability benefits.

Military Retirement Pay: The retirement pension plan provided for active-duty military personnel with benefits that start when the employee retires. It potentially provides disability benefits.

National Guard Retirement: An Army National Guard retirement plan provided for employees who have 20 years of service in the National Guard. By age 60, this retirement pension may be combined with any additional income or retirement. National Guard Retirement potentially provides disability benefits.

Other Disability Income: Supplementary income in the event of illness or accident that prevents the insured from working at their employment.

Pension: An employee benefits plan in which employees and employers pay into a group trust fund. The payment benefits are based on a formula factoring an employee's final pay and employment tenure with an employer.

Reserve Forces Retirement: A retirement pension plan for service members who complete 20 years of service and who become eligible for retirement from the Reserve Forces at age 60. Reserve service members may begin retirement benefits before age 60 if they deploy for war or national emergency. Effective January 2008, for every consecutive 90 days that service members are mobilized, their annuity start date is reduced three months.

Sickness and Accident Insurance: A type of disability insurance that provides coverage when the policyholder becomes sick, injured, or dies from an accident.

State Government Pension: An employee retirement plan for vested state government employees. Such plans often provide disability benefits.

U.S. Government Railroad Retirement: A federally administered retirement program established for railroad employees and employers. The program provides retirement, unemployment, sickness, disability, spousal, and survivor benefits. Tier 1 benefits take the place of Social Security and are first payable at age 62 or after 30 years of service for early retirement. The first full retirement benefits are payable for retired employee between the ages of 65 and 67. The Tier 2 benefits are similar to a private pension retirement plan.

4.6.2 Miscellaneous Income

SIPP collects person-level data from respondents aged 15 or older regarding miscellaneous income receipt at any time during the reference year. The section begins by asking if the respondent received money or income from any of the following sources during the reference year:

- Community or religious charity
- Family or friends
- Roomers or boarders
- Estates
- Incidental or casual earnings
- Miscellaneous cash income, such as lottery winnings
- National Guard or Reserve Pay

If a respondent reports receiving any of the seven miscellaneous income sources, the respondent is then asked how much income was received during the reference year from all the miscellaneous sources.

Level of information the Miscellaneous Income data provide

Miscellaneous Income is collected for all household members who were aged 15 or older at some point during the reference year. The Miscellaneous Income data include person-level indicators of receipt of a given type of income (EMINC_TYP1YN-EMINC_TYP7YN) and the amount received (TMINC_AMT). An additional variable captures whether respondents received any income from one or more miscellaneous sources during the reference year (RMINC_ANY).

Other concepts related to the Miscellaneous Income data

Community Charity: An organization formed for the purpose of collecting and distributing benefits to support individuals, families, and children. Community charities include churches, social organizations, and government assistance programs.

Estates: An individual's property, entitlements, and obligations.

Incidental or Casual Earnings: Income or profit generated from informal, occasional, or irregular periods of receipt or employment.

Miscellaneous Cash Income: Any cash income that does not fall into a specific category.

National Guard or Reserve Pay: Any pay received while on duty (active or temporary) as a member of the National Guard or the Guard Reserve of any branch of the Armed Forces.

Religious Charity: A for-profit or not-for-profit organization whose purpose, membership, and leadership regard the observance of faith or vow of faith. A religious charity may manage a house of worship, provide payment to religious leadership, or provide payment to a religious organization.

Roomers or Boarders: Housing unit residents who rent a housing unit or section for one night or more. The housing rental agreement may include meals and dining facilities.

Short-Term Cash Assistance: Any assistance received from a government agency, charitable organization such as a church, community organization, or family and friends. This does not include TANF, General Assistance, or long-term assistance from any source.

Trusts: A contract administered by a trustee for the distribution of money or property to a beneficiary.

4.6.3 Support Paid

SIPP collects the following information from parents of children under 21 years of age living outside their household:

- The number of children under 21 years of age living outside their household
- If the parents made payments to support those children
- How much support was paid during the previous calendar year
- How often the respondent spent time with the children during the previous calendar year

All respondents aged 15 years and older are asked if they provided financial support to people living outside their household, including:

- Their parent or parents
- Children 21 years and older
- Other related person(s)
- Ex-spouse(s) or ex-partner(s)
- Other unrelated people.

For each category, the number of persons supported is collected, as well as the annual amount paid during the previous calendar year.

Level of information the Support Paid data provide

The support paid data are collected at the person level. Annual amounts of support paid are available at the person level.

Other concepts related to the Support Paid data

In-kind child support paid: Beginning in 2022, the SIPP collects person data about in-kind support paid to the other parent (outside of child support payments). This support may include food or groceries, clothes, or diapers for the child(ren). It can also include payments for medical expenses or childcare. Ranges of annual amounts provided are available at the person level.

4.6.4 Support Received

SIPP collects person-level data about monetary payments that the respondent received for foster child care, child support, and alimony (spousal support) at any time during the reference year.

- Foster Child Care – Asked of guardians aged 15 and older, about whether they received foster child support payments for their foster child(ren) under 18 years of age, from the state in which they lived.
- Child Support – Asked of parents or guardians aged 15 and older, who did not previously report receiving pass-through child support payments about whether they received child support payments for their child(ren) under 21 years of age from the child(ren)'s parent(s) who lived outside their household.¹⁶ Respondents are asked if child support payments were ever court ordered or informally agreed upon.
- Alimony – Asked of respondents aged 15 and older, who are currently divorced or separated, about whether they received alimony or spousal support payments from a former spouse.

The collection of Support Received information is important as SIPP attempts to measure the amounts of inter-household transfer payments that occur, as well as whom those payments are supporting. Collecting amounts of support received allows us to compare and contrast with amounts reported by respondents who pay support for their child(ren) and other persons living outside their household. The collection of monthly Support Received income amounts allows users to identify regular and irregular receipt of these income sources.

Level of information the Support Received data provide

Support Received content is collected at the person level. Amounts of support received are available at the person-month level.

Other concepts related to the Support Received data

In-kind child support received: Beginning in 2022, the SIPP collects person data about in-kind support received from the other parent (outside of child support payments). This support may include food or groceries, clothes, or diapers for the child(ren). It can also include payments for medical expenses or childcare. Ranges of annual amounts received are available at the person level.

¹⁶ In some cases when a person receives TANF or state program payments, the state agency tries to establish a child support order from the absent parent and becomes the collector of child support on behalf of the person receiving TANF benefits. In some states a portion or all of these collected payments are sent to the custodial parent. These payments are called 'pass through', 'disregard', or 'bonus' child support.

4.6.5 Survivor Income

SIPP collects data about whether widows or widowers aged 15 years and older received survivor income benefits at any time during the reference year. Respondents report the type(s) received:

- Black Lung benefits
- Federal Civil Service or other federal civilian employee pension
- Income from a paid-up life insurance policy or annuity
- Local government pension
- Military retirement pay
- National Guard or Reserve Forces retirement
- Payments from an estate or trust
- Pension from a company or union, including income from a profit-sharing plan
- State government pension
- U.S. Government Railroad Retirement
- Veterans' compensation or pension
- Workers' Compensation
- Other survivor income

Level of information the Survivor Income data provide

Survivor income benefit information is available at the person-month level for each adult household member 15 years and older who is a widow/widower. The survivor income data include a person-level variable indicating receipt of any survivor income (ESURANY), person-level indicators of receipt of each type of survivor income (ESURTYP[1-13]YN), and person-month level indicators of receipt of a given type of income (ESUR[1-13]MNYN) and the amount received (TSUR[1-13]AMT).

Other concepts related to the Survivor Income data

Annuity: An annuity is a pension plan purchased by a policyholder at his or her retirement or during his or her working years to guarantee a regular income after retirement. Some annuity contracts provide guaranteed distribution for a set number of payments and some provide payment until death. SIPP includes all such annuities purchased by the person, except those already reported as part of the employee pension.

Black Lung Benefits: Black Lung Disability refers to the federal program beginning in 1973 that provides pension to coal miners who have disability from pneumoconiosis or to their dependent survivors.

Estate: An individual's property, entitlements, and obligations.

Federal Civil Service Pension: The Civil Service Retirement Act of 1920 provided a retirement system for federal employees who began their civil service employment between 1920 and 1987. CSRS is a contributory retirement system, and employees share in the expense of annuities.

Federal Civilian Employee Pension: The Federal Employees Retirement System (FERS) is the retirement system for federal employees who began their civil service employment after 1987. FERS provides retirement income benefits from three sources: a basic benefit plan, Social Security, and Thrift Savings Plan. Two of the three parts of FERS can go with employees to their next job if they leave the Federal Government. The federal agency withholds the cost of the basic benefit and Social Security from their pay as payroll deductions.

Local Government Pension: Also known as a public pension plan, this is the local government employee retirement plan for vested local government employees.

4.7 Income and Poverty Recodes

Unlike the preceding content areas, data on total income and poverty status are not collected directly from the SIPP instrument, but instead are aggregated or assigned based on existing survey content. The following sections describe these aggregations.

4.7.1 Income Recodes

SIPP creates aggregated income recodes at the person, family, and household levels. The income recodes aggregate reported income from the Assets, Employment and Earnings, Program Participation and Income Transfers, Retirement Income, and Other Income sections of the SIPP.

For detailed information on the individual components of the Income Recodes, refer to their respective sections of this Users' Guide.

Total Personal Income (TPTOTINC) is created from:

TPEARN_ALT	Alternate recode of earnings and profits/losses from all jobs stabilized to accommodate months of varying length
TPPRPINC	Total personal investment/property income
TPTRNINC	Total personal means-tested transfer income
TPSCININC	Total personal social insurance income
TPOTHINC	Total personal other income

Total Personal Earnings (TPEARN_ALT) is created from:

The income types included in this variable are wage and salary income, bonus payments, commissions, overtime payments, tips, other income from self-employed businesses, self-employed business profits, and accounting for time spent away from a job without pay. TPEARN_ALT is the alternate recode of earnings and profits from all jobs.

TPEARN_ALT differs from TPEARN by removing all variation in earnings due to variation in the length of a month. For example, TPEARN assigns earnings in February based on it being 28 or 29 days in length, TPEARN_ALT assigns earnings in February assuming it has the same length as all other months.¹⁷

Total Personal Investment & Property Income (TPPRPINC) is created from:¹⁸

TINC_BANK	Income earned from interest-earning assets held at financial institutions, created from:
TJSCHKINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned checking accounts [for respondents with a spouse in the household; this joint amount question is asked of only one spouse, and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records]
TJOCHKINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned checking accounts [for respondents without a spouse in the household]
TOCHKINC	Total interest income earned from individually-owned checking accounts
TJSSAVINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned savings accounts [for respondents with a spouse in the household; this joint amount question is asked of only one spouse, and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records]

¹⁷ For more information refer to *TPEARN Historical Comparison User Note* which compares RPEARN and RPEARN_ALT at <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/tpearn-hist-comp-user-note.html>.

¹⁸ For additional details about universes for variables with a “TJS” or “TJO” prefix, please refer to the user note *2020 SIPP: Universe for Jointly Owned Assets* at <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2020-usernotes/2020-univ-joint-held-assets-debts.html>.

TJOSAVINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned savings accounts [for respondents without a spouse in the household]
TOSAVINC	Total interest income earned from individually-owned savings accounts
TJSCDINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned certificates of deposit [for respondents with a spouse in the household; this joint amount question is asked of only one spouse, and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records]
TJ OCDINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned certificates of deposit [for respondents without a spouse in the household]
TOCDINC	Total interest income earned from individually-owned certificates of deposit
TJSMMINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned money market deposit accounts and money market funds [for respondents with a spouse in the household; this joint amount question is asked of only one spouse, and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records]
TJOMMINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned money market deposit accounts and money market funds [for respondents without a spouse in the household]
TOMMINC	Share of total interest income earned from individually-owned money market deposit accounts and money market funds
TINC_BOND	Income earned from other interest-earning assets, created from:
TJSGOVSINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned government securities [for respondents with a spouse in the household; this joint amount question is asked of only one spouse, and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records]

TJOGOVSINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned government securities [for respondents without a spouse in the household]
TOGOVSINC	Total interest income earned from individually-owned government securities
TJSMCBDINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned municipal and corporate bonds [for respondents with a spouse in the household; this joint amount question is asked of only one spouse, and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records]
TJOMCBDINC	Share of total interest income earned from jointly-owned municipal and corporate bonds [for respondents without a spouse in the household]
TOMCBDINC	Total interest income earned from individually-owned municipal and corporate bonds
TINC_STMF	Income earned from stocks and mutual funds, created from:
TJSMFINC	Share of dividend income earned from jointly-owned mutual funds [for respondents with a spouse in the household; this joint amount question is asked of only one spouse, and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records]
TJOMFINC	Share of dividend income earned from jointly-owned mutual funds [for respondents without a spouse in the household]
TOMFINC	Total dividend income earned from individually-owned mutual funds
TJSSTINC	Share of dividend income earned from jointly-owned stocks [for respondents with a spouse in the household; this joint amount question is asked of only one spouse, and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records]
TJOSTINC	Share of dividend income earned from jointly-owned stocks [for respondents without a spouse in the household]
TOSTINC	Total dividend income earned from individually-owned stocks

TINC_RENT	Net income from rental properties, created from:
TJSRPNETINC	Share of net income earned from jointly-owned rental property [for respondents with a spouse in the household; this joint amount question is asked of only one spouse, and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records]
TJORPNETINC	Share of net income earned from jointly-owned rental property [for respondents without a spouse in the household]
TORPNETINC	Net income earned from individually-owned rental property
TINC_OTH	Net income from other assets, created from:
TANNINC	Amount of income received from annuities
TTRINC	Amount of income received from trusts
TOINVINC	Amount of income received from other financial investments

Total Means-Tested Transfer Payments (TPTRNINC) is created from:

TTANF_AMT	Amount received from monthly TANF benefit
TSSI_AMT	Amount received from monthly SSI benefit
TGA_AMT	Amount received from monthly GA benefit
TVA2AMT	Amount received from monthly Veterans' pension

Total Social Insurance Payments (TPSCININC) is created from:

TVA1AMT	Amount received from VA benefit payments for a service-connected disability
TVA3AMT	Amount received from other VA payments
TVA4AMT	Amount received for G.I. Bill benefits
TVA5AMT	Amount received from VA Insurance proceeds
TWCAMT	Amount received in workers' compensation
TUC1AMT	Amount of regular unemployment compensation received
TUC2AMT	Amount of supplemental unemployment compensation received
TUC3AMT	Amount of other unemployment compensation received

TSSSAMT	Amount received in Social Security benefit payments
TSSCAMT	Amount received in Social Security benefit payments on behalf of a child(ren)

Total Other Income (TPOTHINC) is created from:

TSUR1AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from a pension from a company or union including income from a profit-sharing plan
TSUR2AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from Veterans' compensation or pension
TSUR3AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from a Federal civil service or other Federal civilian employee pension
TSUR4AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from U.S. Government Railroad Retirement
TSUR5AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from a state government pension
TSUR6AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from a local government pension
TSUR7AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from income from a paid-up life insurance
TSUR8AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from military retirement pay
TSUR9AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from Black Lung Benefits
TSUR10AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from workers' compensation
TSUR11AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from payments from an estate or trust
TSUR12AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from National Guard or Reserve Forces retirement
TSUR13AMT	Amount received in survivor benefits from other survivor income
TRET1AMT	Amount received in retirement income from a pension from a company or union including income from a profit-sharing plan
TRET2AMT	Amount received in retirement income from Federal civil service or other Federal civilian employee pension
TRET3AMT	Amount received in retirement income from state government pension
TRET4AMT	Amount received in retirement income from local government pension
TRET5AMT	Amount received in retirement income from military retirement pay

TRET6AMT	Amount received in retirement income from U.S. Government Railroad Retirement
TRET7AMT	Amount received in retirement income from National Guard or Reserve Forces retirement
TRET8AMT	Amount received in retirement income from other retirement income
TDIS1AMT	Amount received in payments from a sickness, accident, or disability insurance policy
TDIS2AMT	Amount received in payments from employer disability payments
TDIS3AMT	Amount received in pension from a company or union including income from a profit-sharing plan
TDIS4AMT	Amount received in payments from Federal civil service or other Federal civilian employee pension
TDIS5AMT	Amount received from a state government pension
TDIS6AMT	Amount received from a local government pension
TDIS7AMT	Amount received from military retirement pay
TDIS8AMT	Amount received from U.S. Government Railroad Retirement
TDIS9AMT	Amount received in payments from Black Lung Benefits
TDIS10AMT	Amount received from other disability income
TFCCAMT	Amount of foster child care payments received
TCSAMT	Amount of child support payments received
TALIAMT	Amount of alimony payments received
TLMPAMT	Amount of lump sum payment received (excluding income rolled over)
TDEFERAMT	Amount received as a deferred payment or final paycheck from a job or business that ended during the reference period
TLIFEAMT	Amount received from a paid-up life insurance policy or annuity
TMINC_AMT	Amount of miscellaneous income received
TIRA_INC_AMT	Amount of income or withdrawals received during the reference period from any IRA or Keogh account(s)

TTHR_INC_AMT Amount of income or withdrawals received during the reference period from any 401(k), 403(b), or Thrift Savings Plan account(s)

TPENLUMPAMT Amount of lump sum pension payments received during the reference period

Level of information the Income Recodes data provide

The income recodes are calculated for each month by summing income sources. For income sources reported annually, reported income is allocated evenly across the months of the reference year by dividing by 12. To avoid double counting, transfer payment amounts that are family or household based are only placed on the record of the family member identified as the benefit owner.

Additional guidance for using Income Recodes data

The SIPP instrument creates aggregate monthly income recodes at the person, family, and household levels. Additional recodes are created at the person level based on income source. [Table 4-4](#) ~~Table 4-4~~ lists these recodes.

TABLE 4-4. INCOME RECODES

Aggregate			Description
Person	Family	Household	
TPTOTINC	TFTOTINC	THTOTINC	Total monthly income excluding Type-2 people
	TFTOTINCT2	THTOTINCT2	Total monthly income including Type-2 people
Components			Description
Person	Family	Household	
TPEARN_ALT			Monthly earnings: The sum of gross earnings, wages, and salary, and/or the amount of monthly income (positive or negative) from self-employment for each job and/or business recorded for the reference month. This recode is stabilized to accommodate months of varying length
TPPRPINC			Monthly investment and property income: The sum of dividend, interest, and property/rental income
TPTRNINC			Monthly means-tested transfer payments: The sum of all means-tested cash transfers (e.g., SSI, GA, TANF)
TPSCININC			Monthly social insurance payments: The sum of non-means-tested social insurance program transfers (e.g., Social Security, unemployment compensation)

TPOTHINC			Monthly income from other sources: The sum of support payments (e.g., alimony, child support), retirement income (e.g., pensions), and any other income not captured elsewhere
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Other concepts related to the Income Recodes data

Family income: Family-level income variables include the income of all household members related by birth, marriage, or adoption in a given month. In other words, primary family members, including related subfamily members, are treated as one family by the Census Bureau when calculating family-level income amounts.

Household income: Household-level income variables include the income of all household members in a given month.

Distribution of Annual Income: For income sources reported annually, reported income is allocated evenly across the months of the reference year by dividing by 12.

Reporting of Joint Income: To avoid double counting, transfer payment amounts that are family based are only placed on the record of the family member identified as the owner of the benefit. For respondents with a spouse in the household, income from jointly owned accounts is asked of only one spouse and this response is divided by 2 and copied to both spouses' records.

4.7.2 Poverty Recodes

Poverty Recodes are assigned based on family and household composition as well as the aggregate Income Recodes.

Monthly family poverty status (TFINCPOV) is one of the most frequently used variables by SIPP users. This monthly measure of poverty allows data users to evaluate the movement of families into and out of poverty over the course of the reference period. The SIPP includes additional monthly and annual variables that data users can use to measure the ability of a family or household to meet their basic needs, both with and without Type 2 individuals.

Level of information the Poverty Recodes data provide

The monthly poverty thresholds are assigned based on the composition of a family or household in a given month, depending on the variable being used. The monthly poverty thresholds are also adjusted to reflect changes in the Consumer Price Index for all Urban Consumers (CPI-U) across months.

The “base” annual poverty thresholds from 1982 are available on the Census Bureau’s website at www.census.gov/data/tables/time-series/demo/income-poverty/historical-poverty-thresholds.html. These annual thresholds are converted to monthly thresholds by dividing by 12 and adjusting for inflation based on the difference in the reference month CPI-U and the 1982 annual CPI-U value.

Once the appropriate monthly threshold is assigned, income-to-poverty ratios are calculated by dividing topcoded total family (or household) income by the appropriate threshold. If the resulting ratio is less than 1, then that family (or household), and all individuals in it, are in poverty for the given month.

For individuals with a valid poverty threshold in each month of the reference period, annual income-to-poverty ratios are calculated. Values are based on the annual sum of the individual's monthly total family (or household) income divided by the annual sum of the individual's monthly poverty thresholds (reflecting changing family or household composition over the reference period). The resulting annual values are then divided to calculate the individual's annual income-to-poverty ratio.

Monthly Variables:

Thresholds

RFPOV	Family poverty threshold in this month, excluding Type 2 individuals
RFPOVT2	Family poverty threshold in this month, including Type 2 individuals
RHPOV	Household poverty threshold in this month, excluding Type 2 individuals
RHPOVT2	Household poverty threshold in this month, including Type 2 individuals

Poverty Status

TFINCPOV	Family income-to-poverty ratio in this month, excluding Type 2 individuals
TFINCPOVT2	Family income-to-poverty ratio in this month, including Type 2 individuals
THINCPOV	Household income-to-poverty ratio in this month, excluding Type 2 individuals
THINCPOVT2	Household income-to-poverty ratio in this month, including Type 2 individuals

Annual Variables:

Poverty Status

TFCYINCPOV	Family income-to-poverty ratio in this calendar year, excluding Type 2 individuals
TFCYINCPOVT2	Family income-to-poverty ratio in this calendar year, including Type 2 individuals
THCYINCPOV	Household income-to-poverty ratio in this calendar year, excluding Type 2 individuals
THCYINCPOVT2	Household income-to-poverty ratio in this calendar year, including Type 2 individuals

Other concepts related to the Poverty Recodes data

Family: A family is defined as all household members related by birth, marriage, or adoption in a given month. In other words, primary family members, including related subfamily members, are treated as one family by the Census Bureau when creating family assignments. For information on the relationship variables, see the Family and Household Relationships Section, (Section 4.1.4.). When poverty status is determined at the family level, all family members have the same poverty status.

Household: A household consists of all people who occupy a housing unit, regardless of their relationships to each other. Household-level poverty status is based on the income of all household members in a given month. When poverty status is determined at the household level, all household members have the same poverty status.

Income-to-Poverty Ratios: Income-to-poverty ratios are calculated by dividing total family or household income by the appropriate threshold. Resulting values below 1 indicate a family/household is “in poverty,” with values closer to 1 indicating that a family/household is closer to meeting their threshold. Values equal to or above 1 indicate a family is not in poverty.

5 Resources and Research

5.1 SIPP Website

The SIPP website at www.census.gov/sipp offers a comprehensive set of resources, including:

- SIPP data files for all panels and years
- An online metadata codebook
- User notes detailing data nuances and issues
- Questionnaires and instrument specifications
- Variable crosswalks
- Source and Accuracy Statements
- Nonresponse Bias Reports
- SIPP-based research products

Data and documentation released by the Census Bureau are not copyrighted. The data files and supporting documentation can therefore be freely copied and distributed to others.

5.1.1 Data

5.1.1.1 Direct Download

Users can access the 2025 SIPP microdata via the *2025 SIPP Data* webpage located at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/data.html. This webpage provides datasets and links to supporting documentation. The 2025 SIPP data are available in STATA, SAS, and pipe-delimited text file formats. To facilitate downloads, each file format is compressed using both ZIP (.zip) and GZIP (.gz) compression methods. ZIP compression is commonly used in Windows and Mac environments, while GZIP compression is commonly used in GNU/Linux environments.

5.1.1.2 Microdata Access Tool (MDAT)

The *Microdata Access Tool (MDAT)* available at <https://data.census.gov/mdat/> enables users to create custom tabulations and data extracts from the SIPP microdata. For custom extracts, identification (ID) variables must be activated in the “Type” column filter to search and select these items. MDAT-based SIPP tables can include duplicate records if incorrect universing is used. We recommend that users have experience working with SIPP data or review the respective Users’ Guide and/or Technical Documentation for the specific panel/year before creating tables with MDAT. For assistance, please contact the SIPP Coordination and Outreach Staff via the “Contact Us” webpage located at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/contact.html.

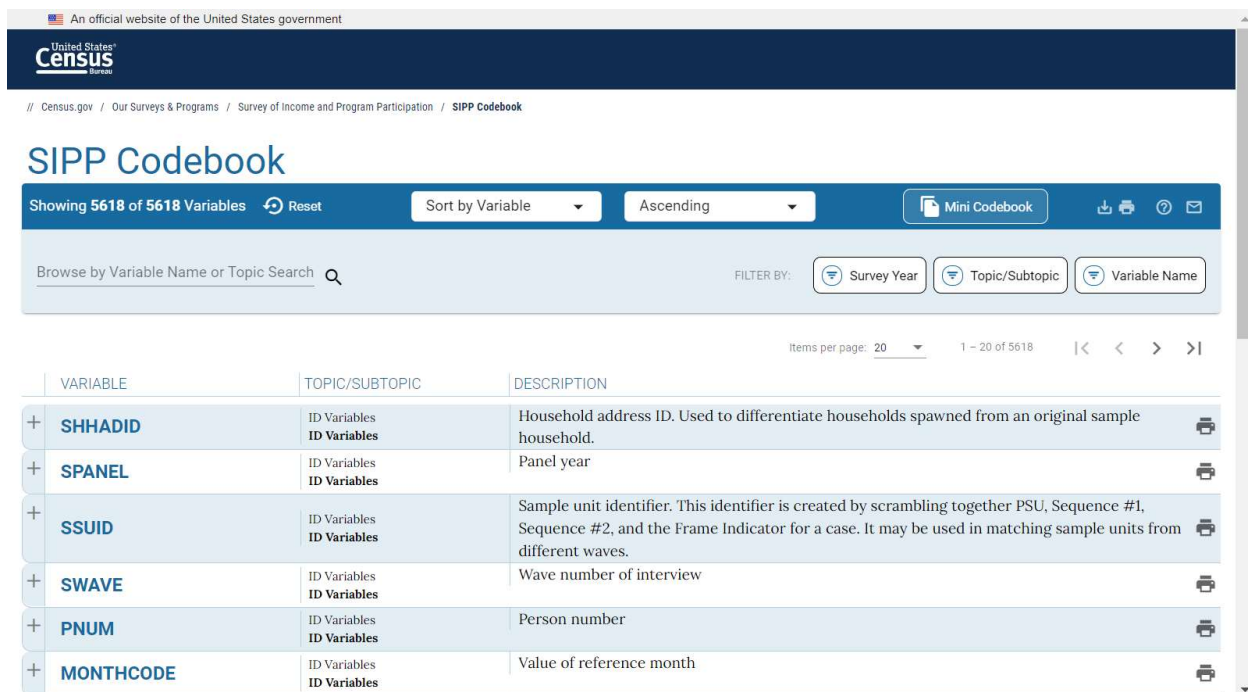
5.1.2 Data Resources

The *Technical Documentation* and *Guidance for Data Users* sections of the SIPP website offer a wealth of information to assist data users. These materials are located at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation.html and www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/guidance.html, respectively. Some of the key materials are highlighted below.

5.1.2.1 Codebook Tool and Data Dictionaries

The *SIPP Codebook* tool provides descriptive information (metadata) for all of SIPP's public-use variables beginning with the 2014 SIPP Panel. This tool is available at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/codebooks.html. The *Codebook* allows users to search and browse variables by survey year and topic. [Figure 5-1](#) shows a screenshot of the SIPP Codebook.

FIGURE 5-1. THE SIPP ONLINE CODEBOOK



The screenshot displays the SIPP Codebook web application. At the top, it shows the United States Census Bureau logo and navigation links. The main header indicates 'Showing 5618 of 5618 Variables'. Below this is a search bar and filter options for Survey Year, Topic/Subtopic, and Variable Name. The main content area is a table with the following data:

	VARIABLE	TOPIC/SUBTOPIC	DESCRIPTION
+	SHHADID	ID Variables ID Variables	Household address ID. Used to differentiate households spawned from an original sample household.
+	SPANEL	ID Variables ID Variables	Panel year
+	SSUID	ID Variables ID Variables	Sample unit identifier. This identifier is created by scrambling together PSU, Sequence #1, Sequence #2, and the Frame Indicator for a case. It may be used in matching sample units from different waves.
+	SWAVE	ID Variables ID Variables	Wave number of interview
+	PNUM	ID Variables ID Variables	Person number
+	MONTHCODE	ID Variables ID Variables	Value of reference month

PDF versions of the metadata available in the *Codebook* are also available on the *Data Dictionaries* page at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/data-dictionaries.html.

5.1.2.2 SIPP Data Primers

The *SIPP Data Primers* provide an introduction to working with SIPP data and survey weights. They include example tables and demonstrations for building data files. These guides are available at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/guidance/data-primers.html.

5.1.2.3 User Notes

There are circumstances where survey questions and/or data may need adjustment or revision. User notes provide this information, along with any resolutions or updates necessary to assist data users and provide the highest quality of data possible. User notes may also include documentation and code to address potential inconsistencies in the data or offer additional clarification. SIPP user notes are available at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes.html.

5.1.2.4 Variable Crosswalks

Variable names can change over time due to question changes or privacy protections. The *SIPP Crosswalks* page at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/crosswalks.html provides spreadsheets that map variable names across data years. The page also includes a *Variable Name Change Summary* workbook, which lists all variable name changes since Wave 1 of the 2014 Panel.

5.1.2.5 Questionnaires and Instrument Specifications

The *Questionnaires and Instruments* page at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/questionnaires.html provides instrument specifications that detail the questions asked to respondents during a SIPP interview.

5.1.2.6 Source and Accuracy Statements

SIPP's *Source and Accuracy Statements* summarize the source of the data, sampling and estimation procedures, population controls, weighting, and potential data errors and demonstrate how to calculate various types of standard errors. The Source and Accuracy Statements are available at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/source-accuracy-statements.html.

5.2 Research Products

The SIPP website features a range of research products analyzing and tabulating estimates from SIPP data. These products include official P-70 publications, working papers, *Fact Sheets*, data visualizations, *America Counts* stories, table packages, and a bibliography of non-Census journal articles, peer-reviewed papers, and other publications that use SIPP data. The website is regularly updated to include the most recent and up-to-date research related to SIPP data. Written research products are available at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/library.html, while table packages are accessed via www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/data/tables.html. Some of these products are described below.

5.2.1 Official (P-70) Publications

The P-70 report series was created to inform the public about the economic status and well-being of American households using SIPP data. The P-70 reports cover a broad range of topics, including living conditions, child care arrangements, health insurance coverage, participation in government programs, poverty, income distribution, and employment.

The Census Bureau's P-70 series is the primary source for published estimates from SIPP. These reports assist data users in several ways:

- Published estimates may include the specific estimates needed for a research project, saving users the effort to generate those estimates themselves.
- Published estimates can often provide a useful cross-check for closely related estimates prepared by data users.
- Published estimates are based on the Census Bureau's internal data files, which are often impossible for external data users to replicate because the internal files have not been subjected to topcoding and other confidentiality protection techniques.

A list of P-70 SIPP reports is available in Appendix C below, and the full reports can be accessed at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/library/publications/p70s.html.

5.2.2 Table Packages

SIPP table packages provide tabulated estimates for a range of topics, including poverty dynamics, social insurance programs, wealth, and disability rates. These products are available at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/data/tables.html.

5.2.3 Working Papers

Census Bureau analysts produce a substantial amount of research drawn from SIPP data and are active participants at both national and regional conferences, including the annual meetings of the Population Association of America, the American Economic Association, and the American Sociological Association. This research is shared with the broader academic community through a series of working papers. SIPP working papers are located at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/library/working-papers.html.

5.2.4 Fact Sheets

Fact Sheets offer a quick way to access key statistics on a wide range of topics covered in the SIPP. The SIPP-based *Fact Sheets* are considered part of the P70 report series, as discussed in section 5.2.1, and are available at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/library/fact-sheets.html.

5.3 Conferences, Workshops, and Webinars

SIPP staff periodically host conferences, workshops, and webinars that provide a hands-on introduction to SIPP and its data, including the SIPP Synthetic Beta file.¹⁹ For more information and to access materials from past events, visit <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/events.html>.

The most recent conference, the *2024 Virtual SIPP Conference*, highlighted how government agencies and other organizations use SIPP data. Recordings and additional information about this conference are available at <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/events/conferences/2024-sipp-conference.html>.

SIPP staff also hosted a workshop at the 2023 Population Association of America (PAA) annual meeting, focusing on the 2018 SIPP data. Materials from this event are available on the SIPP website at <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/events/conferences/2023-SIPP-Workshop-PAA.html>.

The latest webinar series, held in 2019, focused on the 2014 SIPP Panel. The seven-part series covered the following topics:

- Overview of the 2014 Panel of the SIPP
- Demographics and Residences
- Jobs
- Assets, Income, and Poverty
- Programs, Adult Well-being, and Food Security
- Health insurance, Health Care, and Disability
- Family and Fertility

Webinar materials, including audio recordings, transcripts, presentation slides, handouts, and exercises are available on the SIPP website at <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/events/webinars.html>. Although this series covers the 2014 Panel, much of the information applies to the 2025 SIPP as well.

¹⁹ The SIPP Synthetic Beta (SSB) is a Census Bureau product that integrates person-level micro-data with administrative tax and benefit data, while maintaining confidentiality through synthetically-produced data. For more information on SSB, please visit <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/guidance/sipp-synthetic-beta-data-product.html>

6 Data Editing and Imputation

This section describes the editing and imputation procedures applied to SIPP data after the completion of each wave of interviews. Three different approaches are used for dealing with missing data in SIPP:

- Data editing (also referred to as logical imputation) is used for some types of item nonresponse.
- Statistical (or stochastic) imputation is used for some types of unit nonresponse and some types of item nonresponse.
- Weighting adjustments are used for some types of noninterviews.

This chapter briefly discusses the types of missing data and the goals of imputation in SIPP. It then presents an overview of the editing and imputation procedures used to deal with missing and inconsistent data. Next, this chapter provides a detailed description of each of the major steps used by the Census Bureau when creating its internal files and the files that are released for public use.

6.1 Data Editing

All respondent-reported data are edited for logical consistency. For example, say the respondent reported an age of 67 years old. However, the respondent is enrolled in 11th grade and is the biological child of a 47-year-old household member, indicating that the respondent's actual age is likely to be 17 and not 67. This is a simple example of when data editing would correct the reported age. Variables whose names start with an 'E' are edited variables.

During processing, there are also variables created that are based on the values of one or more other variables. These are recoded variables and have names starting with an "R." Some variables are topcoded, bottomcoded, or collapsed for the public-use file. These variables have names starting with a "T."

6.1.1 Types of Missing Data

As in all surveys, there are two general types of missing data in SIPP: unit nonresponse and item nonresponse. Unit nonresponse occurs when one or more of the people residing at a sample address is not interviewed and no proxy interview is obtained. Most types of unit nonresponse are dealt with through weighting adjustments.

Item nonresponse occurs when a respondent completes most of the questionnaire but does not answer one or more individual questions. Item nonresponse data in SIPP occur under the following circumstances:

- Responding sample persons refuse or are unable to provide requested information.
- Interviewers fail to ask a question or incorrectly record a response.
- A response is inconsistent with related responses or is incompatible with response categories.

Item nonresponse data are generally imputed for all variables.

6.1.2 Goals of Imputation

There are two key problems caused by missing data:

- A lack of consistency across analyses because data users compensate for missing data in different ways, and their analyses may be based on different subsets of data.
- Nonresponse is unlikely to be completely random, so estimates of population parameters are biased due to a potential non-representative sample.

Because missing data are always present to some degree, analyses of survey data must be based on assumptions about patterns of missing data. When missing data are not imputed or otherwise accounted for in the model being estimated, the implicit assumption is that data are missing at random after controlling for other variables in the model. The imputation procedures used for SIPP assume that data are missing at random within subgroups of the population. The statistical goal of imputation is to reduce the bias of survey estimates. This goal is achieved to the extent that systematic patterns of item nonresponse are correctly identified and modeled. In SIPP, the statistical goals of imputation are general, rather than specific. Instead of addressing the estimation of specific parameters, SIPP procedures are designed to provide reasonable estimates for a variety of analytical purposes.

Data editing is generally preferred over statistical imputation, and it is used whenever a missing item can be logically inferred from other data that have been provided. When information exists on the same record from which missing information can logically be inferred, that information is used to replace the missing information.

6.1.3 Assessing the Influence of Imputed Data on Analysis

Users of SIPP data interested in assessing the influence of imputed data on their analyses should consider whether SIPP imputation procedures have properties that affect their specific analytical requirements.

An evaluation of the effects of imputed data should include a review of rates of unit nonresponse and an assessment of the extent of item nonresponse. Unit nonresponse tends to increase over the life of a panel, as does the likelihood that nonresponse is not a random effect.

The effects of imputation will likely be small for items with low rates of missing data as long as rates of item nonresponse are not high among important subclasses. Lepkowski et al. (1987), using data from a large federal survey, provide a framework for evaluating the effect of imputed values on analyses. This framework can be readily adapted to SIPP analyses.

6.2 Imputation

SIPP uses three imputation strategies:

1. Model-Based Imputation
2. Sequential Hot-deck Imputation
3. Cold-deck Imputation

The below sections discuss each strategy in more detail.

6.2.1 Model-Based Imputation

Model-based imputation creates topic flags that determine whether a respondent should have answered questions about a specific content area (e.g., Social Security or TANF) if the respondent originally did not report information for that topic. The output of this prediction is a Y/N *topic flag* variable, with ‘Y’ indicating that there should be data related to the topic.

In addition to topic flag variables, select variables pertaining to earnings, assets, liabilities, employment characteristics, and retirement content also use model-based imputation to fill in missing information. The output of these specific variables can be binary (e.g., owning an IRA retirement account), nominal (e.g., wageworker/self-employed/other), or continuous (e.g., earnings). ~~Table 6-1~~ [Table 6-1](#) shows the group of variables imputed through model-based imputation. All other variables are imputed using hot-deck and cold-deck imputation.

TABLE 6-1. MODEL-BASED IMPUTED VARIABLES (MBIVS) IN THE 2025 SIPP

Topic-Flag-Related Variables		Non-Topic-Flag-Related Variables		
EED_SCRNR	ECREPAYANYON	EDEBT_CC	EOWN_RP	EJB5_JBORSE
EJB1_SCRNR	EVAANY	EDEBT_ED	EOWN_SAV	EJB6_INCPB
EJB2_SCRNR	ESSSANY	EDEBT_MED	EOWN_ST	EJB6_PFTLOSS
EJB3_SCRNR	ESSCANY	EDEBT_OT	EOWN_THR401	EJB6_JBORSE
EJB4_SCRNR	EWC_ANY	TIRAKEOVAL	TTHR401VAL	EJB7_INCPB
EJB5_SCRNR	EUCANY	EOWN_ANNTR	EJB1_INCPB	EJB7_PFTLOSS
EJB6_SCRNR	EENERGY_ASST	EOWN_BSI	EJB1_PFTLOSS	EJB7_JBORSE
EJB7_SCRNR	ESCHOOOLLUNCH	EOWN_CD	EJB1_JBORSE	EIRA_INC_YN
EJB8_SCRNR	ESCHOOLBREAK	EOWN_CHK	EJB2_INCPB	ETHR_INC_YN
RSI_YRYN	ELMPNOW	EOWN_GOVS	EJB2_PFTLOSS	EMJOB_IRA
RSNAP_YRYN	EDISABL	EOWN_IRAKEO	EJB2_JBORSE	EMJOB_401
RTANF_YRYN	EDISANY	EOWN_LIFE	EJB3_INCPB	EMJOB_PEN
RGA_YRYN	EEVERET	EOWN_MCBD	EJB3_PFTLOSS	EPENSNYN
RWIC_YRYN	ERETANY	EOWN_MF	EJB3_JBORSE	ESCNTYN_IRA
EPR_SCRNR	ESURANY	EOWN_MM	EJB4_INCPB	ESCNTYN_401
EMC_SCRNR	ELIFEYN	EOWN_OINV	EJB4_PFTLOSS	TIRA_INC_AMT

EMD_SCRNR	EFINDJOB	EOWN_PENSION	EJB4_JBORSE	TTHR_INC_AMT
EML_SCRNR	EPAR_SCRNR	EOWN_RE	EJB5_INCPB	TSCNTAMT_IRA
EOT_SCRNR	EPEN_INC_YN		EJB5_PFTLOSS	TSCNTAMT_401

The imputation process developed to handle missing data (explained below) involves estimating sequential models that predict values for a model-based imputed variable (MBIV), conditional on demographic data, all other topic flags, and Internal Revenue Service (IRS) and Social Security Administration (SSA) administrative data on earnings and benefits. These data are non-monotonically missing, meaning they look like “Swiss cheese,” with pockets of missing data scattered throughout. Because of this feature, SIPP iterates the process multiple times, estimating the sequential models repeatedly and always conditioning on the most up-to-date imputations for any explanatory variable in a model. This process is commonly called Sequential Regression Multiple Imputation (SRMI) and was initially developed by Raghunathan et al. (2001).

SRMI is based on Bayesian statistical theory and is a method of estimating an approximation of the posterior predictive distribution (PPD), a conditional probability distribution that describes the data generation process and captures the relationships between the variables. To impute missing values, SIPP draws from this PPD; in other words, SIPP predicts a value conditional on everything else observed or previously imputed for that record.

This modeling method has several advantages over hot-deck imputation. For one, many more explanatory variables can be included in the models than can be included as stratifiers in a hot-deck. For topic flag variables, this means SIPP can condition the imputation for a given topic flag on the imputed values for every other topic flag, hopefully approximating a joint distribution of values instead of a series of independent imputations. Parent and spouse variables can also be used as regressors or conditioning variables in the models, which allows us to better preserve the relationships among the MBIVs of household members. Finally, non-SIPP data can be used to mitigate the problem of respondents with missing values being different in unobservable ways from respondents with non-missing values. The use of rich administrative data from the SSA and IRS in model-based imputation is particularly helpful in predicting values not only for missing topic flags, but for missing information regarding earnings, assets, liabilities, employment, and select retirement content. This is why these select non-topic flag variables use model-based imputation.

Determining the Universe

The first step prior to imputing missing values is to establish the universe of respondents that pertain to that specific variable. The universe varies depending on the screener questions for that topic. For some topics, the universe is determined strictly by age (e.g., job topics, education enrollment, SSI, and unemployment compensation). For other topics, sex and presence of children are also universe determinants (e.g., WIC, school meals, and Social Security for kids). Another group of topics is only asked of household respondents, and the answers covered a group of individuals linked through family relationships to that household respondent (e.g., TANF, GA, and SNAP). Private health insurance is the

most complicated topic with respondents allowed to choose to report coverage for themselves, for a family member, or both. The creation of the private health insurance topic flag requires a complete accounting and reconciliation of reports from all respondents within a sampling unit to create an accurate person-level indicator of coverage. For the earnings, assets, and employment variables that use SRMI, the universe often is determined by age and/or work history.

Building an Imputation Model

The first step in the imputation model for each MBIV output variable is the identification of important related variables. These auxiliary variables fall into two categories: stratifying and regressor variables. A stratifying variable is an indicator variable that divides respondents into homogeneous groups where each group might be expected to have different models. A regressor variable is any variable that is potentially related to the output variable and could go on the right-hand side of a regression. For each group defined by the stratifying variables, the output variable is regressed on the regressor variables for the cases where the data are not missing. The resulting regression coefficients are then used to predict the values of the output variable for the missing cases. Once a particular output variable has been imputed, it can be used as a predictor in the model for another output variable, entering into the regression for the non-missing cases, and used to impute values for the missing cases. This process is how dependency between output variables is built into the models. SIPP relies on multiple iterations of our process to prevent the order of the modeling from affecting the imputations. The final result is a set of MBIVs with no missing values for every in-universe SIPP respondent because all the originally missing values have been replaced by imputed values.

Choosing a List of Stratifying Variables

A stratifying variable should be a categorical characteristic(s) that best predicts the presence of a topic. SIPP creates an optimal set of stratifying variables and then alternative lists in case the cell sizes created by the optimal list are too small for regressions. Any sub-sample created by the stratifying variables that does not contain at least 100 observations will not be used for regressions. Instead, it will be combined with other sub-samples that are too small and divided again using the next smallest set of stratifying variables.

Choosing a List of Regressor Variables

Regressor variables are the additional variables used to predict the output variable. Regressors may be binary, categorical, or continuous. Continuous variables are particularly useful on the regressor list since too many dummy variables in the regression can cause estimation problems in logistic regressions. For example, age categories are excellent as stratifying variables, but as regressors, it is preferable to use age, age squared, and age cubed rather than a series of dummy variables defining the age category. When variables are dropped from the optimal stratifying list, SIPP generally includes them on the regressor list so that they can still provide predictive value to the modeling process even though they are no longer a stratifying variable.

Administrative Records in Model-Based Imputation

The model-based imputation makes use of six different sources of data shared with the Census Bureau by the SSA and the IRS for stratifying and regressor variables in the models. Once the MBIVs are imputed, all administrative records are stripped from the data and no administrative records are on public-use files.

Derived from W-2 forms filed with SSA by employers, the Detailed Earnings Record (DER) extract reports uncapped income-taxable earnings for each employer that filed a W-2 record after 1977. It also contains a report of earnings that were not income taxable and were deferred into accounts like 401(k) plans. SIPP utilizes the DER to create a measure of total earnings in a given year and to count the number of jobs an individual held. From the DER, SIPP also creates measures of self-employed earnings and an indicator of any deferred earnings. Finally, the DER provides the work history of respondents going back to 1978, providing indicators for years worked and average earnings across years worked in our imputation models. SIPP uses the Master Beneficiary Record (MBR) and Payment History Update System (PHUS) extracts to create indicators for whether an individual was eligible for and received OASDI payments due to retirement, disability, spouse retirement or death, parent retirement or death, or some combination of reasons. These extracts contain both present benefit receipt and historical information, so SIPP can tell what year an individual started receiving benefits and whether they ever stopped. The Supplemental Security Record (SSR) provides the same information about SSI benefits. These three files combined together give us a very accurate picture of who was receiving OASDI benefits, SSI benefits, or both. This information in turn is very helpful in predicting reports of OASDI and SSI receipt.

SIPP also makes use of the Numident, a register of all Social Security Numbers (SSNs) ever issued in the United States, along with the MBR and SSR, as an administrative source of birth date information. If a person is receiving benefits, SIPP uses the birth date from the benefits files to create an age for the individual during the survey reference period. If the person is not receiving benefits, SIPP uses the birth date from the Numident. While this does not replace the survey-reported age on the final public-use data, age derived from administrative data is used as an explanatory variable in model-based imputation.

Finally, SIPP pulls in the W-2 universe using data from the IRS. This helps provide additional useful variables for the imputation process, including the size of the firm where employees work, whether the employer offers a 401(k), and whether the person is the highest paid employee. In addition to the DER, it also provides another source of earnings data, if needed during SIPP production.

Some SIPP respondents do not match to administrative data. This happened because they did not consent to having their data linked or they did not provide enough information for the Census PVS system to find a Protected Identity Key (PIK) for them. The PVS system relies on matching name, date of birth, sex, and address to administrative data files to find an SSN which is then replaced with a PIK. When administrative data is missing, it is imputed during same model-based imputation process that imputes the topic flags and select non-topic flag variables.

6.2.2 Sequential Hot-Deck Imputation

The statistical imputation method used to impute most missing items in SIPP is known as a sequential hot-deck imputation. For many topics, SRMI models determine whether a respondent with missing data should have data for a topic (e.g., receipt of unemployment insurance any time during the reference year), whereas detailed information about the topic (e.g., months of receipt or monthly amount received) is imputed using sequential hot-deck imputation. In some cases, a ratio is imputed. This ratio is used to derive the value instead of imputing the value itself. This is done to preserve relationships between certain variables (e.g., asset value and income).

In a general sense, the sequential hot-deck procedure matches a record with missing data to that of a donor with similar background characteristics and uses the donor's values. This procedure differs from data editing, which replaces missing data with inferred values based on non-missing data from the same case.

The hot-deck is cross-sectional; only values from current wave responses are used in the definition of the hot-deck cells. SIPP hot-deck procedures are designed to preserve the univariate distribution of each variable subjected to imputation. However, they do not generally preserve the covariances among variables. One consequence is that imputation can introduce inconsistencies into the data. For example, if a respondent has reported program participation, but his or her income is too high for that program, it is possible that the income data have been imputed. Whenever users detect inconsistencies, it is wise to check the status flag (described in Section 3.3) to see if the inconsistent data might have been imputed. The discussion of status flags later in this chapter provides more information.

The hot-deck procedure used in SIPP for questions is sequential because the selection of replacement values is implemented one record at a time from an ordered file.

The sequential hot-deck procedure used in SIPP involves five key steps:

1. Specifying cold-deck values
2. Sorting the sample cases
3. Identifying records with no item nonresponse or topic flag set and creating hot-deck values
4. Classifying cases into subclasses of the population, referred to as imputation classes or adjustment cells, according to values on a set of classification or auxiliary variables that are non-missing for all cases (this step is omitted in the initial processing of the key demographic items: race, sex, etc.)
5. Selecting replacement values from donor cases to impute item-missing data

Specifying cold-deck or initial donor values

Cold-deck values are the values to which each cell in the hot-deck matrix is initialized. SIPP never intends for an imputed item to receive the cold-deck value; cold-deck values are used as a last resort if a value cannot be assigned via logical imputation or the hot-deck imputation process. The cold-deck value is usually the most common value for the item in question.

Sorting the sample cases

The records in the sample file are sorted by three geographic variables prior to imputing item missing data: primary sampling unit, segment number, and serial number. The cases are sorted prior to processing and are not resorted at any other time during the imputation process. The sorting operation creates a file in which neighboring records represent geographically proximate households.

Identifying records with no item nonresponse or topic flag set and creating hot-deck values

Once the cases have been sorted, they are processed through a series of programs. During the first pass against the programs, the cold-deck values are updated with information from the current wave. Missing data are not yet imputed, the first record in the sorted file with consistent and non-missing data for a particular group of variables is identified and the values from that case replace the cold-deck values for that section in the matrix.

The values for each subsequent record with consistent and non-missing information update the previous set of consistent and non-missing values written to the matrix. The checking and updating operation continues until all records in the data file have been processed. The last values written to the matrix serve as the starting values in the subsequent sequential hot-deck procedure. In this way, cold-deck values are rarely used as replacement values in SIPP because the initial processing usually replaces all starting values with values from the current wave of data.

Classifying cases into subclasses of the population

In the next step of the imputation procedure, each respondent record or noninterview record in the sorted file is allocated to one of the imputation classes or adjustment cells according to its values on the set of classification, or auxiliary, variables.

1. The auxiliary variables are chosen for each item or set of related items on the basis of their level of correlation with the item receiving the imputation (i.e., classification variables are chosen on the basis of their ability to explain the variability of the item or set of related items). Census Bureau researchers assign different sets of classification variables to different sets of items.
2. The auxiliary variables are either dichotomous or categorical variables (e.g., sex, race); if they are continuous, they are categorized into a parsimonious number of levels (e.g., income, asset levels).
3. The level of the auxiliary variables then defines a matrix, with the number of cells in this matrix being the product of the number of levels for each auxiliary variable. For example, an imputation defined by five variables, each with three levels, has a total of 243 (or 3^5) cells. Any given item or set of related items may have imputation matrices with the numbers of cells ranging from 10, or so, to over 100 in limited circumstances, depending on the matrix. Auxiliary variables such as sex, race, and categorizations of age (with different categorizations for different items) are used frequently in the matrices, as are more specialized auxiliary variables that are relevant for particular items (such as industry and occupation category for the monthly gross pay item).

The allocation of sample cases into imputation classes (also known as subclasses or strata) according to a set of classification variables serves several purposes. Ideally, the set of classification variables should account for a large proportion of the variance in the variable being imputed and should be associated with variations in response rates. To the extent that this is accomplished, the classification procedure creates homogeneous adjustment cells containing similar cases. In this way, donors and recipients are similar under the assumption that the nonresponse mechanism within the imputation class is not related to the item being imputed; that is, an underlying assumption is made that item nonresponse data are distributed randomly within the subclass defined by the cross-classification of the auxiliary variables. The selection of classification variables may also place bounds on the range of values that can be imputed and implicitly satisfy edit constraints. The implicit stratification created by the sort order of the file further improves the opportunity for better imputation to the extent that nearby cases are more similar to each other than cases that are farther apart in the file. This step is omitted for the imputation of the primary demographic values that are imputed before the person-level variables.

Selecting replacement values from donor cases to impute item-missing data

The selection of replacement values for missing items is restricted to donor and recipient records within each cell; that is, records allocated to one cell never donate information to records in another cell with missing items. As the file is processed through the set of programs the second time, the imputations are performed and the set of hot-deck values is updated once again. The records are processed sequentially, according to the sort order of the file. A missing item is given the value of the last corresponding item that is non-missing from a record in that imputation class. If the value of an item in the current record is non-missing, it replaces the previous hot-deck value for that imputation class. In this way, the hot-deck value for each imputation class is constantly being updated with the value of the last non-missing case.

The updating is performed item by item. Missing items in one record receive the current set of replacement values. Then the non-missing values in that record are used to update the hot-deck in preparation for the next record. At any point during the process, the donated values in the hot-deck likely come from many different respondents, even within imputation classes. That is why this imputation procedure does not preserve covariances among the variables being imputed.

7 Nonsampling Error, Sampling Error, and Weighting

Statistics from surveys are subject to both sampling and non-sampling errors. This chapter addresses:

- Sources of non-sampling error and the effect of non-sampling error on estimates
- Sampling error and incorporating SIPP's complex sampling design when computing variance estimates
- SIPP weighting, available weights, and using weights to produce reliable estimates

For further information on the source of the data and accuracy of the estimates, including standard errors and confidence intervals, see the SIPP Source and Accuracy Statements at <www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/source-accuracy-statements.html>.

7.1 Non-sampling Error

All surveys are subject to non-sampling error. SIPP contains non-sampling error common to most surveys, as well as error unique to SIPP's longitudinal design. Under-coverage in household surveys is due primarily to within-household omissions; the omission of entire households is less frequent. SIPP experiences some differential under-coverage of demographic subgroups; for example, the coverage ratio²⁰ of black males aged 15 to 64 years is lower than that for white males in the same age group. To compensate for this differential under-coverage, the Census Bureau adjusts SIPP sample weights to population control totals. The SIPP sample weights also include a nonresponse adjustment to address differential household nonresponse. However, it is not certain to what extent these weighting adjustments eliminate biases. For more information about the effectiveness of nonresponse adjustments in SIPP, please see visit the Nonresponse Bias Analysis Reports page at <<https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/nonresponse-reports.html>>

Sample attrition (when respondents leave the sample) is another source of error. Attrition reduces the available sample size and to the extent that those leaving the sample are systematically different from those who remain, survey estimates could be biased.

Response errors in SIPP take on a number of forms. Many recall errors are thought to be the source of seam bias. This effect results from the respondent's tendency to project current circumstances back onto

²⁰ The coverage ratio is the estimated population before the post-stratification ratio (second stage) adjustment divided by the independent population control. Coverage ratios for select demographic subgroups are in the SIPP Source and Accuracy Statement available at <<http://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/source-accuracy-statements.html>>.

each of the months that constitute the SIPP reference period (the prior calendar year). This causes any changes in respondent circumstances that occurred during the reference period to appear to have happened in the first month of the reference period. The effect is a disproportionate number of changes that appear to occur between the last month of one wave and the first month of the following wave, which is the "seam" between the two waves – hence the name.

Another potential source of response error is the time-in-sample effect. This effect refers to the tendency of sample members to "learn the survey" over time. The more times a sample member is interviewed, the better he or she learns the questionnaire. The concern is that sample members will alter their responses to the survey questions in an effort to conceal sensitive information or to minimize the length of the interview. Additionally, measurement error can occur when respondents misinterpret questions.

7.2 Sampling Error and Variance Estimation

This section discusses methods for obtaining the sampling error estimates derived from the SIPP panels. The sample selected for each SIPP panel is a stratified, multistage probability sample. This complex sample design must be taken into account when calculating the variances of SIPP estimates. The SIPP data files contain variables related to the sample design, which are created for the purpose of variance estimation. Several software packages are now available for computing variance estimates for a wide range of statistics based on complex sample designs, such as the SURVEY procedures in SAS, the SVYSET procedure in Stata, or the SURVEY package in R. Using the variables that specify the design, these programs can calculate appropriate variances of survey estimates. Alternatively, sets of replicate weights are also provided in the SIPP data files and can be used to estimate more accurate standard errors and variances for SIPP estimates. While replicate weighting methods require more computing resources, this is the preferred method of estimating standard errors. Many statistical software packages have procedures that simplify the use of replicate weights for users. Further information and examples of these variance estimation methods can also be found in the SIPP Source and Accuracy Statements at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/source-accuracy-statements.html.

A common mistake in the estimation of sampling error for survey estimates is to ignore the complex survey design and treat the sample as a simple random sample (SRS) of the population. That mistake occurs because most standard software packages for data analysis assume simple random sampling for variance estimation. When applied to SIPP estimates, SRS formulas for variances typically underestimate the true variances. This section describes how appropriate variance estimates, which account for the complex sample design, can be obtained for SIPP estimates.

7.2.1 Direct Variance Estimation

The primary sampling unit (PSU) plays a key role in variance estimation with a multistage sample design. SIPP PSUs are mostly counties, groups of counties, or independent cities, which are sampled with probability proportional to size within strata. Self-representing (SR) PSUs are so large that they are included in the sample with certainty. Because no sampling is involved, the SR PSUs are, in fact, not PSUs but strata. Non-self-representing (NSR) PSUs are stratified, and two NSR PSUs per stratum are sampled without replacement, so that no PSU is selected more than once for the sample.

Although the SIPP PSUs are selected without replacement (as is the case with most multistage designs), for the purpose of variance estimation they are treated as if they were sampled with replacement. The with-replacement assumption greatly facilitates variance estimation since it means that variance estimates can be computed by taking into account only the PSUs and strata, without the need to consider the complexities of the subsequent stages of sample selection. This widely used simplifying assumption leads to an overestimation of variances, but the overestimation is not great.

7.2.2 Variance Units and Variance Strata

The 2025 SIPP sample member records contain data on the PSU and stratum from which a person was sampled. These variables can be used to specify the cluster and strata in software packages to estimate variances. However, to avoid potential identification of sampled persons in small areas, the original PSU and stratum codes are not included in the SIPP public data files. Instead, sets of PSUs are combined across strata to produce variance units (GHLFSAM) and variance strata (GVARSTR), with two variance units in each variance stratum. Variance units and variance strata may be treated as PSUs (or clusters) and strata for variance estimation purposes. Their use does not give rise to any bias in the variance estimates. However, the variance estimates are somewhat less precise than those obtained from using PSUs and strata that have not been combined.

7.2.3 Replicate Weights

The Census Bureau also releases replicate weight files along with the SIPP data files. Data users should use Fay's modified balanced repeated replication (BRR) method for estimating variances for the SIPP panels. The difference between the basic BRR method and Fay's method is that the BRR method uses replicate factors of 0 and 2, whereas Fay's method uses one factor, k , which is in the range $(0, 1)$, with the other factor equal to $2 - k$. In Fay's method, the introduction of the perturbation factor $(1 - k)$ allows the use of both halves of the sample. Thus, Fay's method has the advantage that no subset of the sample units in a particular classification will be totally excluded. [Figure 7-1](#) shows Fay's variance estimation formula used for SIPP estimates.

FIGURE 7-1. SIPP VARIANCE ESTIMATION FORMULA

$$Var(\theta_0) = \{1/[G(1 - k)^2]\} \sum_{i=1}^G (\theta_i - \theta_0)^2,$$

where:

G = number of replicates;

$1 - k$ = perturbation factor;

i = replicate i , $i = 1$ to G ;

θ_i = i^{th} estimate of the parameter θ based on the observations included in the i^{th} replicate;

θ_0 = survey estimate of the parameter θ based on the full sample.

There are 240 replicate weights ($G=240$) in 2025 SIPP data. All replicate weights are calculated based on a perturbation factor of 0.5 ($k = 0.5$). For example, inserting the 2025 values into [Figure 7-1](#)'s equation results in the variance formula of

$$Var(\theta_0) = \{1/(240 * 0.5^2)\} \sum_{i=1}^{240} (\theta_i - \theta_0)^2$$

The SIPP replicate weights are available via the SIPP Data webpage at www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/data.html.

Data users should account for the complex survey design and sampling structure to create unbiased estimates. Below is example STATA code, R code, SAS code, and Python code that can produce an unbiased point estimate and variance estimate of mean personal monthly income for those aged 15 and older (after merging the primary data with the replicate weights):

STATA

```
use "pu.dta"

merge 1:1 ssuid pnun monthcode using "rw.dta"

keep if _merge == 3

svyset [pw=wpfinwgt], brrweight(repwt1-repwt240) fay(.5) vce(brr) mse

svy: mean tptotinc
```

R (using the *survey* library)

```
data <- inner_join(pu, rw, by = c("SSUID", "PNUM", "MONTHCODE"))

sipp.svy = svrepdesign( data = data,
  weights = ~WPFINWGT,
  repweights = "REPWGT[1-9]+",
  type = "Fay",
  rho = 0.5 )

svymean( ~TPTOTINC , sipp.svy , na.rm = TRUE )
```

SAS

```
data pu_rw_merged;
  merge pu(in=a) rw(in=b);
  by SSUID PNUM MONTHCODE;
  if a and b;

run;

proc surveymeans data=pu_rw_merged varmethod = BRR (Fay=0.5) mean cv sum cvsum var T;
  var TPTOTINC;
  weight WPFINWGT;
  repweights REPWGT1-REPWGT240;

run;
```

Python (using *NumPy* and *Pandas*)

```
df = pu.merge(rw,
left_on=['SSUID', 'PNUM', 'MONTHCODE'],right_on=['SSUID', 'PNUM', 'MONTHCODE'])

df_est = df.loc[df.TPTOTINC.isna() != True]
point_estimate =
np.nansum(df_est.TPTOTINC*df_est['WPFINWGT'])/np.nansum(df_est['WPFINWGT'])

rep_means = [np.nansum (df_est.TPTOTINC*df_est['REPWGT'+str(i)])/np.nansum
(df_est['REPWGT'+str(i)]) for i in range(1,241)]
rep_means = np.asarray(rep_means)
variance = (1/(240*.5**2))*sum((rep_means - point_estimate)**2)
```

```
print("Point estimate:{:.2f} , Standard error:{:.2f}".format(\
    point_estimate,variance**.5))
```

7.2.4 Variance Estimation with Imputed Data

As discussed in Chapter 6, SIPP uses several imputation methods to fill in missing data from item nonresponse. Imputation fills in gaps in the data set, making data analysis easier, and allowing more people to be retained as panel members for longitudinal analysis. The concern, however, is that imputation fabricates data to some degree. Treating the imputed values as actual values in estimating the variance of survey estimates leads to an overstatement of the precision of the estimates. It is important to recognize this fact when sizable proportions of values are imputed.

7.3 Weighting

Person weights estimate the number of people in the target population that a person represents. In general, since population units may be sampled with different selection probabilities and since response rates and coverage rates may vary across subpopulations, different responding units represent different numbers of units in the population. The use of weights in survey analysis compensates for this differential representation, thus producing estimates that relate to the target population.

SIPP weights vary due to differential sampling rates as a result of oversampling and because response and coverage rates vary across subpopulations. In 2025 SIPP, the final person lower quartile weight is 5,700 and the upper quartile weight is 13,100 (the maximum weight is 133,000). A respondent with a final person weight of 5,700 represents 5,700 people in the U.S. population for the reference month, whereas a respondent with a weight of 13,100 represents 13,100 people.

7.3.1 Choosing a Weight

The decision of which weight to use for a given analysis depends on 1) the population the results are intended to apply to, and 2) the duration of interest for that analysis. The weights in the SIPP files are constructed for sample cohorts grouped by:

- Month (e.g., the reference month weights)
- Year (e.g., the calendar year weights), and
- Multi-Year periods (e.g., the longitudinal weights that cover consecutive two-, three-, or four-year periods).

Using these weights, data users can choose to base their analyses on:

- A cross-sectional sample at a given month,
- A sample that provides continuous monthly data over a year, or
- A longitudinal sample that provides monthly data over more than one consecutive year.

Using longitudinal samples, data users can study issues such as the dynamics of program participation, lengths of poverty spells, and changes in other circumstances (e.g., household composition). The multi-year longitudinal weights include weights for the cohort of respondent who have positive calendar year weights for every year of the longitudinal period, regardless of panel. The 2025 SIPP release includes three sets of longitudinal weights covering the prior two, three, and four calendar years. Specifically, the longitudinal weights FINYR2, FINYR3, and FINYR4 cover the two-year reference period of 2023-2024, the three-year reference period of 2022-2024, and the four-year reference period of 2021-2024, respectively. The Census Bureau makes nonresponse adjustments to the longitudinal weights to compensate for attrition and post-stratification adjustments to make the weighted sample totals conform to population totals for key variables.

TABLE 7-1: CHOOSING APPROPRIATE WEIGHTS IN 2025 SIPP

Time Duration	Person Level	Example
Monthly	WPFINWGT	Income in July, 2024
Calendar Year	WPFINWGT in December of the reference year	Total TANF receipt in 2024
Multi-Year	FINYR# where # = 2, 3, 4 represents the number of years in the reference period	Median duration spell of unemployment from June 2021 to June 2024 (# = 4)

Note that SIPP releases a file of replicate weights corresponding to each of the above sets of weights for use in variance estimation. The replicate weight file, corresponding to WPFINWGT, can be matched to the primary data file using sample unit ID (SSUID), person number (PNUM), and reference month (MONTHCODE). The longitudinal replicate weight files, corresponding to FINYR#, can be matched to the primary data files using sample unit ID (SSUID) and person number (PNUM).

7.3.2 How Weights Are Constructed

The basic components for all the different sets of weights are the same, namely:

- A base weight that reflects the probability of selection for a sample unit;
- An adjustment for subsampling within clusters;
- An adjustment for movers (in Waves 2 and beyond);
- A nonresponse adjustment to compensate for sample nonresponse;
- An adjustment for combining sample cases from multiple panels (if overlapping panels cover the reference period); and

- A post-stratification (second-stage calibration) adjustment to correct for departures from known population totals.

7.3.3 Reference Month Weights

Reference month final weights are provided on the SIPP calendar-year data files for persons. Household, family, or subfamily weights can be derived from the final person weights. One option is to use the average of the person month weights for all persons in the household, family, or subfamily. Another option is to specify a household, family, or subfamily reference person and use his or her person month weight as the household, family, or subfamily weight. This section summarizes the steps involved in constructing the final person weights for a reference month. Positive weights are computed for all interviewed persons in the SIPP universe for the specified month.

A number of factors lead to fluctuations in sample size (and therefore weights) from month to month. They include births, deaths, and immigration and emigration from the population (and therefore from the sample). In addition to those population dynamics, people move into and out of the sample as a result of the changing household composition of sample members. Since response characteristics can differ by panel and wave, when there are overlapping panels included in a calendar-year file, the previously listed weighting components up through the nonresponse adjustment are done separately by wave first to obtain a noninterview weight for each sample person.

For Wave 1 households, the noninterview weight for each sample person per month is a product of the components:

- Wave 1 base weight: This weight is the inverse of the probability of a sample household's address being selected.
- Weighting-control factor: This factor adjusts for the occasional subsampling of clusters. Clusters are occasionally subsampled in the field when they turn out to be much larger than expected
- Wave 1 nonresponse adjustment: This adjustment compensates for different rates of household noninterview within adjustment classes. 512 nonresponse adjustment classes are defined based on a cross-classification of characteristics. Those characteristics include Census Region; MSA/Place Status (MSA-central city, MSA-non-central city, other place); race of reference person (black, nonblack); household tenure (owner, renter); household size (1, 2, 3, 4+ people); and the within-primary-sampling-unit poverty stratum (poverty, non-poverty). Some adjustment classes are combined to ensure that the adjustment for each class does not exceed a factor of 6 and each class contains at least 30 unweighted sample households.

For households in Waves 2 or later, each person receives an initial weight that is the noninterview weight carried over from Wave 1. This weight is adjusted to compensate for changes in the sample between waves resulting from movers and nonresponse. The noninterview weight for each sample person per month is the product of the following:

- Wave 2+ initial weight: This weight is the product of the Wave 1 base weight, the weighting-control factor, and the Wave 1 nonresponse adjustment factor. It is for each original sample person who is a reference person or is living in group quarters for the current wave.
- Wave 2+ mover adjustment: This adjustment is made to compensate for including people who were not in the original sample but were in the SIPP universe in Wave 1 and who moved into a sample household after Wave 1. For people in housing units that contain adult members who were not part of the original sample but were in the SIPP universe at Wave 1, the weights are decreased. For example, if a third adult moves into a household occupied by two original sample persons, all three adults would receive the initial weight of the original sample persons multiplied by a factor of two-thirds.
- Wave 2+ nonresponse adjustment: The nonresponse adjustment for Waves 2 and beyond is used to compensate for household nonresponse after the first interview. The nonresponse adjustment classes are defined on the basis of sample unit characteristics and personal demographic characteristics from the most recent wave. The information used consists of household characteristics. Reference person characteristics are used to define some of the household characteristics. Tenure (owner/renter occupied), household type (female householder, no spouse present; 65+; other), race and Hispanic origin, and education level are defined at the household level by using reference person data. Other household characteristics include size, poverty status, type of income, type of financial assets, census division, and number of imputed items. Some adjustment classes are combined to ensure that the adjustment for each class does not exceed a factor of 4 and each class contains at least 30 unweighted sample households.

Once the noninterview weights are obtained separately for each wave within the calendar year, they are adjusted by a factor that accounts for combining the waves from multiple panels together. For each person in a panel, this factor is a ratio of the panel's sample size relative to the total sample size of all overlapping panels.

Finally, the person weights go through a second stage calibration. This adjustment brings the sample estimates into agreement with independent monthly estimates of population totals. The characteristics used for calibration include age, race, sex, Hispanic origin, and state. A spouse equalization is also included. A raking procedure is used to ensure that the weights agree with all the control totals included for calibration.

7.3.4 Longitudinal and Calendar Year Weights

For the 2025 SIPP, there is no separate calendar year weight released. Instead, it is recommended that the December reference month weight be used as the calendar year weight, meaning that only people who had an interview covering December of the reference year will be included in calendar year estimates.

Multi-year-period longitudinal weights are available for the cohort of people who receive positive calendar year weights in every year of the reference period. These weights (and corresponding replicate weights) are released in separate longitudinal files that can be merged to the calendar-year data file using the sample unit ID (SSUID) and person number (PNUM). The 2025 SIPP release includes a "two-year"

longitudinal weights file covering the reference period 2023-2024, a “three-year” longitudinal weights file covering the reference period 2022-2024, and a “four-year” longitudinal weights file covering the reference period 2021-2024.

The final longitudinal weights are constructed from the following three components:

- Initial weight: This weight is the household noninterview weight from the first year of the reference period. If persons from more than one panel are receiving the longitudinal weight, this noninterview weight is adjusted by a factor to account for combining cases from overlapping panels.
- Nonresponse adjustment factors: These factors account for noninterviewed eligible sample persons not already accounted for in the noninterview adjustment component of the initial weight. The adjustment classes are similar to those used in the Wave 2+ nonresponse adjustment factors.
- Second-stage calibration factors: These factors are determined by a process similar to that used for the reference weights. The control totals used for the longitudinal weights are the population estimates for December of the last year in the reference period. Therefore, for a given yearly SIPP data release, the calendar year weights and all multi-year longitudinal weights will use the same control totals.

Appendices

A. Acronyms

ACS	=	American Community Survey
ADL	=	Activities of Daily Living
AFDC	=	Aid to Families with Dependent Children
ASA	=	American Statistical Association
BLS	=	Bureau of Labor Statistics
BW	=	Base weight
CAI	=	Computer-assisted interviewing
CAPI	=	Computer-assisted personal interviewing
CHI	=	Contact History Instrument
CMSA	=	Consolidated Metropolitan Statistical Area
CNSTAT	=	Committee on National Statistics
CPI-U	=	Consumer Price Index for all Urban Consumers
CPS	=	Current Population Survey
CV	=	Coefficient of Variation
DADS	=	Data Access and Dissemination System
DCF	=	Duplication Control Factor
DER	=	Detailed Earnings Record
DES	=	Data Extraction System
EBT	=	Electronic Benefit Transfer
EDs	=	Enumeration Districts
EHC	=	Event History Calendar
EITC	=	Earned Income Tax Credit
FERS	=	Federal Employees Retirement System

FIPS	=	Federal Information Processing Standards
GA	=	General Assistance
GED	=	General Education Development
HUs	=	Housing Units
ICPSR	=	Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research
IRA	=	Individual Retirement Account
IRS	=	Internal Revenue Service
ISDP	=	Income Survey Development Program
LQs	=	Living Quarters
MAF	=	Master Address File
MBIV	=	Model-Based Imputed Variable
MSA	=	Metropolitan Statistical Area
NAF	=	Noninterview adjustment factor
NCF	=	New-construction noninterview adjustment factor
NCHS	=	National Center for Health Statistics
NHIS	=	National Health Interview Survey
NLS	=	National Longitudinal Surveys
NOI	=	Neighborhood Observation Instrument
NSR PSUs	=	Non-self-representing PSUs
OASDI	=	Old-Age, Survivors, and Disability Insurance
OMB	=	Office of Management and Budget
PRWORA	=	Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity Reconciliation Act
PSUs	=	Primary Sampling Units
RIP	=	Respondent Identification Policy
SCF	=	Survey of Consumer Finances

SIPP	=	Survey of Income and Program Participation
SNAP	=	Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program
SPD	=	Survey of Program Dynamics
SRMI	=	Sequential Regression Multiple Imputation
SRS	=	Simple Random Sample
SSA	=	Social Security Administration
SSCA	=	Second-stage Calibration Adjustment
SSI	=	Supplemental Security Income
TANF	=	Temporary Assistance for Needy Families
UC	=	Unemployment Compensation
UI	=	Unemployment Insurance
USDA	=	United States Department of Agriculture
WIC	=	Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children

B. Glossary

A

Address Unit - This collection unit is a person or group of persons living at the same address at the time of the interview. The address unit may consist of one person living by himself or herself, a group of unrelated individuals, or one or more families.

Allocation Flag - See *Status Flag*.

B

Bottomcoding - Practice of recoding continuous variables to protect against the possibility that a user might recognize the identity of a SIPP respondent with an extreme value. Variables below a minimum value are recoded to that minimum value or to a mean of responses less than that value.

C

CAI (Computer-assisted Interviewing) - A method of interviewing in which a computer is used as the data collection instrument.

CAPI (Computer-assisted Personal Interviewing) - A method of interviewing in which field representatives use a laptop computer to collect data during in-person interviews. In SIPP, the field representatives also periodically use the laptop computers during telephone interviews conducted from their homes.

Cold-deck Matrix - The matrix of starting values that constitutes the first step in the hot-deck imputation procedure. The matrix values can be determined from information external to the current file being processed or can be determined from reported information from the current file.

Continuation Flags - Person-level variables that indicate whether spells ending in the last month of the reference period (1) ended in the last month of the reference year, (2) continued into the interview year but ended before the interview month, or (3) was ongoing as of the time of interview.

Core Content - Questions asked at every SIPP interview in the 1984-2008 Panels. These questions cover demographic characteristics, work experience, earnings, program participation, transfer income, and asset income.

Core Wave Files - Files for the 1984-2008 Panels that contain the core data from one wave of interviews.

Coverage Unit - A set of people covered by a health insurance policy or an assistance program. A coverage unit may include one person, a subset of people in the household, or all household members. Coverage units are also known as program units.

Cross-sectional - Pertaining to data collected for a single time period from a representative sample. In SIPP hot-deck imputation procedures, cross-sectional refers to current-wave data.

Current Population Survey (CPS) - A labor force survey sponsored jointly by the Census Bureau and the Bureau of Labor Statistics that is used to compute the government's official monthly unemployment statistics along with other estimates of labor force characteristics.

D

Data Dictionary - Contains information about the file structure and the names, locations, and contents of all variables in a microdata file.

Data Editing - The use of related information to replace missing or inconsistent data in the survey.

E

F

Family - Two or more people who are living together and are related by birth, marriage, or adoption.

Following Rules - SIPP rules that guide which original sample members continue to be interviewed should they move.

Full Panel Files - Files containing all data for every person who was a member of a SIPP panel at any time during the life of that panel.

G

General Income - Any type of income except earnings and asset income.

H

Hot-deck Matrix - The matrix used in all but the first stage of hot-deck imputation. As cold-deck values are replaced with information from the current wave, the resulting array of cells constitutes the hot-deck matrix.

Hot-deck Procedure - The statistical method used to impute items missing from the core questionnaire and topical modules. This procedure replaces missing item data in a wave with non-missing values from similar interviewed cases. The imputation method can be a purely cross-sectional procedure of locating donors from the current file on the basis of characteristics reported in this wave, or it can be a longitudinal procedure of locating donors from the prior wave on the basis of characteristics reported at that earlier time for items missing in the current wave.

Household - People living in a housing unit at the time of the interview. SIPP infers households from the interviews conducted at each address.

Household-level Non-interviews - See *Household Nonresponse*.

Household-level Variables - Variables that have the same value across all people in the household for all months of the reference period.

Household Nonresponse - Nonresponse that occurs when the interviewer either cannot locate a household or cannot interview any of its adult members. See Type A, Type B, Type C, and Type D non-interviews.

Household Reference Person - See *Reference Person*.

Household Respondent - The first eligible adult household member interviewed

Housing Unit - Living quarters with its own entrance and cooking facilities

I

Imputation - The most common method for handling missing data in SIPP. Imputation replaces missing values with statistical estimates that are based on the best relevant information available.

Imputation Flag - See *Status Flag*.

In Scope - Being part of the survey universe.

Interview Month - The month during which the interview takes place.

Item Nonresponse - A source of missing data that occurs when a respondent does not answer one or more questions, even though most of the questionnaire is completed.

J

K

L

Logical Imputation - See *Data Editing*.

Longitudinal - Pertaining to data collected at different times over an extended period from a representative sample. In SIPP hot-deck imputation procedures, longitudinal refers to previous-wave data.

M

Merged Households - Households created either when two separate sampling units, each containing original sample members, are merged together, perhaps because of a marriage, or when a household splits into two new households and later the households recombine.

Microdata Access Tool (MDAT) – Census Bureau Microdata Access Tool that allows data users to create custom tabulations and extracts using published microdata. The tool is currently still in Beta status. Users might encounter bugs or incomplete tabulations.

Microdata Files - Data files containing information at the person, family, or household level. For SIPP, they include the core wave files, topical module files, and full panel files.

Missing Item Data - Data that are missing for one or more individual questions or variables, but the observation has sufficient reported information to be classified as interviewed.

Missing Waves - Waves in which a respondent has no data, although data are present for other waves.

Monthly Interview Status Variables - Variables that indicate whether a person was in sample in a particular month, and whether a person was in sample in the interview month. They are known as the PP-MIS variables.

Mover - An original sample person who moves during the life of the panel.

N

National Guard Retirement - An Army National Guard retirement plan provided for employees who have 20 years of service in the National Guard. By age 60, this retirement pension may combine with any additional income or retirement.

National Longitudinal Survey (NLS) - Collects data on current labor force and employment status, work history, and characteristics of the current or last job.

Non-self-representing (NSR) Primary Sampling Units (PSUs) - Smaller PSUs that must be grouped with similar PSUs from the same region in order to form strata for sampling. This level of geography is not available on the public-use files.

Noninstitutional Group Quarters - Noninstitutional living quarters, such as rooming and boarding houses, college dormitories, convents, and monasteries. These do not constitute households and are often treated differently from households.

O

Original Sample Members (OSPs) - All people who were interviewed in the first wave of the panel and any children subsequently born to or adopted by them.

Oversampling - Sampling that involves selecting certain groups or units with higher probabilities than others, resulting in the oversampled group having greater representation than occurs in the population from which it was drawn.

P

P-70 reports - Primary source for published estimates from the SIPP. These reports can be obtained from the SIPP website.

Panel - Refers both to a new sample that is introduced periodically in the SIPP and to the full collection of information for that sample. For example, the 2018 Panel refers to both the sample introduced in 2018 and the 4 waves of interviews conducted with that sample.

Panel Non-respondents - Persons for whom an interview is missing for a wave.

Person-level Non-interviews - This type of non-interview occurs when data are collected for at least one member of a household, but are missing for one or more other sample persons within that household. See *Type Z non-interview*.

Person-level Variables - Variables that have the same value across all months of the reference period for a respondent.

Person-month Files - Microdata files containing a record for each person in a wave, for each month of the reference period the person was in the sample.

Person-month-level Variables - Variables that may vary month-to-month for a respondent.

Person Nonresponse - Nonresponse that occurs when at least one person in the household is interviewed, while at least one other person is not. See *Type Z non-interview*.

Pointer - Variables that are used to link people within a household. An example are parent pointers, which link children to their parent(s). On a child's record, you will find EPNPAR1 and EPNPAR2. These variables which contain the PNUM(s) of any parents living in the household.

Primary Family - Family containing the household reference person and related individuals.

Primary Individual - A household reference person who lives alone or lives with only nonrelatives.

Primary Sample Members - See *Original Sample Members*.

Primary Sampling Units (PSUs) - Geographic units based on Census data and used in developing the SIPP sample. This level of geography is not available on the public-use files.

Program Units - The group of individuals which constitutes one case, as defined by a particular benefit program. In SIPP, program units apply to health insurance and transfer programs and are identified for programs in which a case can consist of more than one person.

Proxy Interviews - Interviews taken on behalf of a sample member who is unable to answer, including those under age 15 at the time of the interview.

Public-Use Microdata Files - Data files that have been prepared by the Census Bureau for public-use. These files have already been processed to impute missing data, to edit data for confidentiality, and to provide weights. Microdata files are available from the SIPP website.

Q

R

Recodes - Variables created from other variables. These variables start with “R.”

Reference Months - The months that constitute the reference period for a wave.

Reference Period - The period of time for which most interview questions are in reference to. For the 2014 Panel through 2020 SIPP, the reference period is the prior calendar year (January to December). For the 1984 to 2008 Panels, the reference period was the four calendar months preceding the month of interview.

Reference Person - An owner or renter of record who is at least 15 years old and who can reasonably be expected to answer questions about the household in general and about other household members should they be unavailable for interview. All people in the household are listed according to their relationship to the reference person in the interview month. If multiple respondents are listed as the owner or renter of record, the reference person is recorded as the first person listed as the owner or renter.

Related Subfamily - A married couple and dependents or parent-child family related to the reference person but not including him or her. An example would be the reference person's daughter and son-in-law. Related subfamilies can only be identified in the interview month, since a reference person is not identified in the monthly data.

Respondent - Someone in the household for whom SIPP collects information

S

Sample Attrition - Loss of sample members. Sample attrition rates decline over time, but total attrition numbers increase.

Seam Effect - The tendency of respondents to report a disproportionate number of changes as occurring at the "seam" between the end one wave and the beginning of another.

Secondary Families - Two or more people living in the same household who are related to each other but not to the household reference person.

Secondary Individual - An individual who is neither a household reference person nor a relative of any other people in the household.

Secondary Sample Members - People living with original sample members.

Self-representing (SR) Primary Sampling Units (PSUs) - Larger PSUs that do not have to be combined with other PSUs in order to form strata for sampling. This level of geography is not available on the public-use files.

Self-response - A respondent who provides information about him/herself.

Sequential Hot-deck Procedure - See *Hot-deck Procedure*.

Source and Accuracy Statement - A statement included with the technical documentation that accompanies public-use files; it contains detailed information about weights on the files, when and how to make adjustments to the weights, and how to use generalized variance procedures to compute standard errors for some common types of estimates. It also includes cautions for users about sources of non-sampling error.

Spell - A period of consecutive months spent in an activity, such as in a job or receiving program benefits.

Spell-level Variables - Variables that have the same value across all months of a spell for a respondent, but values may vary across spells.

Status Flag - A status flag is associated with each item subject to statistical imputation and indicates whether information has been imputed, and if so, the type of procedure used. These variables start with 'A.'

Survey of Program Dynamics (SPD) - An offshoot of SIPP that began re-contacting members of the 1992 and 1993 Panels, with data collection to continue through 2001 in order to collect 10 years of data.

T

Technical Documentation - Information that accompanies microdata files and that includes a description of file contents, a glossary, codes, a data dictionary, a source and accuracy statement, and a copy of the core questions for the panel in question.

Time-in-Sample Effect - Tendency of sample members to "learn" the survey over time, possibly resulting in altered responses.

Topcoding - Practice of recoding continuous variables to protect against the possibility that a user might recognize the identity of a SIPP respondent with an extreme value. Variables exceeding a maximum value are recoded to that maximum value or to a mean of responses in excess of that value.

Topical Content - For the 1984-2008 Panels, questions that are not repeated in every wave. They cover a wide range of topics and can occur once or more than once in a panel. The questions are grouped into modules by topic.

Topical Module Files - For the 1984-2008 Panels, files containing all topical module data from the wave in question.

Topical Modules - For the 1984-2008 Panels, collections of questions asked periodically, but not at every interview, about various topics that might be outside the range of the core content.

Topical Module Imputation Procedure - For the 1984-2008 Panels, missing data in topical modules were imputed using the same hot-deck procedure used to impute missing data in the core questionnaire.

Type A Non-interview - Households that are occupied by people eligible for interview but for which no interview is obtained.

Type B Non-interview - A household non-interview that occurs when the address unit is vacant or in some way unfit for residence.

Type C Non-interview - In Wave 1, a household non-interview that occurs when the housing unit has been demolished or converted to some other use; in subsequent waves, a household non-interview that occurs when all sample members in a household are outside the scope of the survey, for example, deceased, living abroad, living in institutions, or living in armed forces barracks.

Type D Non-interview - Households or people who have moved to an unknown address, or who have moved more than 100 miles from the nearest field representative and for whom no telephone interview is conducted. This type of non-interview applies only to Wave 2 and beyond.

Type Z Imputation - Procedures used in the 1984-2008 Panels to impute missing data for Type Z non-interviews and for situations when a person was in sample early in the wave but not in sample by the month of interview.

Type Z Non-interview - An eligible person in an interviewed household from whom the field representative could not get an interview or for whom the interviewer could not obtain a proxy interview. A non-interview also occurs when a person who was part of the household for a portion of the reference period moves and is no longer a household member on the date of the interview. If the person is an original sample member, an effort will be made to locate and follow the person.

“Type 2” Person - A person who lived with a respondent during the reference year but not at time of interview. A Type-2 person does not get a person record in the public-use microdata, and can have been at any address a respondent lived at during the reference year, not just interview address.

U

Under-coverage - Underrepresentation of demographic subgroups within the surveyed population.

Unrelated Subfamily - A family, that is, a group of two or more related individuals, living at a sample address unit that does not contain the reference person or anyone related to the reference person. Unrelated subfamilies can only be identified in the interview month, since a reference person is not identified in the monthly data.

User Notes - Issued periodically by the Census Bureau, these contain updated information for specific microdata files and are available on the SIPP website.

Usual Place of Residence - Place where a person normally lives and sleeps; specific living quarters held for the person, to which he or she is free to return at any time.

V

Variable Metadata - Provide a complete characterization of a variable's content. Variable metadata are available on the SIPP website.

W

Wave - One round of interviewing, which takes four months to complete; one fourth of the panel.

Wave Files - See *Core Wave Files*.

Weights - Estimates of the number of units in the target population that a given unit represents.

X

Y

Z

C. Publications in the SIPP P-70 Series

TABLE D-1. PUBLICATIONS IN THE SIPP P-70 SERIES

Publication Number	Year of Publication	Title
P70-1	1984	Economic Characteristics of Households in the U.S. Third Quarter, 1983
P70-2	1985	Economic Characteristics of Households in the U.S. Fourth Quarter, 1983
P70-3	1985	Economic Characteristics of Households in the U.S. First Quarter, 1984
P70-4	1985	Economic Characteristics of Households in the U.S. Second Quarter, 1984
P70-5	1985	Economic Characteristics of Households in the U.S. Third Quarter, 1984
P70-6	1986	Economic Characteristics of Households in the U.S. Fourth Quarter, 1984
P70-7	1986	Household Wealth and Asset Ownership, 1984
P70-8	1986	Disability, Functional Limitations, and Health Insurance Coverage: 1984-1985
P70-9	1987	Who's Minding the Kids? Child Care Arrangements: Winter 1984-1985
P70-10	1987	Male-Female Differences in Work Experience, Occupation, and Earnings: 1984
P70-11	1987	What's It Worth? Educational Background and Economic Status: Spring, 1984
P70-12	1987	Pensions: Workers Coverage and Retirement Income, 1984
P70-13	1988	Who's Helping Out? Support Network Among American Families
P70-14	1989	Characteristics of Persons Receiving Benefits from Major Assistance Programs
P70-15-RD-1	1989	Transitions in Income and Poverty Status: 1984-1985
P70-16-RD-2	1989	Spells of Job Search and Layoff...and Their Outcomes
P70-17	1990	Health Insurance Coverage, 1986-1988
P70-18	1990	Transitions in Income and Poverty Status: 1985-1986
P70-19	1990	The Need for Personal Assistance with Everyday Activities: Recipients and Caregivers
P70-20	1990	Who's Minding the Kids? Child Care Arrangements: Winter 1986-1987
P70-21	1990	What's It Worth? Educational Background and Economic Status: Spring 1987
P70-22	1990	Household Wealth and Asset Ownership: 1988
P70-23	1991	Family Disruption and Economic Hardship: The Short-Run Picture for Children
P70-24	1991	Transitions in Income and Poverty Status: 1987-1988
P70-25	1991	Pensions: Worker Coverage and Retirement Benefits, 1987
P70-26	1992	Extended Measures of Well-Being: 1984
P70-27	1992	Job Creation During Late 1980's: Dynamic Aspects of Employment Growth
P70-28	1992	Who's Helping Out? Support Network Among American Families: 1988
P70-29	1992	Health Insurance Coverage: 1987-1990
P70-30	1992	Who's Minding the Kids? Child Care Arrangements: Fall 1988
P70-31	1992	Characteristics of Recipients and the Dynamics of Program Participation: 1987-1988

P70-32	1990	What's It Worth? Educational Background and Economic Status: Spring 1990
P70-33	1993	Americans with Disabilities: 1991-1992
P70-34	1994	Household Wealth and Asset Ownership: 1991
P70-35	1994	Monitoring the Economic Health of American Households: Average Monthly Estimates of Income, Labor Force Activity, Program Participation and Health Insurance, First Quarter 1984 to Third Quarter 1991
P70-36	1994	Who's Minding the Kids? Child Care Arrangements: Fall 1991
P70-37	1994	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Health Insurance 1990-1992
P70-38	1994	The Diverse Living Arrangements of Children: Summer 1991
P70-39	1994	Dollars for Scholars: Postsecondary Costs and Financing 1990-1991
P70-40	1994	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Labor Force and Income: 1990-1992
P70-41	1995	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Program Participation: 1990-1992
P70-42	1995	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Poverty: 1990-1992
P70-43	1995	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Health Insurance: 1991-1993
P70-44	1995	The Effect of Health Insurance Coverage on Doctor and Hospital Visits: 1990-1992
P70-45	1995	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Poverty: 1991-1993
P70-46	1995	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Program Participation: 1991-1993
P70-47	1995	Asset Ownership of Households: 1993
P70-48	1995	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Labor Force: 1991-1993
P70-49	1995	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Income: 1991-1992
P70-50	1995	Beyond Poverty Extended Measures of Well-Being: 1992
P70-51	1995	What's It Worth? Field of Training and Economic Status: 1993
P70-52	1995	What Does it Cost to Mind Our Preschoolers?
P70-53	1996	Who's Minding Our Preschoolers?
P70-54	1996	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Health Insurance 1992-1993 Who Loses Coverage and for How Long?
P70-55	1996	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Poverty: 1992-1993 Who Stays Poor? Who Doesn't?
P70-56	1996	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Income 1992-1993 Moving Up and Down the Income Ladder
P70-57	1996	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Labor Force 1992-1993 - A Perspective on Low-Wage Workers
P70-58	1996	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Program Participation 1992-1993 Who Gets Assistance?
P70-59	1997	My Daddy Takes Care of Me! Fathers as Care Providers
P70-60	1999	Financing the Future: Postsecondary Students, Costs, and Financial Aid
P70-61	1997	Americans with Disabilities: 1994-95
P70-62	1997	Who's Minding Our Preschoolers? Fall 1994 Update
P70-63	1998	Dynamics of Economic Well Being: Poverty 1993-94

P70-64	1998	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Health Insurance 1993-1995 Who loses Coverage and For How Long?
P70-65	1998	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Income 1993-1994 Moving Up and Down the Income Ladder
P70-66	1998	Seasonality of Moves and Duration of Residence
P70-67	1999	Extended Measures of Well-Being: Meeting Basic Needs 1995
P70-68	2001	A Child's Day: Home, School, and Play (Selected Indicators of Child Well-Being) 1994
P70-69	1999	Dynamics of Economic Well-Being: Program Participation 1993-1994 Who Gets Assistance?
P70-70	2000	Who's Minding the Kids? Child Care Arrangements Fall 1995
P70-71	2001	Household Net Worth and Asset Ownership 1995
P70-72	2001	What's it Worth? Field of Training Economic Status, 1996
P70-73	2001	Americans With Disabilities: 1997
P70-74	2001	Living Arrangements of Children 1996
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